OnBuch+

SIGNED COURSE • PREMIUM

ENGLISH LANGUAGE • UPPER SIXTH | UPPER SIXTH — ENGLISH LANGUAGE

## CHAPTER 2

# MODULE THREE: THE LEARNER SEEKS AND OBTAINS ADMISSION INTO, AND COPES IN, DIFFERENT ACADEMIC PROGRAMMES : REVIEW

**SUGGESTED TIME: 27 PERIODS**

**IN THIS CHAPTER**

This review chapter consolidates the entire Upper Sixth English Language programme through advanced literary analysis, phonology, grammar, and examination-focused writing practice. It prepares candidates for Papers 1, 2 and 3 of the GCE Advanced Level through mock examinations, comparative text study, and mastery of the writer's craft.

- By the end of this chapter I can analyse and compare themes, styles, and techniques across prose, drama, and poetry passages.
- By the end of this chapter I can critically analyse prescribed poems such as 'If', 'Corruption', and 'I Am An African', identifying moral themes and poetic devices.
- By the end of this chapter I can recognise and produce weak forms, rhythm, ellipsis, and substitution in spoken and written English.
- By the end of this chapter I can use advanced modals to express degrees of certainty, obligation, and permission accurately.
- By the end of this chapter I can reconstruct minutes of meetings, debates, talks, and lectures in correct format and register.
- By the end of this chapter I can write discursive essays, news reports, and edited texts with appropriate register, tone, and rhetorical effectiveness.


**DOWNLOAD ONBUCH**
Free • Google Play
AI tutor, past papers, results

**GO ONBUCH+**
All signed courses, unlimited AI tutor, PDF sheets — OnBuch+ tab in the app


THIS SIGNED COURSE CONTAINS

**COURSE** complete, illustrated, step by step

**METHODS** and worked examples

**EXERCISES** exam style + solutions

**SUMMARY SHEET** the essentials to remember

**Signed • OnBuch+**
ONBUCH+ TEACHING TEAM
FOLLOWS THE OFFICIAL MINESEC SYLLABUS

OnBuch+

CONTENTS

1. Consolidating Literary Analysis and Grammar Foundations
2. Comparative Analysis Across Passages and Genres
3. In-Depth Study of Selected Poems I: 'If' and Moral Themes
4. In-Depth Study of Selected Poems II: African Voices
5. Comprehensive Poetry Review: The Cosmic Anthology
6. Phonology in Focus: Connected Speech, Dialects and Accents
7. Advanced Grammar: Modals, Ellipsis and Substitution
8. Reconstructive Writing: Minutes, Debates, Talks and Lectures
9. Advanced Composition: Discursive Essays, News Reports and Register
10. Critical Reasoning, Rhetoric and Visual Stimuli
11. Mock Examinations and Final Examination Techniques
12. Integration activity
13. Methods and worked examples
14. Exercises
15. Solutions to the exercises
16. Summary sheet

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

- By the end of this chapter I can analyse and compare themes, styles, and techniques across prose, drama, and poetry passages.
- By the end of this chapter I can critically analyse prescribed poems such as 'If', 'Corruption', and 'I Am An African', identifying moral themes and poetic devices.
- By the end of this chapter I can recognise and produce weak forms, rhythm, ellipsis, and substitution in spoken and written English.
- By the end of this chapter I can use advanced modals to express degrees of certainty, obligation, and permission accurately.
- By the end of this chapter I can reconstruct minutes of meetings, debates, talks, and lectures in correct format and register.
- By the end of this chapter I can write discursive essays, news reports, and edited texts with appropriate register, tone, and rhetorical effectiveness.
- By the end of this chapter I can evaluate arguments and evidence critically and respond to visual stimuli such as cartoons, advertisements, and graphs.

- By the end of this chapter I can sit full mock examinations for Papers 1, 2, and 3 under timed conditions and apply proven examination techniques.

**PREREQUISITES**

- Literary devices and basic poetry analysis from Lower Sixth (imagery, metaphor, tone, persona)
- Essay writing skills: narrative, descriptive, and argumentative essays from Lower Sixth
- Basic modal verbs and reported speech from earlier forms
- Summary writing and comprehension techniques from Lower Sixth Paper 2 practice
- The prescribed texts and the Cosmic Anthology poems studied during the year

# 1 CONSOLIDATING LITERARY ANALYSIS AND GRAMMAR FOUNDATIONS

It is May in Yaoundé: the GCE Advanced Level papers are printed, sealed, and on their way to examination centres across the country. In a few weeks, you will face three papers that test not just what you know about English, but how you think, compare, argue, and write under pressure. Imagine two candidates with the same knowledge: one has trained systematically on every skill — from weak forms in listening to parallelism in rhetoric — while the other has only reread notes. Who walks out of Paper 3 smiling? This chapter is your final, structured rehearsal for that day.

The problem is this: many Upper Sixth candidates can recognise a metaphor, state the theme of a poem, and write grammatical sentences in calm conditions — yet they lose marks in the examination room because their analysis stays at the level of paraphrase and their grammar collapses under time pressure. This first section rebuilds the two foundations on which everything else in this module rests: a rigorous method of **literary analysis**, and the **grammar accuracy** that examiners reward.

## 1.1 The Analytical Framework: Six Windows into a Text

**DEFINITION** **Literary Analysis**

**Literary analysis** is the systematic examination of how a writer uses language, form, and structure to create meaning and produce effects on the reader. It answers not the question "What does the text say?" but the question "How does the text say it, and why does that matter?"

Every passage, poem, or play you will meet in Papers 1, 2, and 3 can be approached through six interlocking windows. Master them as a checklist, and no unseen text will ever feel strange.

1. **Theme** — the central idea or concern the text explores (corruption, love, identity, power, death). A theme is a subject plus a judgement: not "war" but "war dehumanises both victor and victim".
2. **Character** — who acts and suffers in the text, revealed through speech, action, description, and the reactions of others.
3. **Setting** — the time and place of the action, including social atmosphere. A Lagos market at dawn and a mission school at dusk create different meanings even for identical events.
4. **Plot** — the arrangement of events: exposition, complication, climax, resolution. Ask why the writer ordered events this way.
5. **Point of view** — who tells the story (first person "I", omniscient third person, limited third person) and how that choice filters what we know and feel.
6. **Style** — the writer's characteristic use of language: diction, imagery, sentence rhythm, tone, and figurative devices.

**WARNING** **The Cardinal Sin of GCE Literary Essays**

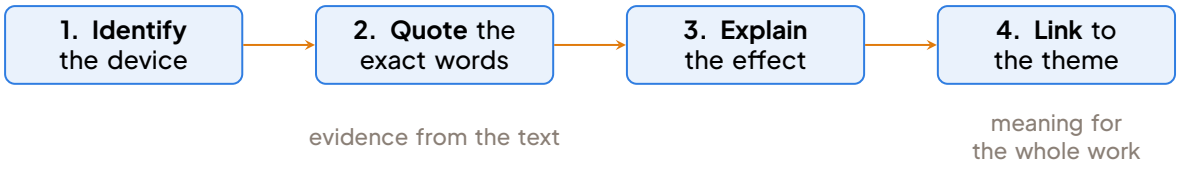
The single most common reason candidates score below average on literature questions is that they describe what a text says instead of analysing how it says it. Retelling the plot of a poem or summarising a passage earns almost no credit. Every paragraph of a good answer must move from observation (the device, the word choice, the structure) to effect (what it does to the reader) to meaning (how it builds the theme). If a sentence in your essay could have been written by someone who never read the text closely, delete it.

## 1.2 Identifying and Commenting on Literary Devices

Examiners do not reward the mere naming of devices. Writing "The poet uses metaphor" and stopping there is like a doctor saying "The patient has a disease" and going home. The full analytical move has four steps.

**METHOD** **The Four-Step Comment on a Device**

1. Name it. Identify the device precisely: metaphor, simile, personification, irony, alliteration, hyperbole, enjambment, contrast.
2. Quote it. Cite the exact words, in quotation marks, kept short.
3. Explain its effect. Say what the device does: what picture, feeling, emphasis, or tension it creates.
4. Connect it to the theme. Show how this local effect contributes to the text's larger meaning.




The literary analysis process: from device to theme.

**EXEMPLE** **Applying the Four Steps**

Consider the line: "The courtroom swallowed his last hope."

- Weak answer: "The writer uses personification here." (Naming only: 1 of 4 steps.)

- Strong answer: "The writer personifies the courtroom as a predator that 'swallows' the accused's hope. The verb suggests something alive, greedy, and irreversible — hope is not lost but devoured. This image reinforces the theme of an unjust system that consumes the powerless."

Notice how the strong answer moves through all four steps in three sentences. That is the rhythm of every good analytical paragraph.

## 1.3 Grammar Review I: Concord and Tense Consistency

Grammar is not decoration; it is the machinery that carries your ideas to the examiner. Two areas cause the most damage in GCE scripts.

**DEFINITION** **Concord**

**Concord** (or agreement) is the grammatical rule by which related words in a sentence match one another: a subject and its verb must agree in number and person (She writes / They write), and a pronoun must agree with its antecedent in number and gender (Each student brought his or her script).

The traps examiners know you will fall into:

- **Intervening phrases.** The quality of the essays **was** (not were) impressive. The head noun is quality, singular; the plural noun before the verb is a decoy.
- **Indefinite pronouns.** Everyone, somebody, each, neither, either take singular verbs: Neither of the boys **has** paid.
- **Collective nouns.** The committee **has** decided (acting as one body) but The committee **have** quarrelled among themselves (acting as individuals).
- **Inverted order.** There **were** three candidates absent. The true subject follows the verb.

**Tense consistency.** Within a piece of writing, choose a time frame and defend it. Narratives normally run in the past; literary analysis conventionally uses the present (Achebe portrays Okonkwo as a man who **fears** weakness); reports of past events stay in the past. The classic error is drifting: "The candidate enters the hall, sat down, and is opening her paper." Pick one tense and hold it unless the meaning genuinely shifts in time.

## 1.4 Grammar Review II: Sentence Types and the Ten Deadly Errors

A sentence is **simple** (one clause), **compound** (two independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction or semicolon), **complex** (an independent clause plus at least one subordinate clause), or **compound-complex**. Deliberate variety of sentence type is a mark of mature writing; accidental fragments and run-ons are a mark of carelessness.

The table below lists the ten error patterns that GCE examiners report most frequently, with corrections. Study it until the correct forms are automatic.

| N | Frequent error | Correction |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | The informations were false. | The information was false. (uncountable noun) |
| 2 | He is more taller than me. | He is taller than I (am). (double comparative) |
| 3 | Neither of them have come. | Neither of them has come. (concord) |
| 4 | Being late, the bell rang before him. | Being late, he arrived after the bell. (dangling modifier) |
| 5 | She don't know the answer. | She doesn't know the answer. (third person) |
| 6 | I have seen him yesterday. | I saw him yesterday. (simple past with finished time) |
| 7 | The reason is because he lied. | The reason is that he lied. (redundancy) |
| 8 | He is a man whom I know is honest. | He is a man who I know is honest. (case of pronoun) |
| 9 | Between you and I, he is wrong. | Between you and me, he is wrong. (object after preposition) |
| 10 | The students was writing when I entered. | The students were writing when I entered. (concord) |

## 1.5 Punctuation for Effect: Dashes, Semicolons, Colons

Advanced writers use punctuation not merely to avoid error but to conduct the reader's attention.

- The **dash** (—) creates a dramatic pause, an afterthought, or a sharp interruption: "He had one ambition left — revenge." Use it sparingly; two dashes can also enclose a parenthesis with more force than commas.
- The **semicolon** (;) joins two closely related independent clauses, suggesting that the second completes or balances the first: "Power corrupts; absolute power corrupts absolutely." It also separates items in a list that already contains commas.
- The **colon** (:) announces: it tells the reader that an explanation, a list, or a quotation follows: "The poem rests on one conviction: integrity outlasts wealth."

**WARNING** **Semicolon Traps**

Never use a semicolon before a coordinating conjunction (and, but, so) or to introduce a list — that is the colon's job. And never capitalise the word after a semicolon unless it is a proper noun.

## 1.6 Sentence Transformation and Synthesis in GCE Format

Paper 2 regularly asks you to rewrite a sentence beginning with a given word, preserving the

meaning, or to combine several sentences into one. The skill tested is control of structure: passivisation, nominalisation, inversion, and subordination.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 1** **Transformation and Synthesis Practice**

(a) Rewrite, beginning with the words given, without changing the meaning: "Although the rain was heavy, the candidates arrived on time." Begin: Heavy though…

(b) Combine into one sentence: "The minister arrived late. He did not apologise. The audience was annoyed."

**SOLUTION**

(a) Heavy though the rain was, the candidates arrived on time. The concessive conjunction although is replaced by the inverted structure adjective + though + subject + verb; the meaning is preserved exactly.

(b) Several correct syntheses exist. Model: "The minister arrived late and did not apologise, which annoyed the audience." Here the first two sentences are coordinated (shared subject), and the third becomes a non-defining relative clause with which referring to the whole preceding idea. Alternative: "The audience was annoyed because the minister, arriving late, offered no apology." — this version subordinates the cause and nominalises did not apologise into offered no apology. Both earn full credit; what matters is that no idea is lost and no comma splice is created.

## 1.7 Linking Grammar Accuracy to Marks

How do examiners actually penalise errors? Under the GCE marking philosophy, composition and language answers are assessed on both **content** and **expression**. A script with occasional slips in an otherwise controlled, ambitious style is treated leniently; a script with recurrent errors — the same concord mistake in every paragraph, tense chaos throughout — signals that the candidate has not mastered the language, and the expression mark falls band by band. Worse, persistent error obscures content: an examiner who must decode your sentences cannot reward your ideas. The practical lesson: it is more profitable to write slightly simpler sentences accurately than ambitious sentences inaccurately, and then to raise ambition gradually as control grows.

**KEY POINTS** **Key Points of This Section**

- Literary analysis examines how a text means, not merely what it says.
- Use the six windows: theme, character, setting, plot, point of view, style.
- Comment on every device in four steps: name it, quote it, explain the effect, link to the theme.
- Concord and tense consistency are the highest-frequency grammar traps; master

the ten-error table.

- Dashes, semicolons, and colons are instruments of emphasis, not ornaments.
- In transformations, preserve meaning exactly; in synthesis, lose no idea and create no run-on.
- Recurrent errors cost more marks than isolated slips: accuracy is a scoring strategy.

**EXERCISE 1** **Consolidation Tasks**

1. Read this sentence from an unseen passage: "The old chief's words fell on the assembly like stones into still water." Write a four-step analytical comment (name, quote, effect, theme).
2. Correct the errors: "The news were so shocking that everybody in the crowd were silent."
3. Punctuate for effect: "he had one dream left to see his daughter graduate"
4. Rewrite beginning with the words given: "The boy was so tired that he could not continue the journey." Begin: So tired…
5. Combine into one sentence: "The rains failed. The crops withered. The village faced famine."

**SOLUTION** **Exercise: Consolidation Tasks**

1. Model: The writer uses a simile, comparing the chief's words to "stones … into still water". The image suggests weight, suddenness, and rippling disturbance: the words shatter a calm gathering and their impact spreads outward through everyone present. This reinforces the theme of authority — a single respected voice can transform an entire community.
2. "The news was so shocking that everybody in the crowd was silent." (News is uncountable and singular; everybody takes a singular verb.)
3. "He had one dream left — to see his daughter graduate." (A colon is also acceptable.)
4. "So tired was the boy that he could not continue the journey." (Inversion after initial so + adjective.)
5. Model: "Because the rains failed, the crops withered and the village faced famine." — or, more elegantly: "The failure of the rains withered the crops and brought famine

upon the village."

## 2 COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS ACROSS PASSAGES AND GENRES

In the previous section, we consolidated the foundations of literary analysis and grammar. You learned to isolate a single text, to dissect its language, structure, and themes, and to write about it with precision. But the GCE Advanced Level examination — and indeed, advanced literary study — rarely asks you to look at a text in isolation. Paper 1 often presents two unseen passages side by side. Paper 2 invites you to connect themes across the prescribed novels, plays, and poems. The real world of criticism demands that you see literature as a conversation across time, culture, and genre. This section equips you with the rigorous tools to move from analysis to comparative analysis: the art of placing texts in dialogue, of weighing similarities against differences, and of articulating why the comparison itself matters. This directly addresses **Lesson 44** of the official syllabus: Comparative Analysis – Comparing Themes and Styles Across Passages.

### 2.1 Principles of Comparison: Similarities, Differences, and Significance

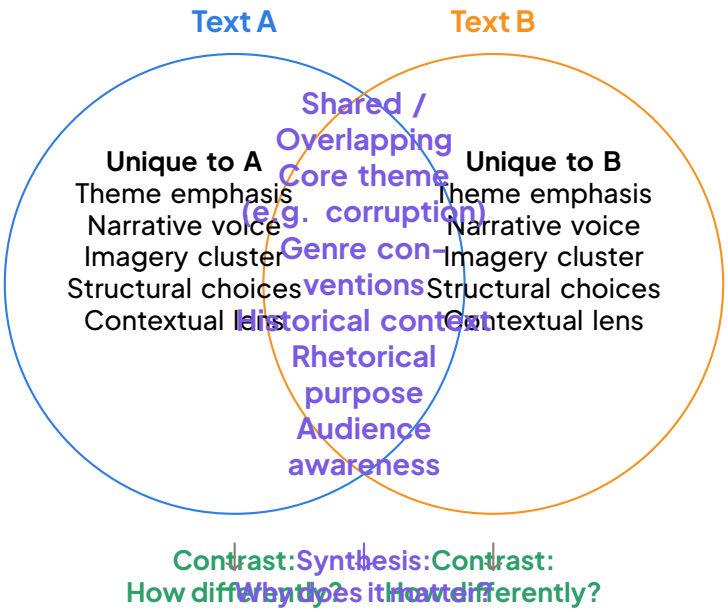
DEFINITION **Comparative Analysis**

A structured examination of two or more texts to highlight meaningful similarities and differences in theme, style, structure, or perspective, leading to an evaluative judgement about their significance.

Comparison is not a game of "spot the difference." A list of resemblances ("Both texts use metaphors") or contrasts ("Text A is in first person; Text B is in third") earns little credit. The examiner asks: So what? What does the similarity reveal about a shared human concern? What does the difference tell us about the author's purpose, the genre's constraints, or the historical moment?

PROPERTY **The Significance Principle**

A strong comparison always answers "so what?" – the significance of the similarity or difference. A similarity is analytically valuable only if it illuminates a shared technique used to different ends, or a universal theme treated distinctively. A difference is valuable only if it exposes a deliberate generic, cultural, or ideological choice.




Venn diagram template for comparing two texts. Use the intersection for shared ground; the outer zones for distinctive features. The analytical payoff lies in the synthesis: explaining the significance of both overlap and divergence.

**EXEMPLE** **Applying the Venn Diagram: Two Opening Paragraphs**

Text A (Novel, 1958): "Okonkwo was well known throughout the nine villages and even beyond. His fame rested on solid personal achievements. As a young man of eighteen he had brought honour to his village by throwing Amalinze the Cat." – Chinua Achebe, Things Fall Apart

Text B (Play, 1984): "PRAISE SINGER: The world is not a marketplace where you buy and sell honour. The world is a battlefield where honour is won with blood." – Wole Soyinka, Death and the King's Horseman

| Aspect | Text A (Prose) | Text B (Drama) |
|---|---|---|
| Theme: Honour/Reputation | Earned through physical feat (wrestling); communal recognition | Abstract, philosophical; won through sacrifice |
| Voice | Third-person omniscient narrator; authoritative, communal | Praise Singer; choric, poetic, performative |
| Imagery | Concrete: "nine villages," "Cat" (metaphor) | Abstract: "marketplace," "battlefield," "blood" |
| Structure | Linear exposition; establishes protagonist | Choral opening; establishes cosmic/moral framework |
| Significance (So what?) | Achebe grounds honour in Igbo social reality; Soyinka elevates it to a metaphysical principle. Both write back to colonial erasure, but Achebe reconstructs the social fabric, while Soyinka invokes the sacred. | |

## 2.2 Comparing Themes Across Two Prose Passages: Structuring the Response

When comparing two prose passages – a staple of Paper 1 – you have two structural options. The **parallel (block) method** treats Text A fully, then Text B, then compares. The **alternating (point-by-point) method** compares within each thematic point. The latter is almost always superior for examination writing because it forces integration and avoids the "two mini-essays" trap.

METHOD **Alternating Comparative Essay Structure**

1. Introduction: Identify both texts (author, title, date, genre if known). State the shared theme or focus. Offer a thesis that predicts a significant similarity and a significant difference.
2. Body Paragraph 1 (Point 1): Topic sentence naming the first sub-theme/technique. Evidence from Text A. Evidence from Text B. Direct comparison using connectives. Link back to thesis.
3. Body Paragraph 2 (Point 2): Same structure, new sub-theme/technique.

4. Body Paragraph 3 (Point 3): Same structure. Consider genre/context here if relevant.
5. Conclusion: Synthesise. Restate thesis in light of evidence. Offer a final evaluative judgement: which text achieves its purpose more powerfully? What does the comparison reveal about the theme itself?

**WARNING** **The "Two Mini-Essays" Trap**

Writing a paragraph on Text A's theme, then a paragraph on Text B's theme, then a final paragraph saying "Both texts show..." is not comparative analysis. It is sequential summary. The examiner cannot see the comparison happening. Always alternate: make a point, illustrate from A, illustrate from B, compare, link. Every body paragraph must contain both texts.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 2** **GCE-Style Paired Passage Question**

Question: Read the two passages below. Both concern a young person leaving home for the city. Compare and contrast how the writers present the experience of departure and the emotions involved.

Passage 1 (from a novel, 1960s Cameroon): "Njock stood at the motor park, his wooden box tied with raffia rope at his feet. The lorry to Douala coughed and shuddered, a metal beast impatient to devour the road. His mother's wrapper was damp where she had wiped her eyes. 'Go, my son,' she whispered, 'and become a man who builds.' He did not look back until the dust swallowed the village square."

Passage 2 (from a memoir, 1990s Nigeria): "I watched the Lagos traffic from the third-floor window, the yellow molue buses like beetles crawling through honey. My father had paid the fare, counted the naira notes with fingers that trembled slightly. 'The city eats the unprepared,' he said. I touched the letter in my pocket – university admission – and wondered if the boy who left the village still existed."

Model Response (Alternating Structure):

Introduction: Both passages depict the pivotal moment of rural-to-urban migration, a defining experience in postcolonial African literature. Passage 1, a third-person narrative, frames departure as a communal rite of passage; Passage 2, a first-person memoir, frames it as an anxious, individual negotiation with identity. While both use the city as a symbol of transformation, Passage 1 emphasises collective hope, whereas Passage 2 exposes private fear.

Point 1: The Physical Setting as Symbol. Passage 1's "motor park" and "lorry" are visceral, communal spaces – "dust," "raffia rope," "cough and shudder" – grounding departure in material reality. Passage 2's "third-floor window" and "molue buses like beetles" create distance; the narrator observes rather than participates. The simile "like beetles crawling through honey" suggests entrapment and sluggishness, contrasting with Passage 1's

"metal beast impatient to devour," which implies violent energy. Comparison: Both use vehicle imagery, but Passage 1's beast carries the protagonist forward; Passage 2's beetles trap the city in stasis.
Point 2: Parental Figures and the Burden of Expectation. In Passage 1, the mother's "damp wrapper" and command "become a man who builds" externalise the burden: Njock carries the village's future. In Passage 2, the father's "fingers that trembled" and warning "The city eats the unprepared" internalise it: the narrator carries his own fragility. Comparison: Both parents invest the journey with moral weight, but Passage 1's mother speaks for tradition ("build"), while Passage 2's father speaks for survival ("unprepared").
Point 3: Narrative Perspective and Interiority. Passage 1 denies us Njock's thoughts – "He did not look back" is an external observation. Passage 2 grants full interiority: "I wondered if the boy who left the village still existed." Comparison: The third-person choice in Passage 1 universalises Njock as an archetype of the "nation-builder"; the first-person in Passage 2 particularises the migrant as a fractured self.
Conclusion: Passage 1 mythologises departure as heroic nation-building; Passage 2 demythologises it as psychological rupture. Together, they map the evolution of the African migrant narrative from collective optimism (1960s) to individual alienation (1990s).

## 2.3 Comparing Style: Diction, Imagery, Tone, and Narrative Technique Side by Side

Style comparison requires a shared metalanguage. You must name the feature (diction, syntax, imagery, tone, narrative technique), illustrate it from each text, and explain the effect of the similarity or difference.

KEY POINTS **Checklist for Style Comparison**

- Diction: Register (formal/colloquial), semantic fields (war, nature, commerce), abstract vs concrete, archaisms vs neologisms.
- Imagery: Metaphor, simile, personification, symbol clusters. Are images organic or mechanical? Sensory or intellectual?
- Tone: Ironic, elegiac, urgent, detached, satirical, reverent. How is tone created (diction, syntax, punctuation)?
- Narrative Technique: Point of view, focalisation, time manipulation (flashback, foreshadowing), reliability, distance.
- Syntax: Sentence length, periodic vs loose, parallelism, fragmentation, interrogatives.

**EXEMPLE** **Style Comparison: Two Descriptions of a Market**

Text A (Prose, descriptive): "The market breathed. Stalls exhaled spices – cumin, dried crayfish, country onion – and inhaled the sweat of a thousand bargains. Women's voices rose and fell like the talking drums of old, each price a rhythm, each purchase a resolution."
Text B (News report, objective): "Buea Central Market recorded a 15% increase in footfall yesterday. Traders reported brisk sales of foodstuffs, particularly dried fish and plantains. The Divisional Officer urged compliance with new hygiene regulations."

| Feature | Text A (Literary) | Text B (Journalistic) |
|---|---|---|
| Diction | Sensory, poetic: "breathed," "exhaled," "rhythm" | Factual, administrative: "footfall," "compliance," "regulations" |
| Imagery | Extended personification (market as body); simile (voices/drums) | None. Literal, denotative language only. |
| Tone | Reverent, celebratory, cultural | Neutral, informational, bureaucratic |
| Syntax | Periodic, balanced, rhythmic clauses | Short, declarative, subject-verb-object |
| Significance | Text A constructs the market as a living cultural heart; Text B constructs it as an economic statistic. The comparison reveals how genre dictates what is seen and valued. | |

## 2.4 Comparative Literary Analysis Across Prose, Drama, and Poetry: What Changes with Genre

The GCE syllabus requires you to compare themes across the three major genres. The theme (e.g., corruption, power, identity, tradition vs modernity) remains constant, but the means of realisation shift radically. Understanding genre-specific affordances is the key to high-level comparison. This prepares you for **Lesson 53: Comparative Literary Analysis – Themes Across Prose, Drama, and Poetry**.

| Analytical Focus | Prose (Novel/Short Story) | Drama (Play) | Poetry |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Primary Medium** | Narrative discourse (narrator + characters) | Performance text (dialogue + stagecraft) | Verbal music (line, stanza, voice) |
| **Time** | Flexible: summary, scene, flashback, stretch | Real-time (mostly); past revealed through dialogue | Condensed; vertical (moment) or horizontal (sequence) |
| **Consciousness** | Direct access (stream of thought, free indirect style) | Externalised: soliloquy, aside, subtext | Concentrated: speaker's mind as lyric space |
| **Setting** | Described; can be panoramic or intimate | Staged: limited, symbolic, dependent on production | Evoked: imagery creates "place" in the mind |
| **Character** | Developed over time; interiority + action | Revealed through speech/action; actor-dependent | Persona/speaker; often archetypal or fragmented |
| **Theme Delivery** | Through plot arc, character arc, narrator comment | Through conflict, dialogue, irony, spectacle | Through image, metaphor, sound, form |
| **Key Question for Comparison** | How does narrative time shape the theme? | How does performance (silence, gesture, audience) shape the theme? | How does form (line break, rhyme, metre) enact the theme? |

Comparison table: Prose vs Drama vs Poetry – typical features and analytical focus. When comparing across genres, ask the genre-specific key question.

EXEMPLE **Theme: Corruption – Across Three Genres**

Prose (Achebe, A Man of the People): Chief Nanga's corruption is shown through narrative irony – the gap between his public rhetoric ("We are the enemies of corruption") and

private action (bribes, seduction). The novel's length allows us to see the systemic rot: police, civil service, voters all complicit.
Drama (Soyinka, The Trials of Brother Jero): Brother Jero's corruption is performative. He acts the prophet on stage; the audience sees the gap between his asides ("I am a prophet by trade") and his public sermons. Comedy and dramatic irony expose him. The stage makes corruption visible and audible.
Poetry (Birago Diop, "Corruption" / "Power of Corruption" in Cosmic Anthology): Corruption is condensed into image and sound. "The vulture / Perches on the skull / Of the nation" – metaphor fuses predator and carrion. Rhythm mimics the heartbeat of decay. The line break forces a pause: "The vulture / Perches" – the nation holds its breath.
Comparative Thesis: Prose maps the anatomy of corruption (how it works); Drama stages the theatre of corruption (how it performs); Poetry distills the essence of corruption (what it feels like).

## 2.5 Comparative Connectives and the Point–Evidence–Comparison–Link Model

Fluid comparison requires a repertoire of connectives that do more than signal "same" or "different." They must encode the nature of the relationship.

| Function | Connectives (use variety) |
|---|---|
| **Similarity** | similarly, likewise, equally, in the same way, both texts..., just as... so too..., mirroring..., paralleling... |
| **Difference (Contrast)** | whereas, while, conversely, in contrast, on the other hand, unlike Text A, Text B..., Text A...; Text B, however,... |
| **Qualified Similarity** | both texts explore X, but Text A... while Text B...; although both use metaphor, Text A's is... whereas Text B's... |
| **Development/Escalation** | moreover, furthermore, more significantly, this is amplified in Text B where..., Text B extends this by... |
| **Significance (So what?)** | this reveals..., this suggests..., crucially..., the effect is to..., thereby highlighting..., ultimately... |

METHOD **The PECL Paragraph Model (Point–Evidence–Comparison–Link)**

1. Point: A clear topic sentence naming the specific technique or sub-theme you are comparing.
2. Evidence A: Precise quotation or close reference from Text A. Embed it.
3. Evidence B: Precise quotation or close reference from Text B. Embed it.
4. Comparison: Explicit comparative sentence using a connective. Explain how they are similar/different in technique or effect.

5. Link: Connect back to the thesis/question. Answer "so what?" for this point.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 3** **PECL in Action: Comparing Tone in Two Poems on African Identity**

Poem A (Excerpt): "I am an African / Not because I was born here / But because my heart beats / In rhythm with the land." (Wayne Visser, "I Am An African")
Poem B (Excerpt): "They came with Bibles / And took our land / They left with the land / And left us the Bible." (Anonymous protest poem, Southern Africa)
PECL Paragraph: Point: Both poets define African identity through a declarative first-person voice, but the tone diverges from affirmation to accusation. Evidence A: Visser's speaker claims identity through voluntary belonging: "my heart beats / In rhythm with the land." The metaphor of the heartbeat suggests organic, living connection. Evidence B: The protest poet defines identity through historical trauma: "They came with Bibles / And took our land." The parallel structure (came/took, left/left) creates a tone of bitter irony. Comparison: Whereas Visser uses lyrical metaphor to construct a positive, chosen identity, the protest poet uses historical parallelism to construct identity as resistance. Visser's tone is inclusive ("my heart"); the protest poet's tone is adversarial ("They" vs "us"). Link: This contrast reflects two strands of postcolonial consciousness: the re-claiming of self (Visser) and the indictment of the other (protest poem). Both are nec-essary to the full picture.

## 2.6 GCE Practice: Paired-Passage Questions from Past Papers

Paper 1 (Comprehension and Summary) frequently sets two passages (A and B) on a related theme. The questions test:

- **Direct comparison:** "Compare how the two writers present..." (6–8 marks)
- **Inference across texts:** "What do both passages suggest about...?" (3–4 marks)
- **Style comparison:** "How does the language of Passage A differ from Passage B in convey-ing...?" (4–5 marks)

**METHOD** **Tackling the Paired-Passage Comparison Question**

1. Read actively: Annotate both passages for the question's focus (theme, attitude, style). Use two colours: one for Text A, one for Text B.
2. Plan in a table: Draw a quick 3-column table: Point | Text A Evidence | Text B Evidence. Fill 3–4 rows.
3. Write alternating paragraphs: One paragraph per row. Use PECL.

4. Check connectives: Have you used whereas, similarly, conversely, more significantly?
5. End with synthesis: A final sentence that weighs the comparison.

**EXERCISE 2** **Timed Practice: 20 Minutes**

Passage A: A speech by a Cameroonian minister at a youth rally, 2023. Formal register, rhetorical devices (anaphora, tripling), future-oriented, collective pronouns ("we," "our nation"). Theme: patriotism and development.
Passage B: A satirical cartoon caption + short dialogue from a newspaper, 2023. Informal register, Pidgin English elements, irony, present-focused, individual voices. Theme: youth unemployment and political promises.
Question: Compare how the two texts present the relationship between political leaders and young people. (8 marks)
Instructions: Annotate. Plan a 3-point table. Write two full PECL paragraphs. Time yourself.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise: Paired-Passage Practice**

Point 1: Register and Authority. Passage A uses high formal register ("It is incumbent upon…", "The government remains committed…") to project authority and legitimacy. Passage B uses Pidgin ("Man no fit chop promise") and colloquialism to undermine authority through ridicule. Comparison: Whereas Passage A's register constructs the leader's power, Passage B's register deconstructs it. Link: Language itself becomes the site of the power struggle.
Point 2: Time Orientation. Passage A is future-oriented: "will build," "shall achieve," "vision 2035." Passage B is present-oriented: "We dey suffer now," "Where the money?" Comparison: The minister displaces accountability into the future; the cartoon demands it now. Link: This temporal clash exposes the credibility gap.
Point 3: Collective vs Individual Voice. Passage A: "We Cameroonians," "Our shared destiny." Passage B: "Me, I no get job," "My brother for Douala." Comparison: Passage A erases difference through collective myth; Passage B insists on individual lived reality. Link: The comparison reveals two incompatible discourses of citizenship.

## 2.7 Summary: Key Principles for Comparative Excellence

**KEY POINTS** **Comparative Analysis: The Golden Rules**

- Integrate, don't segregate. Alternate texts within paragraphs (PECL). Never write two separate analyses.
- Name the technique. "Both use metaphor" is weak. "Both use extended metaphor, but Text A's is organic (growth) while Text B's is mechanical (machinery)" is strong.
- Answer "so what?" every time. The comparison must yield an insight about theme, genre, context, or authorial purpose.
- Use comparative connectives precisely. Whereas for contrast, similarly for resemblance, more significantly for weighting.
- Respect genre. A play's soliloquy is not a novel's stream of consciousness. A poem's line break is not a prose paragraph break. Compare how the genre shapes the theme.
- Contextualise when relevant. Date, culture, audience, literary movement – these explain why the similarities/differences exist.

DID YOU KNOW? **Comparative Criticism in Cameroon**

The Cameroonian literary tradition itself is a comparative laboratory. Anglophone writers (Achebe, Soyinka, Beti, Oyono, Nsah Mala, Fonchingong) and Francophone writers (Beti, Oyono, Mongo Beti, Werewere Liking) often treat the same historical events – colonialism, the UPC rebellion, the Ahidjo/Biya eras – through different linguistic and generic lenses. Comparing The Poor Christ of Bomba (Mongo Beti, novel, French) with The Old Man and the Medal (Ferdinand Oyono, novel, French) or with Things Fall Apart (Achebe, novel, English) reveals how language and genre mediate the representation of colonial trauma. Your comparative skills allow you to enter this conversation.

You now possess the architecture of comparative analysis: the Venn mindset, the alternating structure, the PECL paragraph, the genre-awareness table, and the connective toolkit. In the next section, we turn to the first of our deep poetic dives: Rudyard Kipling's "If" and the moral architecture of Victorian stoicism – and how African poets answer, resist, or rewrite that legacy. This leads directly into **Lesson 45: Analyzing Selected Poems – e.g. "If" by Rudyard Kipling and Moral Themes**.

## 3 IN-DEPTH STUDY OF SELECTED POEMS I: 'IF' AND MORAL THEMES

In our previous section, we sharpened our comparative lenses, learning to place two passages side by side and trace how different writers shape similar themes through distinct stylistic choices. We now turn from the comparative mode to the intensive mode: a deep, sustained engagement with a single, iconic poem. Rudyard Kipling's If is not merely a set text; it is a cultural touchstone, a poem that has been pinned on dormitory walls, quoted in parliamentary debates, and

recited at graduation ceremonies from Buea to Bamenda. Its power lies in its deceptive simplicity: a single, sprawling conditional sentence that unfolds across four stanzas, each piling condition upon condition until the final, triumphant apodosis — "you'll be a Man, my son!" This section will equip you to dissect its architecture, analyse its moral universe, and write about it with the precision the GCE Advanced Level demands.

## 3.1 Context, Structure, and the Conditional Framework

**EXPERIMENT** **Reading 'If' — First Encounter**

Read the poem below aloud, slowly, letting the rhythm carry you. Do not annotate yet; simply absorb the movement from if to if to the final you'll be a Man.

If — Rudyard Kipling (1910)

If you can keep your head when all about you
Are losing theirs and blaming it on you,
If you can trust yourself when all men doubt you,
But make allowance for their doubting too;
If you can wait and not be tired by waiting,
Or being lied about, don't deal in lies,
Or being hated, don't give way to hating,
And yet don't look too good, nor talk too wise:

If you can dream — and not make dreams your master;
If you can think — and not make thoughts your aim;
If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster
And treat those two impostors just the same;
If you can bear to hear the truth you've spoken
Twisted by knaves to make a trap for fools,
Or watch the things you gave your life to, broken,
And stoop and build 'em up with worn-out tools:

If you can make one heap of all your winnings
And risk it on one turn of pitch-and-toss,
And lose, and start again at your beginnings
And never breathe a word about your loss;
If you can force your heart and nerve and sinew
To serve your turn long after they are gone,
And so hold on when there is nothing in you
Except the Will which says to them: "Hold on!"

If you can talk with crowds and keep your virtue,
Or walk with Kings — nor lose the common touch,
If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you,
If all men count with you, but none too much;
If you can fill the unforgiving minute
With sixty seconds' worth of distance run,

Yours is the Earth and everything that's in it,
And — which is more — you'll be a Man, my son!

**DEFINITION** **Didactic Poetry**

Poetry whose primary purpose is to teach a moral, philosophical, or practical lesson. Unlike lyric poetry, which foregrounds personal emotion, or narrative poetry, which tells a story, didactic poetry uses verse as a vehicle for instruction. The didactic poem often adopts an authoritative voice, employs imperative or conditional structures, and aims at the reader's ethical formation. If is a quintessential example: it does not merely describe virtue; it prescribes it.

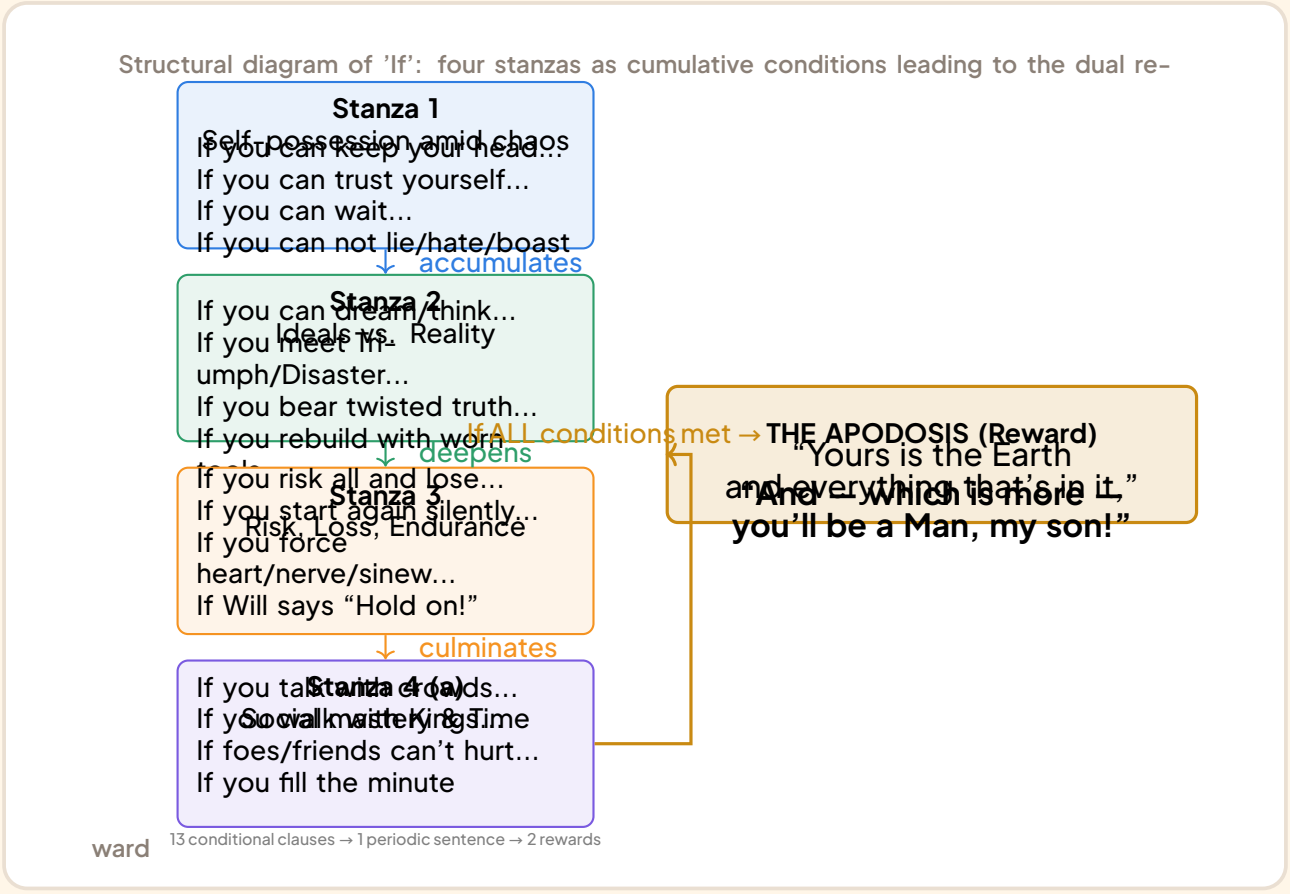
Kipling wrote If in 1895, inspired by the character of Leander Starr Jameson, whose failed raid against the Boers in South Africa exemplified stoic resilience in the face of political betrayal. The poem was first published in Rewards and Fairies (1910), a collection of stories and poems for children. This origin is crucial: the poem is framed as a father's counsel to his son, a rite-of-passage text mapping the journey from boyhood to manhood.

Structurally, the poem is a masterclass in the **periodic sentence** — a sentence whose main clause is withheld until the end. Grammatically, the entire thirty-two-line poem is a single complex sentence composed of a **protasis** (the if-clauses) spanning the first three stanzas and the first half of the fourth, and an **apodosis** (the main clause) in the final four lines:

$$\text{If } (C_1 \wedge C_2 \wedge \ldots \wedge C_{13}), \text{ then } (R_1 \wedge R_2).$$

Where $C_i$ are the conditions (keep your head, trust yourself, wait, dream, think, meet Triumph/Disaster, bear twisted truth, rebuild, risk winnings, force heart/nerve/sinew, talk with crowds, walk with Kings, fill the minute) and $R_1$ = "Yours is the Earth", $R_2$ = "you'll be a Man, my son".

This syntactic architecture enacts the poem's central moral argument: **manhood is not a gift of nature but a conquest of will**. The reward is deferred, conditional, earned. The accumulating ifs create a mounting pressure, a sense of the sheer difficulty of the ideal, making the final release — "Yours is the Earth..." — feel both vast and intimate.




## 3.2 Mapping Virtues: Stanza-by-Stanza Analysis

Each stanza clusters its conditions around a dominant moral virtue. The table below provides a revision-ready map. Notice how Kipling pairs each virtue with a specific rhetorical device that enacts it.

| Stanza | Dominant Virtue | Key Conditions (Paraphrased) | Signature Device |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Composure / Self-possession** | Keep head amid panic; trust self amid doubt; wait without fatigue; resist lies, hatred, smugness | **Antithesis** (losing/blaming vs. keep/trust); **Polysyndeton** (and/Or/And) mimics patient accumulation |
| 2 | **Equanimity / Detachment** | Dream/think without enslavement; treat Triumph & Disaster as impostors; bear twisted truth; rebuild after ruin | **Personification** (Triumph & Disaster as "impostors"); **Metaphor** ("worn-out tools") |
| 3 | **Resilience / Will** | Risk all, lose, restart silently; force heart/nerve/sinew; Will commands "Hold on!" | **Metonymy** (heart, nerve, sinew for whole being); **Personification** (Will as commander); **Imperative** embedded in condition |
| 4a | **Humility / Social dexterity** | Talk with crowds/keep virtue; walk with Kings/keep common touch; immune to foes/friends; value all/none too much | **Antithesis** (crowds/Kings, foes/friends, all/none); **Parallelism** (If you can… / Or walk…) |
| 4b | **Time mastery** | Fill the unforgiving minute with sixty seconds' distance run | **Metaphor** (minute as unforgiving taskmaster; distance run as value); **Paradox** (unforgiving minute) |

## 3.3 Key Devices: Antithesis, Personification, Imperative Address

DEFINITION **Antithesis**

The juxtaposition of contrasting ideas, words, or phrases in a balanced, parallel structure. Antithesis creates tension, highlights duality, and forces the reader to hold two opposites in mind simultaneously. In If, antithesis is the engine of the poem's moral logic: virtue is defined by what it is not and by the opposite it withstands.

EXEMPLE **Antithesis in 'If'**

- "Triumph and Disaster" — personified as twin impostors. The antithesis strips both of

their seductive power: success is not ultimate good, failure not ultimate evil.

- "talk with crowds and keep your virtue / Or walk with Kings — nor lose the common touch" — public acclaim vs. aristocratic privilege; virtue vs. common touch.
- "If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you" — hostility vs. affection; both can wound if one lacks inner fortitude.
- "If all men count with you, but none too much" — democratic equality vs. dangerous dependency.

In each case, the balanced syntax (parallel clauses, correlative conjunctions neither/nor, all/but none) mirrors the moral balance the poem demands.

**DEFINITION** **Personification**

Attributing human qualities, intentions, or agency to non-human entities or abstractions. Kipling personifies Triumph and Disaster as "two impostors", the Will as a commander speaking to "heart and nerve and sinew", and the minute as "unforgiving". This transforms abstract moral tests into dramatic encounters: the subject must meet, treat, force, fill — active verbs against personified adversaries.

The poem's address is **second-person imperative disguised as conditional**. The repeated "If you can..." functions as a hortatory command: Do this. Be this. The persona — a father, a mentor, an idealised masculine voice — speaks with authority earned by experience. The final "my son" collapses the distance between poet and reader: every reader is addressed as the son, the heir to this demanding legacy.

**KEY POINTS** **The Persona–Son Relationship**

- Didactic frame: Father → Son. Authority is personal, not institutional.
- Universalisation: "My son" = every young person (originally male, now read inclusively) facing adulthood.
- Deferred reward: The father does not give the Earth or manhood; he states the conditions under which the son earns them.
- Emotional climax: The dash before "which is more" signals a pause of paternal tenderness — the ultimate reward is not worldly dominion but recognised identity.

## 3.4 Relevance to Contemporary Cameroonian Youth and Leadership

DID YOU KNOW? **Kipling and Cameroon**

Kipling wrote at the height of British imperialism; If has been criticised as a manifesto of colonial stoicism — "the white man's burden" internalised. Yet postcolonial readers across Africa have reclaimed the poem. In Cameroon, where bilingualism, regional tensions, and youth unemployment test daily resilience, If's virtues resonate differently: composure amid political rhetoric, equanimity when promises are broken, resilience when startups fail, humility in leadership, time mastery in a culture where "African time" is often a joke. The poem becomes a mirror: do our leaders treat Triumph and Disaster as impostors? Do they risk all and restart silently? Do they fill the unforgiving minute?

WORKED EXAMPLE 4 **Essay Practice: 'Discuss the moral lessons of If and their relevance today'**

Question: "Discuss the moral lessons of If and their relevance today."

Model Introduction: Rudyard Kipling's If (1910) stands as one of the most enduring didactic poems in the English language. Structured as a single periodic sentence of thirteen conditional clauses, the poem maps a father's blueprint for manhood — not as biological maturity but as moral conquest. Its four stanzas enact a curriculum of virtue: self-possession (stanza 1), equanimity (stanza 2), resilience (stanza 3), and social mastery with time discipline (stanza 4). This essay argues that while the poem's Victorian stoicism and gendered framing invite critique, its core lessons — emotional regulation, detachment from outcomes, perseverance through failure, and humility in power — remain urgently relevant for contemporary Cameroonian youth navigating a landscape of political uncertainty, economic precarity, and social fragmentation.

Model Body Paragraph (Theme → Evidence → Device → Effect → Relevance): Theme: Equanimity in the face of public success and failure. Evidence: "If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster / And treat those two impostors just the same." Device: Personification + Antithesis. Triumph and Disaster are capitalised, personified as "impostors" — deceivers who pretend to be final judgments. Effect: The balanced line forces the reader to hold both extremes equally; the word "impostors" strips them of metaphysical weight, reducing them to passing events. Relevance: In Cameroon's political arena, election victories are treated as eternal mandates, defeats as existential catastrophes. A leader who internalises this lesson would neither grow arrogant in office nor desperate in opposition. For a young entrepreneur in Douala, a rejected grant application (Disaster) and a viral success (Triumph) are both transient — the work continues.

Model Conclusion: If does not offer comfort; it offers a standard. Its final reward — "Yours is the Earth... you'll be a Man, my son" — is conditional, exclusive, and utterly demanding. For today's Cameroonian youth, the poem is not a relic of empire but a challenge: to cultivate a self that neither crowds nor kings can unmake, that rebuilds with worn-out tools, that fills each unforgiving minute. The Earth is not given; it is earned, minute by minute, choice by choice.

METHOD **Writing a Poetry Essay: The T-E-D-E-R Method**

Follow these steps for any poetry essay question:

1. T — Theme: Identify the specific moral lesson or theme (e.g., "resilience through failure").
2. E — Evidence: Quote the exact lines (use ellipsis for length). Embed quotations in your sentence.
3. D — Device: Name the literary device (antithesis, personification, metaphor, imperative, etc.) and explain how it works in these lines.
4. E — Effect: Analyse the effect on the reader: tension, balance, personification makes abstract concrete, etc.
5. R — Relevance: Connect to personal, societal, or contemporary context (Cameroon, youth, leadership, your experience). This is where the top marks live.

Do this for 3–4 distinct themes. Structure: Introduction → 3–4 TEDER paragraphs → Conclusion.

WARNING **Common Mistake: Retelling vs. Analysing**

The Trap: Writing a paragraph that says: "In stanza 1, the poet says if you can keep your head when others lose theirs… In stanza 2, he says if you can dream but not make dreams your master…" This is paraphrase, not analysis. It earns minimal marks (knowledge only).
The Fix: Every paragraph must make an argument about a theme, using the line as evidence. Compare:

- Weak: "Kipling says Triumph and Disaster are impostors."
- Strong: "By personifying Triumph and Disaster as "impostors", Kipling strips both of their authority, teaching that equanimity requires refusing the emotional extremes of both success and failure — a lesson vital for politicians who mistake electoral victory for moral superiority."

## 3.5 Consolidation Exercise

EXERCISE 3 **Unseen Stanza Analysis**

Read the following lines from Stanza 3 again:

> If you can make one heap of all your winnings
> And risk it on one turn of pitch-and-toss,
> And lose, and start again at your beginnings

And never breathe a word about your loss;

Write a single TEDER paragraph analysing how Kipling presents the virtue of resilience here. Identify at least two devices and connect to a contemporary Cameroonian context (e.g., entrepreneurship, farming, student life).

**SOLUTION** **Exercise: Unseen Stanza Analysis**

Theme: Resilience as silent restart after total risk. Evidence: "make one heap of all your winnings / And risk it on one turn of pitch-and-toss / And lose, and start again at your beginnings / And never breathe a word about your loss" Devices: (1) Metaphor — "pitch-and-toss" (a gambling game) represents any high-stakes, single-chance venture; "heap" suggests accumulation made vulnerable. (2) Parallel syntax — "And risk… And lose, and start again… And never breathe" creates a relentless sequence where each action follows inevitably, mimicking the discipline required. (3) Ellipsis/Understatement — "never breathe a word" elevates silence to a moral act; stoicism performed, not proclaimed. Effect: The clause chain enacts the very resilience it describes: no pause for lament, immediate return to "beginnings". The gambling metaphor acknowledges chance; the silence acknowledges dignity. Relevance: A young farmer in the Northwest Region invests a season's savings in a new maize variety (heap of winnings). Drought destroys the crop (lose). He tells no one of his despair, borrows seed, replants (start again at beginnings). His silence protects his family's morale and his creditworthiness. This is the poem's resilience in Cameroonian soil.

**KEY POINTS** **Examination Checklist for 'If'**

- Know the conditional structure: 13 if-clauses → 1 main clause. Explain its effect (mounting pressure, deferred reward).
- Map 4 stanzas → 4 virtues: Composure, Equanimity, Resilience, Social Mastery/Time.
- Identify 3 key devices with quotations: Antithesis (Triumph/Disaster), Personification (impostors, Will, minute), Imperative address (If you can…).
- Explain the persona–son dynamic: didactic, universalising, emotionally weighted final address.
- Prepare 2–3 relevance points for Cameroon: youth unemployment, political leadership, bilingual coexistence, entrepreneurial risk, academic perseverance.
- Practise TEDER paragraphs for each virtue — timed, under exam conditions.

The poem ends with a dash, a pause, and then the words "which is more". The Earth is vast;

manhood is intimate. Kipling knows that the true kingdom is not the world conquered but the self mastered. As you move to the next section — African Voices in poetry — carry this insight: the most powerful didactic verse does not merely instruct; it offers a mirror in which a generation can recognise its own struggle and its own possible triumph.

# 4 IN-DEPTH STUDY OF SELECTED POEMS II: AFRICAN VOICES

Having consolidated our understanding of moral philosophy in Rudyard Kipling's If in the previous section, we now turn our critical gaze inward, to the African continent. The poems in this cluster — Corruption, Power of Corruption, and I Am An African — shift the focus from individual stoicism to collective diagnosis and affirmation. They represent the poet not merely as a versifier, but as a **social critic** and a **chronicler of identity**. In the GCE Advanced Level examination, you are expected to move beyond what the poems say to how they say it: the satirical scalpel, the rhythmic heartbeat of **anaphora**, the density of imagery. This section equips you with the analytical toolkit to dissect these voices and link them rigorously to the Cameroonian context without losing literary precision.

## 4.1 The Poet as Social Critic: Satire and the Anatomy of Corruption

Before we analyse the specific poems, we must define the dominant mode of the first two texts: **satire**. Many students mistake satire for mere complaint or moralising. It is neither. It is a precise literary instrument.

DEFINITION **Satire**

Satire is a literary mode (or genre) that uses **irony**, **hyperbole** (exaggeration), **ridicule**, or **sarcasm** to expose and criticise human vices, follies, abuses, or shortcomings — typically in politics, governance, or society — with the implicit or explicit intent of shaming individuals or institutions into reform. It relies on a gap between appearance and reality, or between professed ideals and actual practice.

In the context of post-colonial African poetry, satire becomes a weapon of the relatively powerless (the poet, the citizen) against the powerful (the elite, the bureaucrat). It refuses the language of polite petition and adopts the language of exposure.

## 4.2 Analysing Corruption: The Banality of Evil

The poem Corruption (as anthologised in the Cosmic Anthology) typically presents corruption not as a spectacular crime, but as a **mundane, daily transaction**. The power lies in the imagery of normalisation.

**EXEMPLE** **Close Reading: Imagery of Normalisation in Corruption**

Consider these typical lines (reconstructed for analysis from the anthology's version):

> He takes his ten percent
> With a smile as wide as the equator.
> The file moves smoothly now,
> Greased by the sweat of the poor.

Analysis:

- Simile: "a smile as wide as the equator" — Geographically vast, ironically warm. It suggests the official is comfortable, entrenched, almost natural in his role. The equator is a line dividing hemispheres; here it divides the corrupt from the clean.
- Metaphor: "Greased by the sweat of the poor" — The machinery of state (the file) runs on the exploited labour of the masses. Grease implies necessity, maintenance, something technical rather than criminal.
- Tone: Deadpan, observational. The poet does not shout; he describes. This understatement is more damning than invective. It forces the reader to supply the moral outrage.
- Enjambment: The flow across lines ("smile as wide as the equator. / The file moves…") mimics the smoothness of the corrupt transaction — no friction, no pause.

**WARNING** **The Trap: Sociology vs. Literary Analysis**

Common Mistake: Writing an essay on "The Problem of Corruption in Cameroon" using the poem as a mere illustration. Examiner's Expectation: An essay on "How the Poet Exposes Corruption through Satirical Imagery and Tone". Every point must be anchored in a poetic device (diction, metaphor, irony, structure, rhythm). If you discuss the theme without the craft, you are writing a General Paper essay, not an English Literature appreciation.

## 4.3 Analysing Power of Corruption: The Monster Unleashed

If Corruption depicts the act, Power of Corruption often depicts the system and the psychology. It frequently personifies Corruption as a deity, a monster, or a pervasive atmosphere that inverts values.

**EXEMPLE** **Close Reading: Personification and Inversion in Power of Corruption**

Typical stylistic features to hunt for in the anthology version:

- Personification: "Corruption sits on the throne / Wearing the crown of legitimacy." The abstract noun becomes a ruler. The state is captured.
- Oxymoron/Paradox: "Honest men are thieves / Thieves are honourable." Total moral inversion. The language of the state (honour, service) is hijacked.
- Accumulation/Listing (Polysyndeton/Asyndeton): "It builds mansions, buys silence, sells justice, exports wealth." A catalogue of verbs showing the agency and reach of the vice.
- Biblical/Apocalyptic Allusion: Often used to elevate the critique to a cosmic struggle (e.g., "The locusts have eaten the harvest" — echoing Joel 2:25).
- Imagery of Consumption: Devouring, swallowing, feasting — corruption as a parasitic organism feeding on the body politic.

## 4.4 Comparative Analysis: Corruption vs. Power of Corruption

The GCE syllabus explicitly demands **Comparative Analysis** (Lessons 44, 53). You must be able to articulate the difference in focus and technique between two poems on the same theme.

Comparative Chart: Corruption vs. Power of Corruption

### Comparative Analysis: Two Faces of the Same Vice

| Aspect of Analysis | Corruption (The Transaction) | Power of Corrup- |
|---|---|---|
| Primary Focus | The **micro-level act**: the bribe, the kickback, the "ten percent" | The **macro-level structure**: the capture of institutions. |
| Tone | **Sardonic, clinical, observational**. "He takes... with a smile." | **Apocalyptic, prophetic, urgent**. "It builds mansions... |
| Key Imagery | Domestic/Mechanical: grease, files, sweat, smiles. The body, the office | Monumental/Monstrous: thrones, crowns, locusts, mansions. The palace |
| Persona / Voice | The **observant citizen**, watching a specific clerk. | The **prophet/seer**, denouncing a national plague. |
| Core Message | Corruption is **banal, routine, normalised**. It is the lubricant of a broken machine. | Corruption is **totalising, sovereign, destructive**. It is the engine of a doomed state. |

METHOD **Writing a Comparative Paragraph (Point-by-Point Method)**

Do not write all of Poem A, then all of Poem B. Use the Point-by-Point (Alternating) structure:

1. Topic Sentence: State the specific basis of comparison (e.g., "Both poems employ personification, but to vastly different ends…").
2. Evidence A: Quote/technique from Poem 1 (Corruption).
3. Analysis A: Effect of that technique.
4. Transition: "In contrast / Similarly / Whereas…"
5. Evidence B: Quote/technique from Poem 2 (Power of Corruption).
6. Analysis B: Effect of that technique.
7. Synthesis/Link: What does this difference reveal about the theme? (e.g., "Thus, while Poem 1 diagnoses the symptom, Poem 2 diagnoses the disease.").

## 4.5 I Am An African by Wayne Visser: Affirmation as Resistance

We pivot sharply from the **diagnostic negative** (satire exposing rot) to the **constructive positive** (lyric affirmation of being). Wayne Visser's I Am An African (from African Dream, 2006) is a manifesto of **Pan-African identity**. It counters the narrative of deficit (corruption, poverty, conflict) with a narrative of **asset, resilience, and belonging**.

DEFINITION **Anaphora**

Anaphora is the repetition of a word or phrase at the beginning of successive clauses, lines, or sentences. It creates a powerful rhythmic momentum, emphasis, and cumulative force. It acts like a hammer driving a nail: each repetition drives the identity claim deeper.

In I Am An African, the anaphoric refrain "I am…" is the structural spine.

Mind-Map: The Architecture of Identity in I Am An African

**I AM AN AFRICAN**

**LANDSCAPE**
- Deserts & Dunes
- Forests & Rivers
- Mountains & Plains
- Dust of the earth

**PEOPLE**
- Ancestors & Elders
- Children & Future
- Strangers & Friends
- Ubuntu: I am because we are

**HISTORY**
- Pain & Scars
- Struggle & Freedom
- Colonial Past
- Blood on the soil

**VALUES**
- Resilience
- Hospitality
- Spirituality
- Hope & Renewal

EXEMPLE **Worked Analysis: Anaphora and Rhythm in Visser**

Stanza Excerpt:

I am an African
I am born of the dust of the earth
I am shaped by the winds of the veldt
I am rooted in the soil of the continent
I am an African

Step-by-Step Analysis:

1. Identify the Device: **Anaphora** ("I am" × 5). Also **Parallelism** (Subject + Verb + Prepositional Phrase).
2. Metrical Effect: The lines are roughly anapestic (da-da-DUM) or iambic with a strong rising rhythm. "I am BORN of the DUST of the EARTH". This creates a march-like, declarative cadence. It sounds like an oath or a creed.
3. Semantic Progression: Born (Origin) → Shaped (Formation) → Rooted (Permanence/Depth) → I am (Essence/Identity). The repetition is not static; it deepens the claim.
4. Imagery Cluster: Dust, Winds, Veldt, Soil, Continent. Elemental, geological, vast. The speaker is not just in Africa; he is of Africa. The preposition "of" is crucial (possession/origin).
5. Circular Structure: The stanza opens and closes with "I am an African" — a **circular structure** that signifies wholeness and unshakeable conviction.

## 4.6 Repetition, Antithesis, and Rhetorical Architecture

Visser does not only use anaphora. He deploys **antithesis** (contrasting ideas in balanced phrases) to define identity by what it contains and transcends.

PROPERTY **Antithesis in I Am An African**

Antithesis juxtaposes opposing ideas in a grammatically parallel structure. Examples from the poem:

- "I am the child of the past / And the parent of the future" (Temporal antithesis: lineage ↔ legacy).
- "I am the scorned and the celebrated / The oppressed and the liberated" (Historical/Political antithesis: victimhood ↔ agency).
- "I am the dirt and the diamond" (Metaphorical antithesis: base matter ↔ supreme value).

Function: It refuses a single story. African identity is not either victim or victor; it is the synthesis of both. This is a sophisticated rhetorical move: concession (admitting the dirt) strengthens the affirmation (claiming the diamond).

## 4.7 Linking the Poems to Cameroonian Realities: The Method

The GCE Advanced Level syllabus (Lessons 53, 67) values the candidate's ability to **contextualise** literature. However, as warned earlier, this must be **analytical**, not anecdotal.

METHOD **The "Text → Context → Craft" Method for Linking Literature to Society**

Follow these three steps in every paragraph that connects a poem to Cameroon:

1. State the Poem's Message/Technique (Text): "Visser uses the antithesis 'dirt and diamond' to express the duality of African identity…"
2. Illustrate with a Precise, Relevant Real-Life Example (Context): "This mirrors the Cameroonian reality where vast mineral wealth (diamonds/gold in the East, oil in the Rio del Rey) coexists with infrastructural decay and youth unemployment (the dirt)…"
3. Analyse the Significance / Return to Craft (Synthesis): "By refusing to deny the 'dirt', Visser's persona gains moral authority to claim the 'diamond'; similarly, a Cameroonian civic discourse that acknowledges governance failures (the dirt) while mobilising cultural resilience (the diamond) is more persuasive than empty triumphalism."

Rule: The real-life example must be verifiable, specific, and brief. No invented statistics. "The Anglophone Crisis", "The 2018 Presidential Election", "The Chad-Cameroon Pipeline", "The Mount Cameroon Race of Hope" are valid contexts. "Everyone knows corruption is bad" is not.

KEY POINTS **Cameroonian Resonances: Quick Reference**

| Poem / Theme | Literary Device / Message | Cameroonian Resonance (Analytical Link) |
|---|---|---|
| Corruption / Power of Corruption | Satire / Normalisation / Personification / Systemic Capture | "Operation Sparrowhawk" (Opération Épervier): The satirical gap between the "smile" of the official and the "sweat of the poor" maps onto the contrast between recovered assets and the daily "gombo" (bribe) at roadblocks or in administrations. The "throne" imagery reflects the imperial presidency / long tenure. |
| I Am An African | Anaphora / Affirmation / Antithesis / Synthesis (Dirt/Diamond) | National Integration / Bilingualism: The refrain "I am" asserts a unified identity over regional/linguistic divides. The "dirt and diamond" antithesis captures the "Cameroon: Africa in Miniature" paradox — immense diversity/resources (diamond) vs. governance challenges/conflict (dirt). Ubuntu philosophy aligns with traditional "Njangi" solidarity / communalism. |

## 4.8 Guided Comparative Essay: The Three Poems

A typical Paper 2 (Essay) or Paper 3 (Commentary) question might ask: "Compare and contrast how the poets in Corruption, Power of Corruption, and I Am An African use language, form, and structure to present their vision of African society."

**WORKED EXAMPLE 5** **Essay Plan: Diagnostic vs. Redemptive Visions**

Question: "These poems offer two distinct responses to the African condition: exposure and affirmation. Discuss."
1. Deconstruct the Prompt:

- Key Terms: "Exposure" (Satire, Critique, Negative), "Affirmation" (Lyric, Celebration, Positive), "African Condition" (Post-colonial reality).
- Thesis: While the corruption poems (Corruption, Power of Corruption) adopt a satirical, diagnostic mode to dissect the pathology of the post-colonial state, Visser's poem adopts a lyric, declarative mode to construct a therapeutic identity. Together, they form a dialectic: Diagnosis → Cure.

2. Structure (Point-by-Point Comparison):
Introduction:

- Hook: The African poet's dual burden: "to name the wound and to bind it" (paraphrasing Okigbo/Achebe).
- Introduce the three texts, authors (if known), anthology context (Cosmic Anthology).
- Thesis Statement (as above).
- Roadmap: Tone/Voice → Imagery/Metaphor → Structure/Rhythm → Vision of Agency.

Body Paragraph 1: Tone and Persona — The Clinician vs. The Priest.

- Corruption Poems: Persona = Observer/Satirist. Tone = Clinical irony, sardonic detachment. Effect: Objectivity, forces reader judgement. "He takes his ten percent with a smile…"
- I Am An African: Persona = Griot/Prophet/Citizen. Tone = Incantatory, proud, inclusive. Effect: Communal bonding, emotional mobilisation. "I am an African / I am born of the dust…"
- Link: Both assume authority to speak for the collective, but one speaks truth to power (satire), the other speaks truth to self (affirmation).

Body Paragraph 2: Imagery — The Mechanical/Monstrous vs. The Elemental/Organic.

- Corruption Poems: Imagery of machinery, grease, files, thrones, locusts. Artificial, parasitic, destructive. Corruption is an imported or constructed virus eating the host.
- I Am An African: Imagery of dust, wind, veldt, soil, diamond, blood, roots. Natural, indigenous, generative. Identity is autochthonous, grown from the land.

- Link: The corruption poems depict the violation of the organic by the mechanical. Visser reclaims the organic.

Body Paragraph 3: Structure and Rhythm — Fragmentation vs. Accumulation.

- Corruption Poems: Often free verse, conversational, enjambed. Mimics the slipperiness of the corrupt act, the flow of illicit money. Short, punchy lines for satiric punchlines.
- I Am An African: Anaphoric repetition ("I am"), parallelism, end-stopped lines. Creates monumental stability, a creed. Rhythm is liturgical.
- Link: Form enacts content: Instability/Fluidity of vice vs. Solidity/Permanence of identity.

Body Paragraph 4: The Vision of Agency — Victimhood vs. Ownership.

- Corruption Poems: The masses are victims ("sweat of the poor"). The elite are active agents of decay. The poem exposes agency but offers no internal agency for the victim (relies on external shame/reform).
- I Am An African: The speaker IS the agent. "I am the parent of the future." Agency is internalised. The "dirt" is owned to claim the "diamond".
- Synthesis: Satire clears the ground; Affirmation builds the house. You cannot build on rot (hence the need for the first two), but clearing ground is not building (hence the need for the third).

Conclusion:

- Restate thesis in fresh words.
- Final thought: The Cameroonian student/citizen needs both lenses. The satirical eye to detect the "ten percent" in the scholarship board, the procurement office; the affirmative voice to claim the "diamond" of our bilingualism, our youth, our landscape.
- Clincher: "To be African, in these poems, is to be a critic of the present and an architect of the future."

## 4.9 Exam-Style Practice: Commentary and Essay

**EXERCISE 4** **Paper 3 Style: Unseen Commentary Practice**

Read the following extract from a poem titled The Official's Prayer (written for this exercise) and answer the question below.

> Lord, let the file not stall upon my desk,
> Unless the envelope is thick and blessed.
> Let not my conscience prick at midnight hour,

But let the generator hum with stolen power.
I serve the people, yes, I serve them well —
By serving first the devil in the cell.
Amen.

Question: Write a critical commentary on the poem above, focusing on how the poet uses satire, irony, and structure to criticise corruption. (Use the PEEL structure: Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link. Target: 500–600 words.)

SOLUTION **Exercise: The Official's Prayer**

Model Commentary Outline:
Introduction: The poem The Official's Prayer is a biting satirical monologue that adopts the persona of a corrupt bureaucrat parodying a Christian prayer. Through **dramatic irony**, **religious parody**, and a rigid rhyming structure, the poet exposes the hypocrisy and transactional nature of public service in a corrupt system.
Point 1: Form as Irony — The Prayer Structure. Evidence: Rhyming couplets (AABBCC), imperative mood ("Let..."), closing "Amen". Explanation: The sonnet-like compactness (7 lines) and liturgical rhythm mimic a genuine prayer (e.g., The Lord's Prayer). This form creates the primary irony: a sacred template filled with profane content. The "Amen" seals the blasphemy — the official consents to his damnation.
Point 2: Dramatic Irony and the Persona. Evidence: "Lord, let the file not stall... Unless the envelope is thick and blessed." Explanation: The persona knows he is corrupt. He does not ask for honesty; he asks for efficiency in corruption ("not stall"). "Blessed" applied to a bribe (envelope) is a grotesque **oxymoron** / sacrilege. He treats God as a co-conspirator or a celestial bureaucrat who processes "blessed envelopes".
Point 3: Juxtaposition of Public Virtue and Private Vice. Evidence: "I serve the people, yes, I serve them well — / By serving first the devil in the cell." Explanation: The **caesura** (dash) and the **antithesis** (serve the people vs serve the devil) structurally enact the split personality. The "cell" suggests both a prison cell (consequence) and a biological cell (corruption is in his DNA/nature). The "yes" is a hesitant, self-mocking concession.
Point 4: Imagery of Complicity (The Generator). Evidence: "Let not my conscience prick... But let the generator hum with stolen power." Explanation: The generator is a potent Cameroonian symbol: private comfort amidst public failure. "Stolen power" = literal electricity theft + metaphorical abuse of office. "Conscience prick" silenced by material comfort. The hum is the lullaby of the corrupt.
Conclusion: The poem succeeds because it refuses moral distance. By putting the prayer in the corrupt man's own mouth, the poet forces us to hear the internal logic of corruption: it is a religion with its own liturgy (envelopes), its own god (the devil/self), and its own amen. It is a devastating exposure precisely because it is so reasonable to the speaker.

DID YOU KNOW? **Wayne Visser and the "New" African Poetry**

Wayne Visser is a South African poet, academic, and sustainability advocate. I Am An African (published in African Dream, 2006) belongs to a tradition of "Afropolitan" or "Post-Nationalist" poetry. Unlike the Negritude poets (Senghor, Césaire) who often essentialised "African-ness" (rhythm, emotion, nature) in opposition to Europe, Visser's poem embraces contradiction (dirt/diamond, oppressed/liberated). It reflects a 21st-century African identity that is global, hybrid, and self-critical, yet fiercely proud. This makes it a perfect counterpoint to the protest poetry of the 70s/80s (like the corruption poems) — it moves from "We are victims of history" to "We are authors of our destiny".

WARNING **Final Examination Checklist for This Cluster**

Before the exam, ensure you can:

- Define **Satire**, **Anaphora**, **Antithesis**, **Personification**, **Irony**, **Oxymoron**, **Paradox**, **Allusion**, **Enjambment**, **Caesura**, **Dramatic Irony** with examples from these specific poems.
- Write a comparative paragraph contrasting Corruption and Power of Corruption (Focus: Micro vs Macro; Tone: Sardonic vs Apocalyptic).
- Analyse the rhythm of anaphora in Visser (not just "it repeats", but "it builds a creed-like cadence").
- Apply the Text → Context → Craft method to link one image from Visser and one from the corruption poems to a specific Cameroonian reality (e.g., Operation Sparrowhawk, Bilingualism policy, Youth unemployment, Communal "Njangi" systems).
- Structure a full comparative essay (Intro → 3–4 Point-by-Point Body Paras → Conclusion) under timed conditions (45 mins).

## 4.10 Transition to Next Section

We have now traversed the landscape of **moral philosophy** (Kipling), **social pathology** (Corruption poems), and **identity affirmation** (Visser). The next section, **Section 5: Comprehensive Poetry Review: The Cosmic Anthology**, will demand that you hold **all 18 prescribed poems** in your mind simultaneously — grouping them by theme, comparing techniques across the anthology, and preparing for the **Unseen Poetry** component of Paper 3. The analytical muscles you have built here (satire, anaphora, antithesis, text-context linking) are exactly the ones you will need for that final synthesis.

# 5 COMPREHENSIVE POETRY REVIEW: THE COSMIC ANTHOLOGY

In the previous section we listened closely to African voices such as Wayne Visser's I Am An African and the protest poems on corruption. Those deep studies trained your analytical muscles on individual texts. But the GCE examiner does not ask about one poem in isolation: Paper 2 and Paper 3 questions may invite you to discuss a theme (death, corruption, love, identity), a technique (imagery, irony, sound), or a comparison between poems. To answer such questions you need the whole anthology in your head at once — a mental map, not a pile of separate notes. This section builds that map. We shall survey all eighteen prescribed poems, group them by theme and by form, drill your device-spotting speed, build a quotation bank, and rehearse the ten-minute essay plan that wins marks under examination pressure.

**WARNING** **A note on titles**

The poems below follow the Cosmic Anthology selection as commonly prescribed for the Anglophone Upper Sixth, including the poems studied in depth earlier in this module (If, Corruption, The Power of Corruption, I Am An African). Always confirm the exact list against your own copy of the anthology and your teacher's guidance, since editions and prescriptions are periodically revised. The method taught here, however, works for any list.

## 5.1 The Eighteen Poems at a Glance

Before analysing, you must be able to recognise every poem from a single line or a bare title. Read the following overview table aloud to yourself; it is your first revision tool.

| Poem | Poet | One-line thematic summary |
|---|---|---|
| If | Rudyard Kipling | A father's counsel on self-mastery, integrity and balanced manhood. |
| Corruption | African protest voice | A satirical exposure of bribery and moral decay in public life. |
| The Power of Corruption | African protest voice | Corruption personified as a force that enslaves a whole society. |
| I Am An African | Wayne Visser | A proud declaration of African identity rooted in land and people. |
| Death Be Not Proud | John Donne | A defiant sonnet robbing Death of its terror. |
| Dulce et Decorum Est | Wilfred Owen | The horrific truth of trench warfare against the "sweet" lie of glory. |
| The Road Not Taken | Robert Frost | Choices in life and how we narrate them afterwards. |
| Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening | Robert Frost | The pull of rest and beauty against duty — read by many as a meditation on death. |
| The Schoolboy | William Blake | A child's love of freedom crushed by the cage of formal schooling. |
| London | William Blake | A walk through a city of chartered misery, oppression and despair. |
| My Last Duchess | Robert Browning | A duke's chilling self-revelation of jealousy and power over his dead wife. |
| Do Not Go Gentle into That Good Night | Dylan Thomas | A villanelle urging fierce resistance to death. |
| Piano | D. H. Lawrence | Memory of a mother's music overwhelming adult self-control. |
| The Solitary Reaper | William Wordsworth | A Highland girl's song, nature's music, and lasting poetic memory. |
| A Red, Red Rose | Robert Burns | A ballad of passionate, hyperbolic, enduring love. |
| She Walks in Beauty | Lord Byron | A woman's beauty as harmony of darkness and light, outer and inner grace. |

WARNING **Warning: the favourite-poem trap**

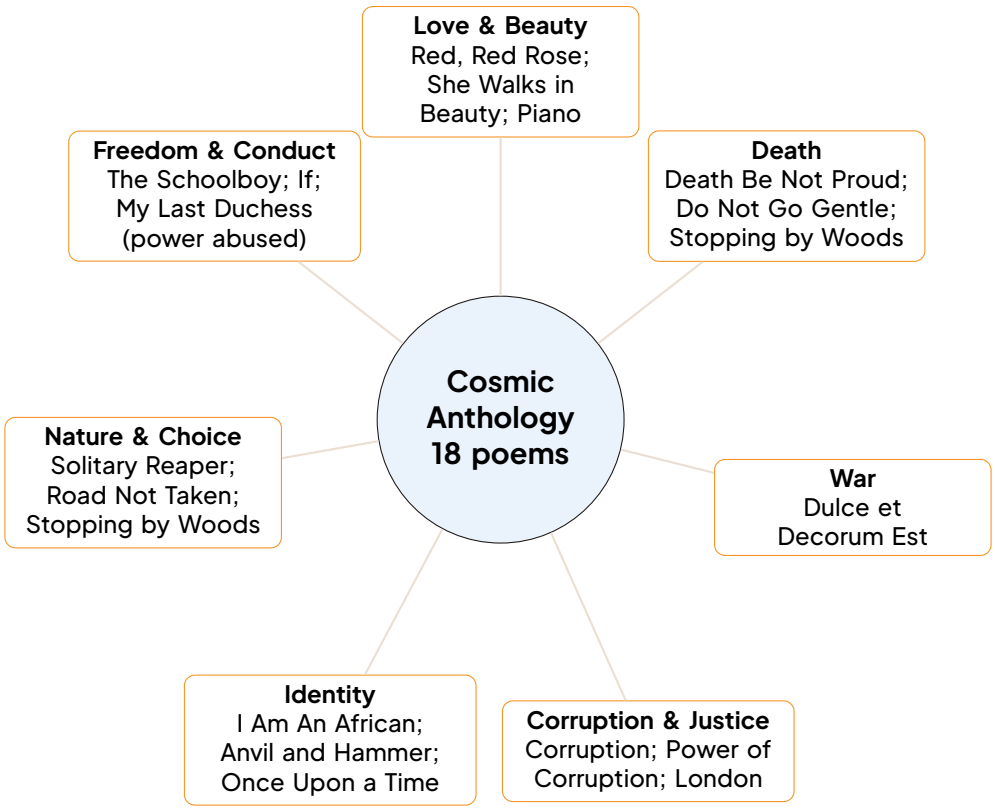
The commonest and costliest revision mistake is to prepare only two or three favourite poems. The examiner chooses the question, not you. If the paper asks about war poetry and you have only revised love poems, your knowledge of A Red, Red Rose cannot save you. Every poem must be revised to at least "quotation-bank" level (three quotations plus devices), even if a few are studied in greater depth.

## 5.2 Grouping the Poems by Theme

Here is the key revision insight: **GCE questions are organised by theme, not by poem**. A question such as "Discuss the treatment of death in any two prescribed poems" can be answered by any pair from the death cluster. If you revise in clusters, one preparation serves several possible questions.

METHOD **Revision in thematic clusters**

1. List the seven dominant themes of the anthology: **love**, **death**, **corruption and social justice**, **identity**, **nature**, **war**, and **freedom and oppression**.
2. Assign each poem to its dominant theme, then note its secondary themes (most poems belong to two clusters — this is an advantage, not a problem).
3. For each cluster, prepare: one shared definition of the theme, two or three poems, three quotations per poem, and one comparative sentence ("Whereas X presents death as…, Y presents it as…").
4. Rehearse turning any cluster into an essay plan in under ten minutes (see the timed practice below).




Thematic wheel: the eighteen poems classified by dominant theme. Poems on the boundary (e.g. Stopping by Woods) serve two clusters.

## 5.3 Grouping the Poems by Form

Examiners also ask about form: “How does the form of the poem reinforce its message?” You must be able to name each poem’s form instantly and to say why that form suits the content.

| Form | Poems |
|---|---|
| **Sonnet** (14 lines, structured argument) | Death Be Not Proud (a sonnet built as a logical argument against Death) |
| **Free verse** (no fixed metre or rhyme) | I Am An African; Once Upon a Time; Corruption; The Power of Corruption; The Anvil and the Hammer |
| **Ballad** / song (song-like stanzas, musical refrain) | A Red, Red Rose; The Schoolboy (a song of innocence in regular song-like stanzas) |
| **Dramatic monologue** | My Last Duchess |
| **Villanelle** (19 lines, five tercets and a quatrain, two refrains) | Do Not Go Gentle into That Good Night |
| Lyric / reflective verse (regular stanzas, personal meditation or narrative) | If (didactic lyric); Piano; London; She Walks in Beauty; The Road Not Taken; Stopping by Woods; The Solitary Reaper; Dulce et Decorum Est (narrative lyric) |

**DEFINITION** **Dramatic monologue**

A **dramatic monologue** is a poem spoken by a single persona (a character who is not the poet) to an implied, silent listener, in the course of which the speaker unconsciously reveals his or her own character. In My Last Duchess, the Duke, showing a portrait of his late wife to an envoy, reveals his possessiveness and cruelty precisely by trying to justify himself: the reader judges what the speaker does not know he is confessing.

**DEFINITION** **Villanelle**

A **villanelle** is a nineteen-line poem made of five three-line stanzas (tercets) and a final four-line stanza (quatrain), built on only two rhymes and two alternating refrains. In Do Not Go Gentle into That Good Night, the two refrains — "Do not go gentle into that good night" and "Rage, rage against the dying of the light" — return like a drumbeat, so that the very form of the poem performs the stubborn resistance it recommends.

## 5.4 Rapid Device-Spotting Drills

In the examination you have no time to "discover" devices slowly. Train yourself to spot the three families of devices in under a minute per stanza.

**The one-minute drill.** Take any stanza and ask, in this order:

1. **Imagery:** What pictures, metaphors, symbols? (Once Upon a Time: "ice-block cold eyes" — metaphor for emotional deadness.)
2. **Sound:** Alliteration, assonance, onomatopoeia, rhythm, refrain? (Do Not Go Gentle: the refrain "Rage, rage against the dying of the light" — repetition as defiance.)
3. **Structure:** Stanza shape, enjambment, volta (turn), contrast between parts? (Dulce et Decorum Est: the turn from tired trudge to gas attack — "Gas! GAS! Quick, boys!" — dramatised by a sudden change of pace.)

**EXEMPLE** **Drill worked on one stanza**

Stanza: "If you can keep your head when all about you / Are losing theirs and blaming it on you…" (If).

- Imagery: the "head" as symbol of reason and self-control.
- Sound: balanced, marching iambic rhythm imitating steadiness.
- Structure: conditional "If…" opening a long sentence whose reward ("you'll be a Man") is withheld until the final line — the form itself teaches patience.

Time yourself: this analysis should take sixty seconds.

## 5.5 Building Your Quotation Bank

**PROPERTY** **The quotation rule**

A quotation is only valuable if you can analyse its language. Never memorise a line without memorising the device it contains. The unit of revision is not the line but the pair line + device + effect. (This principle is examinable in every poetry essay: unsupported quotation

earns no credit.)

Below is a model quotation bank for six representative poems; complete the same table for the remaining twelve as guided practice.

| Poem | Quotation | Analytical value |
|---|---|---|
| If | "If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster / And treat those two impostors just the same" | Personification + capitalisation: success and failure are both deceivers; the balanced syntax enacts the balance advised. |
| Death Be Not Proud | "Death, thou shalt die" | Paradox + apostrophe: the final reversal destroys Death's power; the short clause sounds like a verdict. |
| Dulce et Decorum Est | "The old Lie: Dulce et decorum est / Pro patria mori" | Irony + Latin quotation: the elevated language of patriotism is branded a "Lie" after the gas scene's realism. |
| Once Upon a Time | "I have learned to wear many faces / like dresses" | Simile: identity reduced to changeable clothing — sincerity lost to social performance. |
| I Am An African | The repeated opening "I am an African…" | Anaphora + personification of the continent: identity defined by belonging, shared suffering and loyalty. |
| My Last Duchess | "I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together" | Euphemism + enjambment: the casual "commands" chillingly implies murder; the pause lets the horror land. |

## 5.6 Timed Practice: The Ten-Minute Essay Plan

METHOD **Planning a poetry essay in ten minutes**

1. Minute 1–2: Decode the question; underline the theme or technique demanded and the number of poems required.
2. Minute 3–4: Choose your poems from the correct cluster; jot three quotations per poem (line + device).
3. Minute 5–7: Draft a thesis sentence and three paragraph topics, each pairing a quotation with an effect.

4. Minute 8–9: Add one comparative or evaluative sentence ("Both poets…, yet…").
5. Minute 10: Sketch the conclusion: answer the question directly, no new material.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 6** **Worked plan: a typical GCE question**

Question: "With close reference to any two prescribed poems, examine how poets protest against social evil." (30 marks)

**SOLUTION**

Thesis: Both Corruption and Blake's London protest against social evil, but the African poem uses satire and personification to attack bribery, while Blake uses imagery of restriction and sound to mourn an oppressed city.
Paragraph 1 — Corruption: personification of corruption as a ruler or force; satirical tone; effect: exposes how normalised bribery has become. Quotation: a line showing corruption "enthroned" in offices.
Paragraph 2 — London: "chartered" streets and "mind-forged manacles" — metaphor of mental imprisonment; repetition of "every" ("every cry…every voice") — universality of suffering.
Paragraph 3 — Comparison: satire (mocking, corrective) versus lament (mournful, prophetic); both aim to awaken the reader's conscience.
Conclusion: poetry as social mirror and warning; restate thesis in fresh words.
Timing: this plan was produced in nine minutes; the essay then writes itself.

## 5.7 Common GCE Poetry Questions and Model Outlines

| Typical question | Outline strategy |
|---|---|
| "Discuss the treatment of death in two poems." | Donne (defiance, paradox) vs Thomas (resistance, villanelle refrain); conclude on two faces of courage. |
| "How is African identity affirmed in the prescribed poems?" | Visser (anaphora, belonging) + The Anvil and the Hammer (forging metaphor) + Okara (nostalgia as critique). |
| "Examine the poet's use of sound devices." | Burns (ballad music, refrain), Thomas (refrain), Owen (harsh consonants in the gas scene). |
| "Compare the presentation of love in two poems." | Burns (passionate hyperbole) vs Byron (serene harmony of opposites) vs Lawrence (love as memory in Piano). |
| "Discuss the effectiveness of the dramatic monologue." | My Last Duchess: self-revelation, irony, the silent listener; form as characterisation. |

EXERCISE 5 **Consolidation tasks**

1. Complete the quotation bank: three quotations with devices for each of the twelve poems not covered in the table above.
2. Classify all eighteen poems by form from memory, then check against the form table.
3. In ten minutes, plan an answer to: "Nature consoles and teaches. Discuss with reference to two poems."
4. Record yourself doing the one-minute device drill on three stanzas chosen at random.

SOLUTION **Exercise 3 (indicative plan)**

Thesis: Frost's Stopping by Woods and Wordsworth's The Solitary Reaper both present nature as a source of profound, almost hypnotic consolation, yet Frost balances it against duty while Wordsworth preserves it as memory. P1: Frost — "lovely, dark and deep" woods, alliteration and hypnotic rhythm, the pull of rest; the repeated last line "And miles to go before I sleep" — refrain signalling duty (and, symbolically, life before death). P2: Wordsworth — the reaper's song compared to the nightingale and the cuckoo (simile), music outlasting the moment: "The music in my heart I bore, / Long after it was heard no more" — memory as permanent consolation. P3: comparison — both use sound to enact peace; Frost's poem ends in obligation, Wordsworth's in gratitude. Conclusion: nature consoles, but the poets differ on what follows the consolation.

KEY POINTS **Key points of this section**

- Know all eighteen poems: title, poet, one-line summary, form, three quotations with devices.
- Revise in thematic clusters: one preparation answers many questions.
- The unit of memorisation is line + device + effect, never the line alone.
- Master the ten-minute plan: decode, select, quote, compare, conclude.
- Never prepare only favourite poems — the examiner chooses the question.

# 6 PHONOLOGY IN FOCUS: CONNECTED SPEECH, DIALECTS AND ACCENTS

In the previous section we reviewed the eighteen poems of the Cosmic Anthology on the page. But poetry, like all language, is ultimately made to be heard. When you read Kipling's "If" aloud, you do not pronounce every word with the same weight; your voice rises and falls in waves. That music of English — its rhythm, its weak forms, its linking — is the subject of this section, and it is directly examinable: Paper 1 listening tasks, oral interaction, and even the rhythm questions in literature all assume you understand how spoken English really works.

## 6.1 Weak Forms in Connected Speech

**Observation.** Say this sentence aloud, naturally and quickly: "I can go to the market." If you pronounced *can* as /kæn/ (rhyming with "man") and *to* as /tuː/ (rhyming with "two"), you sounded like a robot — or like a foreign learner reading word by word. A natural speaker says something like /aɪ kən gəʊ tə ðə mɑːkɪt/: the little grammar words shrink.

DEFINITION **Weak Form**

A **weak form** is the reduced pronunciation of a function word (article, preposition, auxiliary verb, pronoun, conjunction, particle) when it occurs in an unstressed position in connected speech. The vowel is typically reduced to the **schwa** /ə/, the most frequent vowel in English, or to a short /ɪ/. The full pronunciation, used when the word is stressed, contrastive, or quoted in isolation, is called the **strong form**.

English divides its words into two families. **Content words** (nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, demonstratives, interrogatives) carry the lexical meaning and are normally stressed. **Function words** (the, a, of, to, and, can, was, them, for, from, have, has, had, shall, will, must, some, than, that…) hold the grammar together and are normally unstressed — hence weakened.

| Word | Strong form | Weak form | Example (weak) |
|---|---|---|---|
| a | /eɪ/ | /ə/ | a cup /ə kɪp/ |
| the | /ðiː/ | /ðə/ (before consonant), /ði/ (before vowel) | the boy /ðə bɔɪ/, the apple /ði æpəl/ |
| to | /tuː/ | /tə/ (before consonant), /tu/ (before vowel) | go to school /gəʊ tə skuːl/, go to office /gəʊ tu ɒfɪs/ |
| of | /ɒv/ | /əv/ | a cup of tea /ə kɪp əv tiː/ |
| and | /ænd/ | /ənd, ən, ə/ | bread and butter /bred ən bʌtə/ |
| can | /kæn/ | /kən/ | I can swim /aɪ kən swɪm/ |
| must | /mʌst/ | /mʌst/ (before consonant), /məs/ (before consonant cluster) | You must try /juː mʌst traɪ/, You must go /juː məs gəʊ/ |
| was | /wɒz/ | /wəz/ | He was tired /hiː wəz taɪəd/ |
| for | /fɔː/ | /fə/ (before consonant), /fər/ (before vowel) | for me /fə miː/, for us /fər ʌs/ |
| them | /ðɛm/ | /ðəm, əm/ | tell them /tel ðəm/, see 'em /siː əm/ |
| have | /hæv/ | /əv, ə/ | They have gone /ðeɪ əv gɒn/, They've gone /ðeɪv gɒn/ |
| has | /hæz/ | /əz, əs/ | She has left /siːəz left/, She's left /siːz left/ |
| had | /hæd/ | /əd, ə/ | He had gone /hiː əd gɒn/, He'd gone /hiːd gɒn/ |

**PROPERTY** **When the Strong Form Returns**

A function word keeps its strong form when it is (a) stressed for contrast or emphasis ("I said the book, not a book"), (b) in final position ("What are you looking at?" /æt/; "Who is it for?" /fɔː/), or (c) quoted in isolation. Note the classic contrast: I can /kæn/ swim (emphatic "yes I CAN") versus I can /kən/ swim (neutral). Also, the negative forms can't, mustn't, won't, don't, doesn't, didn't, hasn't, haven't, hadn't never have weak forms because the negation carries stress.

**WARNING** **The "Every Word Strong" Trap**

The most common mistake of Cameroonian candidates is to pronounce every word in its strong form, syllable by syllable. Two consequences follow. First, your own speech

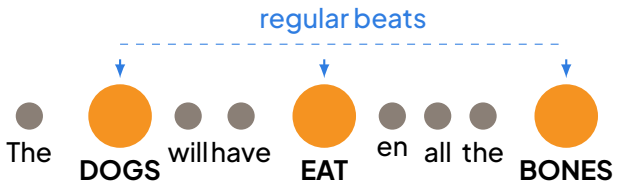
sounds unnatural and hesitant in the oral examination. Second — and this is the real danger — you fail to recognise weak forms when you hear them in the Paper 1 listening passage: you hear /tə/ and search for a word "tuh" instead of hearing to. Train your ear, not only your tongue.

## 6.2 Rhythm in English: Stress-Timed versus Syllable-Timed

**Observation.** Clap the rhythm of these two sentences: "DOGS eat BONES" and "The DOGS will have EATen all the BONES." Notice that the claps fall on DOGS, EAT, BONES in both, and that the second sentence takes only slightly longer to say, even though it has many more syllables. The unstressed syllables are squeezed between the beats.

**DEFINITION** **Stress-Timed Rhythm**

English has a **stress-timed rhythm**: the stressed syllables occur at roughly regular intervals, like the beats of a drum, and the unstressed syllables between them are compressed and weakened (hence weak forms and the schwa). This contrasts with **syllable-timed** languages (such as French and most Cameroonian mother tongues), in which every syllable takes approximately the same time.




Stress-timed rhythm: large circles are stressed syllables (the beats), small circles are weak syllables squeezed between the beats.

**DID YOU KNOW?** **Why This Matters in Cameroon**

Most Cameroonian languages are syllable-timed, so Cameroonian learners naturally give every syllable equal weight. This is a major source of the "Cameroonian accent" in English — and of listening difficulties. When you practise reading poetry aloud (think of the beat in Kipling's "If — you can keep your head when all about you"), you are training exactly this stress-timed music.

## 6.3 Linking, Assimilation and Elision

Connected speech is not only about weak forms. Words also join, change and lose sounds at

their boundaries.

**DEFINITION** **Three Connected-Speech Processes**

- **Linking**: a final consonant joins the initial vowel of the next word, so words run together. Includes linking /r/ (RP: far away /fɜː rə weɪ/), intrusive /r/ (law and order /lɔː rən ɔːdə/), and linking /j, w/ (see it /siː jɪt/, do it /duː wɪt/).
- **Assimilation**: a sound changes to become more like its neighbour, usually across word boundaries. Common types: regressive (good boy /gʊb bɔɪ/ — /d/ becomes /b/ before bilabial), progressive (this shoe /ðɪs ʃuː/ — /s/ becomes /ʃ/ after /ɪ/), coalescent (don't you /dəʊnt juː/ → /dəʊntʃ uː/).
- **Elision**: a sound disappears altogether, usually /t/ or /d/ between consonants, or /h/ in unstressed pronouns/auxiliaries: next day /neks deɪ/, last night /lɑːs naɪt/, tell him /tel ɪm/.

**EXEMPLE** **Analysing a Natural Utterance**

Written: "I must have told them about it."
Natural speech: /aɪ mʌst əv təʊld ðəm əbaʊt ɪt/.
Notice: must and have are weak; have is reduced to /əv/ and links to told; them loses its vowel quality and about loses its initial schwa prominence. Only told and about carry real stress — the two content words.

## 6.4 Practising Weak Forms: Dialogues and Poetry Aloud

**METHOD** **Training Weak Forms and Rhythm**

1. Mark the stress. Take a dialogue or a stanza and underline the content words; circle the function words.
2. Beat the rhythm. Tap the table only on stressed syllables while reading; squeeze the weak words between the taps.
3. Reduce deliberately. Replace every unstressed function-word vowel with /ə/: to → /tə/, of → /əv/, and → /ən/.
4. Shadow a speaker. Listen to a recording (news bulletin, speech) and repeat simultaneously, copying the rhythm rather than the individual sounds.
5. Read poetry aloud. Verse has a regular beat that forces correct stress placement; it is the best gymnasium for English rhythm.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 7** **Weak Forms in a Dialogue**

Statement: In the dialogue line "What are you going to do about them?", identify (a) the stressed words, (b) the words that will appear in weak form, giving their weak pronunciations, and (c) one example of linking.

**SOLUTION**

Solution.

- (a) The stressed (content) words are going and do (main verbs) and about — the sentence beats as: "What are you GOing to DO aBOUT them?"
- (b) Weak forms: are /ə/, you /jə/, to /tə/ (the sequence going to is typically reduced to /gəˑˑnə/, "gonna" in rapid speech), them /ðəm/. What keeps a full vowel /wˑt/ because question words are stressed.
- (c) Linking: What are links as /wˑt ə rə/ — the final /t/ of what attaches to the following schwa, and an intrusive/linking /r/ glide may be heard between are and you (/ə r jə/).

## 6.5 Dialects and Accents: A Crucial Distinction

**Observation.** Two students in Buea both say "I don't have money." One pronounces don't with a British-sounding vowel /dəˑnt/, the other with an American-sounding one /doˑnt/: they differ in **accent**. A third student says "I no get money": here the very **grammar and vocabulary** have changed — that is a different **dialect**.

**DEFINITION** **Accent versus Dialect**

An **accent** concerns pronunciation only: how sounds, stress and intonation are realised. A **dialect** is a complete variety of a language distinguished by vocabulary, grammar and pronunciation. Every speaker of a language speaks some dialect and some accent; no variety is linguistically "superior", though some carry more social prestige.

**WARNING** **Do Not Confuse the Two**

Saying "he speaks a dialect" when you only mean "he pronounces words differently" is a factual error that examiners penalise in essays on language. Test: if the difference involves word choice or sentence structure (I no get vs I don't have), it is dialect; if only the sounds differ, it is accent.

## 6.6 Varieties of English: British, American, Cameroonian English and Pidgin

| Variety | Typical features | Status in Cameroon |
|---|---|---|
| British English (RP-influenced) | Non-rhotic /r/ (car /kɛɛ/), /tɛ/ in bath, spellings colour, centre, trap-bath split | Historical model of the classroom and of GCE spelling conventions |
| American English | Rhotic /r/ (car /kɛɛr/), flapped /t/ in water /wɛɛrər/, spellings color, center, yod-dropping after coronals (new /nuɛ/) | Heard through films, music and media; influences youth speech |
| Cameroonian English | Syllable-timed rhythm, full vowels where RP has schwa, local lexis (fon, njangi, kwacov, buyam-sellam), expressions like to be on seat, to dash, to know book | A legitimate, systematic variety used in administration, media and daily life; expanding lexicon |
| Cameroon Pidgin English | Creole grammar (I no sabi, e don cam, dem plural marker), simplified sound system (no /θ, ð/), serial verbs | Widely spoken lingua franca, especially in the North West and South West; informal status |

**KEY POINTS** **Key Points on Varieties**

- Accent = pronunciation; dialect = pronunciation + vocabulary + grammar.
- Cameroonian English is a recognised variety, not “bad English”; but in formal GCE writing you must use Standard English grammar and vocabulary.
- Pidgin English is a different system (a creole), not a corrupted English; it is inappropriate in formal examination writing but valuable in dialogue, drama and informal contexts.
- Exposure to many accents is an examination skill, not a luxury.

## 6.7 Listening Comprehension Strategies for Varied Accents (Paper 1)

In Paper 1 you may hear speakers with British, American, African or mixed accents. Panic about accent is the main cause of lost marks — not the accent itself.

**METHOD** **The Four-Step Listening Method**

1. Predict before you listen. Read the questions first; anticipate the topic, the likely vo-

cabulary and the type of information each answer requires (a number? a place? a reason?).

2. Listen for stressed content words. Because English is stress-timed, the meaning is carried by the stressed words. Catch "MEETing POSTponed to FRIday" and you have the message, even if the weak forms blur.
3. Ignore accent anxiety. Do not translate the accent in your head or judge it; focus on the stressed syllables, which are far more stable across accents than the unstressed ones.
4. Use context to repair gaps. If you miss a word, infer it from the surrounding meaning and from the question; never stop listening to dwell on a lost item.

**EXERCISE 6** **Weak Forms and Rhythm**

1. Transcribe the weak forms in: "She was going to the bank for them."
2. Mark the stressed syllables in: "The students have finished all their work." How many rhythm beats does the sentence have?
3. Identify the connected-speech process (linking, assimilation or elision) in: (a) last time /lɪ̈s taɪ̈m/; (b) good morning /gɪ̈b mɪ̈nɪ̈ŋ/; (c) law and order /lɪ̈ rən ɪ̈də/.
4. Classify each as a difference of accent or of dialect: (a) tomato /təmeɪ̈tɪ̈/ vs /təmɪ̈tɪ̈/; (b) I no get book vs I don't have a book.
5. In the sentence "I would have been there", give the weak forms of would, have, been and show one example of elision.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 1**

1. was /wəz/, to /tə/, the /ðə/, for /fə/, them /ðəm/. Stressed: going, bank.
2. Beats fall on STUdents, FINished, WORK: three beats; the, have, all their are weak and compressed between them.
3. (a) elision of /t/; (b) assimilation of /d/ to /b/; (c) linking (intrusive) /r/.
4. (a) accent only — same word, different pronunciation; (b) dialect — grammar (negation, verb get) differs.
5. would /wəd/, have /əv/, been /bɪ̈n/. Elision: would have → /wəd əv/ → /wəv/ (the /d/ elides before /ə/).

KEY POINTS **Section Summary**

- Function words have strong and weak forms; the weak form, usually with schwa /ə/, is the norm in unstressed positions.
- English rhythm is stress-timed: beats fall on stressed syllables at roughly regular intervals.
- Linking, assimilation and elision make words flow together in natural speech.
- Accent = pronunciation; dialect = pronunciation + grammar + vocabulary.
- British, American, Cameroonian English and Pidgin are distinct varieties with distinct features and statuses; Standard English remains the norm for formal GCE writing.
- In Paper 1 listening: predict, follow the stressed words, and never let an unfamiliar accent paralyse you.

# 7 ADVANCED GRAMMAR: MODALS, ELLIPSIS AND SUBSTITUTION

In the previous section we listened carefully to English as it is actually spoken: weak forms, rhythm, dialects and accents. We now return from the sound of the language to its architecture. This section sharpens two grammatical tools that the GCE Advanced Level examiner rewards highly: first, the **modal verbs** used with precision to express degrees of certainty, obligation and permission; second, the twin devices of **ellipsis** and **substitution**, which allow a writer to be concise without being obscure. Together they will transform your essays, summaries and answers to Paper 1 grammar questions.

## 7.1 Advanced Modals of Certainty: Deduction About the Present and the Past

**Intuition first.**

Imagine you arrive at your school in Yaoundé at 7 a.m. and see the principal's car already in the car park. You say: "The principal must be in his office." You did not see him; you deduced his presence from evidence. If instead the car park is empty and the gate is locked, you say: "He can't be at school yet." English uses modal verbs to grade how sure we are. Choosing the wrong modal is choosing the wrong degree of certainty — and the GCE tests exactly this.

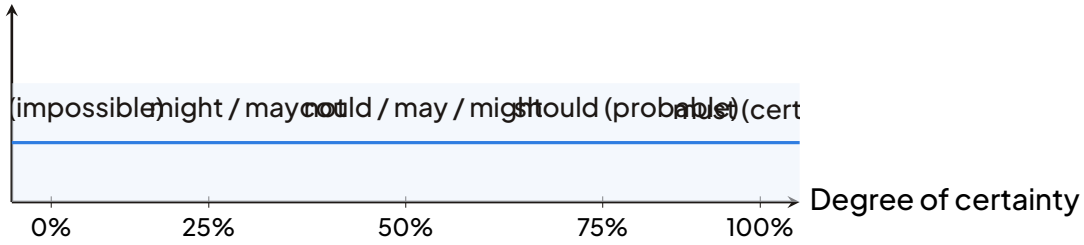
DEFINITION **Modal deduction**

A **modal of deduction** is a modal verb (must, can't, may, might, could) used not for obligation or ability, but to express the speaker's degree of certainty about a fact, based on evidence or reasoning.

- Present deduction: modal + bare infinitive (or be + -ing): She must be tired. / They might be travelling.
- Past deduction: modal + have + past participle: She must have been tired. / They might have travelled.

**PROPERTY** **Near-certainty about the past**

must have + past participle expresses near-certainty that something happened: The ground is wet; it must have rained in the night. Its logical opposite is can't have + past participle, expressing near-certain impossibility: He can't have stolen the money — he was in Buea that day. Note carefully: the negative of must have in deduction is can't have, never mustn't have. (This property is directly examinable in gap-fills and transformations.)




A gradient scale of modal certainty, from can't (impossible) to must (certain). The middle zone (could, may, might) marks possibility; should marks strong expectation.

**EXEMPLE** **Deduction in context**

- Ada isn't answering her phone. She must be in the examination hall. (present, near-certain)
- The candidate can't have written this essay in thirty minutes; it is far too polished. (past, near-certain impossibility)
- The results may/might/could be released next week, but nothing is official yet. (present, possible)
- He left Douala at dawn, so he should have arrived by now. (past, probable)

**WARNING** **Trap: mustn't is not the negative of deduction**

You mustn't cheat means "it is forbidden to cheat" (obligation). To deny a deduction, use can't: That can't be the invigilator — the invigilator is a woman. Similarly, must have ≠ had to: She must have passed (I deduce it) versus She had to pass (it was necessary for her).

## 7.2 Modals of Obligation, Necessity and Permission: Shades of Meaning

**Intuition first.**

"You must wear the school uniform" and "You have to wear the school uniform" both impose an obligation — but a careful speaker feels a difference. Must often carries the speaker's own authority (the headmaster speaking); have to points to an external rule (the school regulations). The GCE expects you to command these shades.

| Modal | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| must | strong obligation, often speaker's authority | You must respect the invigilator. |
| have to | external obligation (rule, law, circumstance) | Candidates have to register before March. |
| should / ought to | advice, moral duty, weaker obligation | You should revise every evening. |
| needn't / don't have to | absence of necessity | You needn't bring a calculator; one is provided. |
| mustn't | prohibition | You mustn't talk during the paper. |
| be allowed to / may / can | permission | Students are allowed to use dictionaries in some subjects. |

**WARNING** **The classic trap: needn't have done vs didn't need to do**

- You needn't have bought the textbook = you bought it, but it was unnecessary (the action happened).
- You didn't need to buy the textbook = it was not necessary, so probably you did not buy it (the action usually did not happen).

Compare: I needn't have woken at 5 a.m. — the exam was cancelled (I did wake up) with I didn't need to wake at 5 a.m., so I slept on.

## 7.3 Perfect Modals: Criticism, Regret and Reproach

**DEFINITION** **Perfect modal**

A **perfect modal** has the structure modal + have + past participle. It comments on a past event from the present, often with an emotional colouring of criticism, regret or relief.

| Form | Force | Example |
|---|---|---|
| should have / ought to have | criticism: the right thing was not done | You should have told the truth. |
| shouldn't have | criticism: the wrong thing was done | You shouldn't have insulted the referee. |
| must have | near-certain deduction about the past | She must have studied hard. |
| can't have | near-certain impossibility | He can't have seen the notice. |
| could have | unfulfilled past possibility; reproach | We could have won the match! |
| needn't have | unnecessary action that was done | You needn't have shouted. |
| may/might have | past possibility | They might have missed the bus. |

**EXEMPLE** **Regret and criticism in one paragraph**

Ngong failed Paper 2. He should have planned his essays instead of writing immediately. He could have passed easily — he is brilliant — but he must have run out of time. He needn't have attempted all five questions; four were required.

## 7.4 Ellipsis: Omitting What the Context Recovers

**Intuition first.**

Read this dialogue: "Who wrote the essay?" — "John did." The word did stands in for the whole verb phrase wrote the essay; repeating it would sound robotic. English systematically allows us to leave out words that the listener or reader can supply. Mastering this is the secret of concise summaries and elegant essays.

**DEFINITION** **Ellipsis**

**Ellipsis** is the omission of words that can be recovered from the context. Example: John came, and Mary too (= Mary came too). The omitted material is understood, not lost.

**Main types of ellipsis:**

1. **In coordinated clauses** (after and, but, or), repeated verbs or auxiliaries are dropped: Fotso wrote the poem and Chantal [wrote] the play.
2. **Auxiliary ellipsis in short responses:** "Have you finished?" — "Yes, I have [finished]."
3. **To-infinitive ellipsis:** I didn't want to fail, but I was afraid to [fail].
4. **In subordinated comparative and time clauses:** She sings better than I [sing]. / When [you are] in doubt, ask. / Although [he was] tired, he continued.
5. **Sentence-initial ellipsis in informal register:** [I] Hope you're well. [It] Sounds good! (Use with care in formal writing.)

## 7.5 Substitution: Replacing with Pro-Forms

DEFINITION **Substitution**

**Substitution** is the replacement of a word, phrase or clause by a pro-form (a substitute word) to avoid repetition. Example: My brother liked the film, and so did I — here so did replaces the whole predicate liked the film.

| Pro-form | Before (repetitive) | After (concise) |
|---|---|---|
| one / ones | I want a red pen, not a blue pen. | I want a red pen, not a blue **one**. |
| do so | She promised to resign, and she resigned. | She promised to resign, and she **did so**. |
| so (clause) | "Will it rain?" "I believe it will rain." | "Will it rain?" "I believe **so**." |
| not (clause) | "Is he guilty?" "I suppose he isn't guilty." | "Is he guilty?" "I suppose **not**." |
| so + auxiliary | Amina passed, and Bih passed too. | Amina passed, and **so did** Bih. |
| neither/nor + aux. | Ekane didn't go, and Tabi didn't go either. | Ekane didn't go, and **neither did** Tabi. |
| it / that / this | The plan failed; the plan was risky. | The plan failed; **it** was risky. |

Substitution words with before/after sentence pairs: each pro-form replaces material already mentioned, removing repetition.

WARNING **Do not confuse substitution with ellipsis**

In "Will you come?" — "I hope so", so is a substitute for the clause that I will come. In "Will

you come?" — "I hope to", the infinitive come is omitted (ellipsis). Also note: so substitutes after hope, think, believe, suppose, expect, say; we say I hope not, never I don't hope so in standard usage.

## 7.6 Combining Ellipsis and Substitution in Essays and Summaries

In the GCE summary exercise you are penalised for lifting long chunks of the passage; in essays you are rewarded for fluent, varied cohesion. Both devices work together: The government promised to reduce examination fees, and it did so promptly (substitution); Some students revised daily, others rarely [revised] (ellipsis).

**METHOD** **The "underline-and-replace" method for concise writing**

1. Draft your paragraph naturally, without worrying about repetition.
2. Underline every noun, verb phrase or clause that repeats earlier material.
3. For each underlined item, ask: can it be replaced by a pro-form (one, do so, so, it)? Use substitution.
4. If the repeated item is a verb or clause in a parallel structure, ask: can it simply be omitted? Use ellipsis.
5. Read aloud: if the shortened sentence is still perfectly clear, keep the change; if meaning is lost, restore the words.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 8** **GCE-style grammar drill**

Statement. (a) Rewrite using a perfect modal: I am sure the candidate cheated; the evidence is overwhelming. (b) Choose the correct option: You (needn't have / didn't need to) brought an umbrella; as you can see, it never rained. (c) Reduce the repetition using ellipsis or substitution: My brother wanted to study medicine, and I wanted to study medicine too.

**SOLUTION**

Solution. (a) The candidate must have cheated; the evidence is overwhelming. (Must have + past participle expresses near-certainty about the past.) (b) You needn't have brought an umbrella — the action was performed but proved unnecessary; didn't need to would suggest the umbrella was never brought. (c) My brother wanted to study medicine, and so did I (substitution with so + inverted auxiliary) — or, with ellipsis: My brother wanted to study medicine, and I did too.

**EXERCISE 7** **Practice: gap-fills, transformation, error correction**

1. Gap-fill: The lights are off; the caretaker … have gone home. (near-certainty)
2. Gap-fill: You … have submitted the form late; now you will pay a fine. (criticism)
3. Transform without changing meaning: Perhaps she missed the bus. (Use might.)
4. Correct the error: He mustn't have stolen the phone because he was in church.
5. Make concise: Some candidates answered question one; other candidates answered question two.

**SOLUTION** **Practice: gap-fills, transformation, error correction**

1. must — near-certain deduction about the past (must have gone).
2. shouldn't — shouldn't have submitted criticises a past action.
3. She might have missed the bus. (past possibility)
4. He can't have stolen the phone because he was in church. (Deductive impossibility takes can't, never mustn't.)
5. Some candidates answered question one, others question two (ellipsis of the repeated verb phrase answered question).

**KEY POINTS** **Key points**

- Certainty scale: can't < might/may/could < should < must; for the past, add have + past participle.
- The negative of deductive must is can't, never mustn't.
- Needn't have done = done but unnecessary; didn't need to do = not necessary, usually not done.
- Ellipsis omits recoverable words; substitution replaces them with pro-forms (one, do so, so, not, it).
- After drafting, underline repetitions and replace or omit them: conciseness is a marked GCE skill.

With these grammatical instruments sharpened, we are ready for the next section, where precision of grammar meets precision of format: reconstructive writing — minutes, debates, talks

and lectures.

# 8 RECONSTRUCTIVE WRITING: MINUTES, DEBATES, TALKS AND LECTURES

In the previous section we sharpened our grammatical tools — advanced modals, ellipsis and substitution — which allow us to express ideas concisely and precisely. We now put those tools to work in one of the most characteristic tasks of GCE Paper 2: **reconstructive writing**. In a reconstruction task, the examiners give you raw material — a dialogue, a narrative account, or a jumbled set of notes — and ask you to transform it into a formal document: minutes of a meeting, a report of a debate, or an account of a talk or lecture. The grammar you have just revised (reported speech, the passive voice, ellipsis) is exactly the machinery needed to perform this transformation elegantly.

## 8.1 What Are Minutes?

Imagine the Students' Representative Council of your school meets to discuss the state of the refectory. Two hours of heated discussion follow. A week later, nobody agrees on what was actually decided: the prefect claims one thing, the bursar another. This is precisely why organisations keep **minutes** — an agreed, written memory of the meeting.

DEFINITION **Minutes**

**Minutes** are the official written record of the proceedings and decisions of a meeting, seminar or workshop. They state who was present, what was discussed, what was decided, and who is responsible for each follow-up action. Minutes are written in a formal register, in reported speech (never direct speech), and usually in the past tense, often with the passive voice.

PROPERTY **Formulaic Language of Resolutions**

Decisions in minutes are introduced by fixed, formulaic phrases. The most common are:

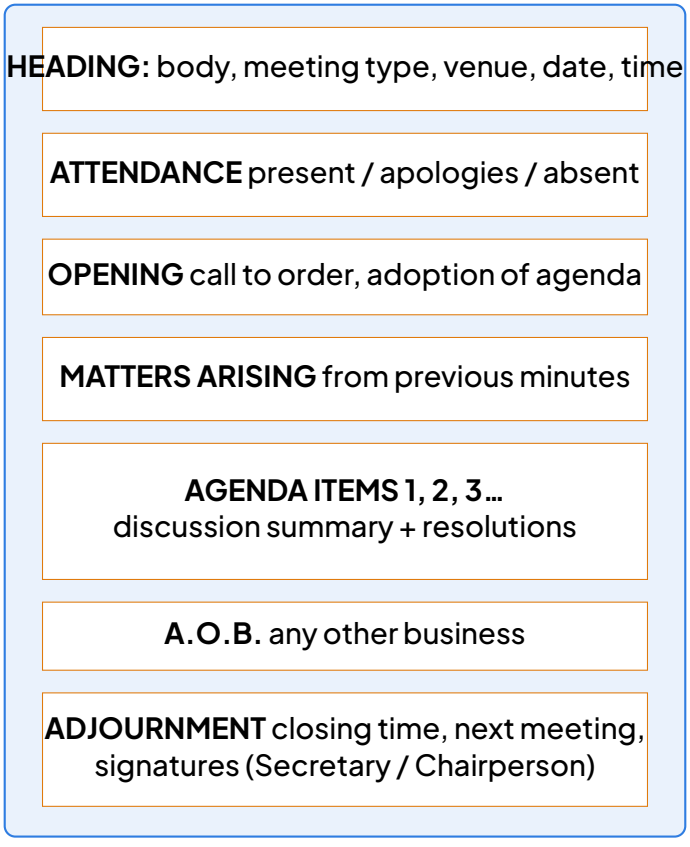
- It was resolved that…
- The meeting agreed that…
- It was decided that…
- The committee unanimously resolved that…
- The motion was carried / adopted / defeated.

Memorising these frames is examinable in practice: examiners award marks for correct formulaic language in Paper 2 reconstruction questions.

## 8.2 The Format of Minutes

Minutes follow a rigid, predictable skeleton. Learn it as a template:

1. **Heading:** name of the body, type of meeting, venue, date and time.
2. **Attendance:** members present (often with their roles); **apologies** from absent members; sometimes absent without apology.
3. **Opening:** the chairperson calls the meeting to order; the agenda is adopted.
4. **Minutes of the previous meeting** are read and confirmed; **matters arising** from them are dealt with.
5. **Agenda items:** each item is numbered; discussions are summarised objectively; resolutions are recorded with the formulaic phrases above.
6. **Any Other Business (A.O.B.):** unplanned matters raised at the end.
7. **Adjournment:** time of closure, date of next meeting, and the signatures of the secretary and chairperson.




Template of a minutes document with its labelled zones.

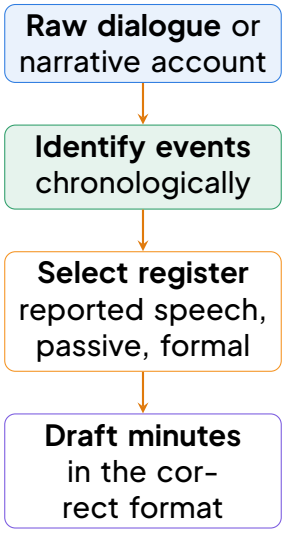
## 8.3 The Method of Reconstruction

METHOD **From Raw Material to Finished Minutes**

1. Read the whole passage (dialogue or narrative) once to grasp the event: who met, where, when, why.
2. List the events chronologically: opening, each topic discussed, each decision, closure.
3. Classify each item: is it a discussion (views exchanged), a decision/resolution (agreed outcome), or an action point (a task assigned to a named person)?
4. Convert all direct speech to reported speech, using the past tense and the passive voice where natural (The bursar explained that…; It was suggested that…).
5. Impose the format: heading, attendance, numbered agenda items, A.O.B., adjournment.
6. Check the register: remove slang, contractions, interjections and emotional language; keep the tone neutral and objective.

WARNING **The Cardinal Sin of Reconstruction**

The most common and most costly mistake is copying the dialogue instead of reporting it. Minutes never contain direct speech, quotation marks, or dramatic detail ("No way!" shouted Musa is impossible in minutes). Equally wrong: inventing decisions the passage does not contain, omitting the attendance list, or writing in the present tense. Report, summarise, format — never transcribe.




The reconstruction pipeline: from raw dialogue to finished minutes.

## 8.4 Distinguishing Discussions, Decisions and Action Points

A skilled minutes-writer separates three kinds of content, each with its own grammar:

| Type | Typical language | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Discussion | Members expressed concern that…; It was pointed out that… | Some members felt that the refectory prices were too high. |
| Decision | It was resolved that…; The meeting agreed that… | It was resolved that prices be frozen for one term. |
| Action point | X was asked to…; X undertook to… | The bursar was asked to negotiate with suppliers. |

Notice the grammar of the decision row: after *It was resolved that*, formal English prefers the **subjunctive** (*that prices* **be** *frozen*, *that the bursar* **negotiate**) or *should* + infinitive (*that prices should be frozen*). Both are correct; the indicative (*that prices were frozen*) is acceptable but less elegant in minutes.

## 8.5 Reconstructing Debates

A debate reconstruction follows its own logic. Identify and report, in order:

1. the **motion** (*The motion before the house was: "Boarding schools should be abolished."*);
2. the **proposers** and **opposers**, with a neutral summary of each speaker's main arguments;
3. the **verdict**: the vote, the judges' decision, or the moderator's closing remarks.

Attribute arguments fairly (*The first proposer argued that…*; *In response, the lead opposer contended that…*) and never take sides: the reporter is invisible. Note that the motion itself is conventionally quoted word for word — this is the one place where quotation marks are legitimate in a reconstruction.

**EXEMPLE** **Reporting a Debate — Model Paragraph**

The motion before the house was: "Social media does more harm than good to Cameroonian youth." The first proposer argued that social media distracted students from their studies and spread misinformation. The lead opposer countered that the same platforms gave young people access to scholarships, revision groups and civic information. After contributions from the floor, the motion was put to the vote and was defeated by 42 votes to 31.

## 8.6 Reconstructing Talks and Lectures

For a talk, seminar or lecture, report: the **speaker** (name, title, institution), the **occasion and audience**, the **main points** in logical order, any **visual aids or demonstrations**, and the **question-and-answer session** (In response to a question from a participant, the speaker clarified that…). Conclude with the vote of thanks or closing remarks.

**EXEMPLE** **Reporting a Talk — Model Opening**

On Friday 14 March, Dr Ewusi, an agronomist from the University of Buea, delivered a talk on climate-smart agriculture to the Upper Sixth science students in the school hall. Using charts and soil samples, she explained how crop rotation and drought-resistant varieties could protect farm yields in the South West Region. During the question-and-answer session, she advised students interested in agricultural careers to consider the newly created colleges of agriculture.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 9** **Reconstructing Minutes from a Dialogue**

Statement. Reconstruct the minutes of the following meeting.
"I declare this meeting of the Form Five Science Club open," said the president, Amina, at 4 p.m. on Tuesday in Lab 2. "Only six of us are here; Tabe sends his apologies — he is unwell. First point: the science fair." "We need 50,000 francs for materials," said the treasurer, Bih. "That is too much!" objected Ngong. "Let us organise a sponsored walk instead of asking the school." "Good idea," said Amina. "All agreed? Yes. Bih, please cost the materials and report next week. Any other business? None. Meeting closed at 5.15 p.m."

**SOLUTION**

Solution (model minutes).
MINUTES OF THE MEETING OF THE FORM FIVE SCIENCE CLUB
held in Laboratory 2 on Tuesday at 4.00 p.m.
Present: Amina (President), Bih (Treasurer), Ngong, and three other members. Apolo-

gies: Tabe (indisposed).
1. Opening. The President called the meeting to order at 4.00 p.m.
2. Science Fair. The Treasurer informed the meeting that 50,000 FCFA would be needed for materials. Concern was expressed that the amount was too high, and it was suggested that a sponsored walk be organised rather than requesting funds from the school. It was resolved that a sponsored walk be held to raise the funds. The Treasurer was asked to cost the materials and report at the next meeting.
3. A.O.B. No other business was raised.
4. Adjournment. The meeting was adjourned at 5.15 p.m.
Secretary President
Commentary. Observe how every trace of the original dialogue has disappeared: no quotation marks, no exclamations, no "Good idea". Ngong's objection becomes the neutral Concern was expressed that…; Amina's informal "All agreed? Yes" becomes the formulaic It was resolved that…; and the instruction to Bih becomes an action point in the passive voice.

**EXERCISE 8** **Timed Practice — GCE Style**

In 50 minutes, reconstruct the minutes of a Parent-Teacher Association executive meeting described in a narrative passage provided by your teacher. Your minutes must include: a full heading, attendance and apologies, at least three numbered agenda items, one resolution using It was resolved that…, one action point, and an adjournment. Then exchange scripts and mark a partner's work against this checklist.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise: marking guide**

Award marks as follows: correct heading and attendance (4), chronological coverage of all events (4), at least one formulaic resolution (3), one clearly assigned action point (3), consistent reported speech and past tense with no direct speech (4), formal objective register throughout (2). Deduct heavily for any copied dialogue or invented content.

**KEY POINTS** **Key Points**

- Minutes are the official record of a meeting: heading, attendance, agenda items, resolutions, adjournment.
- Reconstruct by listing events chronologically, converting to reported speech, and imposing the format.
- Separate discussions, decisions (It was resolved that…) and action points (X was

asked to…); after resolved that, prefer the subjunctive or should + infinitive.

- Debates: motion (quoted), proposers, opposers, verdict. Talks: speaker, audience, main points, questions.
- Never transcribe dialogue; report it — objectively, formally, in the past tense.

# 9 ADVANCED COMPOSITION: DISCURSIVE ESSAYS, NEWS REPORTS AND REGISTER

In the previous section you learned to reconstruct the record of an event: the minutes of a meeting, the report of a debate, the summary of a lecture. In each case, your task was to be faithful to what was said and to present it in a clear, organised, impersonal form. We now move one step further in your training as advanced writers. The GCE examiner will also ask you to compose original texts of your own: an essay that weighs several sides of a burning national question, or a news report that informs the public about an event in Yaoundé, Bamenda or Buea. To succeed, you must master two things at once: the **structure** of each genre, and the **register** — the level of formality — that each genre demands. This section teaches you both.

## 9.1 The Discursive Essay: Exploring Multiple Perspectives

Imagine a class debate on the motion: "Boarding schools should be abolished in Cameroon." Some students argue passionately for the motion; others reject it completely. Now imagine that instead of taking one side, you are asked to examine the whole question fairly — to present the strongest arguments on each side, weigh them, and only then give your own considered view. That is exactly what a discursive essay does.

DEFINITION **The Discursive Essay**

A **discursive essay** is a balanced piece of writing that examines several viewpoints on a controversial issue — presenting arguments for and against with supporting evidence and examples — before the writer reaches a reasoned personal conclusion in the final paragraph.

The discursive essay differs from the purely argumentative essay you met earlier. In an argumentative essay, you defend one position from the first line. In a discursive essay, you act like a **fair judge**: you listen to both parties, evaluate the evidence, and deliver a verdict only at the end. The examiner rewards maturity of thought — the ability to see that real issues (social media, examinations, tradition versus modernity) are rarely black and white.

METHOD **Structuring a Discursive Essay**

Follow this five-move plan:

1. Introduction: present the issue and show that it is controversial. Do not state your opinion yet. A useful frame: "Few questions divide opinion in Cameroon today as sharply as the question of…"
2. Arguments for: devote one or two paragraphs to the strongest arguments on one side, each supported by an example, a fact or a logical consequence. Use signposts: On the one hand…; Supporters argue that…; It is often claimed that…
3. Arguments against: devote one or two paragraphs to the opposing side, with the same fairness and the same quality of support. Signposts: On the other hand…; Critics, however, point out that…
4. Weighing (optional but impressive): a short paragraph comparing the two sets of arguments: which are stronger, and why?
5. Conclusion — your personal stance: state your own position clearly, summarising the reasoning that led you there: Having considered both sides, I am convinced that…

EXEMPLE **A Model "Weighing" Paragraph**

Notice how a single paragraph can compare the two sides before the conclusion: "Both camps, it must be admitted, argue from genuine concern. Parents who defend mobile phones in school are thinking of safety and of their children's digital future; teachers who demand a ban are thinking of concentration and of the integrity of examinations. Yet the two concerns are not equally weighty. A phone can be switched off during a lesson, but a lesson once lost to distraction cannot be recovered. It is the argument about misuse, therefore, that tips the balance — though it does not justify a total prohibition." Observe the signposts of balance (it must be admitted; yet; therefore) and the way the writer prepares the personal stance without yet stating it fully.

WARNING **Common Mistakes in Discursive Essays**

- Declaring your opinion in the introduction — this turns the essay into an argumentative one and destroys the suspense of balanced inquiry.
- Presenting one side strongly and the other side weakly (a "straw man"). Both sides must be argued seriously.
- Listing arguments without development. Each argument needs an explanation and an example.

- Ending without a personal stance. The conclusion must take a position; "it depends" is not a conclusion.

## 9.2 Register Analysis: Formal, Neutral and Informal Styles

Consider how you would report the same piece of news — that you cannot attend school tomorrow — in three situations: to your best friend on WhatsApp, to your classmate in a short note, and to your Principal in a letter. You might write: "Can't make it tmrw, sorry!" / "I won't be at school tomorrow." / "I regret to inform you that I shall be unable to attend classes tomorrow owing to a family commitment." The message is identical; the **register** is different.

**DEFINITION** **Register**

**Register** is the level of formality of language, determined by three variables: the audience (to whom am I writing or speaking?), the purpose (to inform, persuade, request, entertain?), and the context (a courtroom, a classroom, a market, a chat with friends?). Choosing the wrong register — slang in a formal letter, or stiff officialese in a friendly note — is a serious fault at Advanced Level.

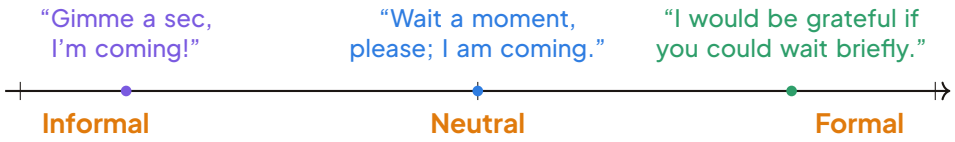
**PROPERTY** **Markers of the Formal Register**

The formal register is characterised by:

- No contractions: write do not, cannot, it is — never don't, can't, it's.
- No slang or colloquialisms: children, not kids; police officers, not cops.
- Single-word verbs preferred to phrasal verbs where an equivalent exists: request (not ask for), tolerate (not put up with), investigate (not look into), postpone (not put off).
- Longer, well-structured sentences, often with subordination and passive constructions: The matter is being investigated.
- Impersonal tone and formal address forms: Dear Sir/Madam, Yours faithfully, It would appear that…

(Not examinable as a "proof", but you must be able to apply these markers in your own writing and identify them in comprehension passages.)

| Variable | Informal | Neutral | Formal |
|---|---|---|---|
| Vocabulary | kids, bucks, awesome | children, money, very good | minors, funds, exemplary |
| Contractions | can't, won't, it's | generally avoided in writing | do not, will not, it is |
| Phrasal verbs | put up with, find out | tolerate, discover | tolerate, ascertain |
| Sentence length | short, fragmented | medium | longer, subordinated |
| Address forms | Hi Paul! | Dear Paul, | Dear Dr Nkeng, / Dear Sir, |
| Typical context | chat, diary, SMS | note, class essay | official letter, report, speech |




The register continuum: the same request expressed at three levels of formality.

**WARNING** **Register Is a Continuum, Not a Switch**

Do not imagine that a text is either "formal" or "informal" with nothing between. Most good examination writing — essays, reports, formal letters — sits in the formal-to-neutral zone: correct, impersonal, but not pompous. Overly stiff language ("I humbly beseech your esteemed indulgence…") is as much a fault as slang, because it sounds unnatural and insincere. Aim for dignified clarity.

## 9.3 Writing News Reports: The Inverted Pyramid

Pick up any serious newspaper — Cameroon Tribune, for instance — and read only the **first paragraph** of a front-page story. You will discover that this single paragraph, called the **lead**, already tells you the essentials of the event. The following paragraphs merely add detail and background. This is the famous **inverted pyramid**: the most important information comes first, the least important last, so that a reader (or an editor cutting for space) can stop anywhere and still have the story.

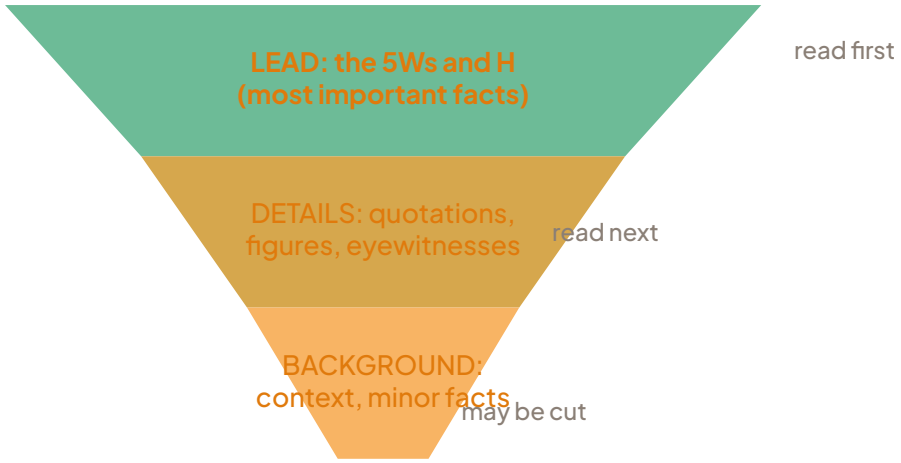
**METHOD** **Writing the Lead: The 5Ws and H**

Your opening paragraph (one or two sentences, maximum about 35 words) must answer:

1. Who is involved?

2. What happened?
3. When did it happen?
4. Where did it happen?
5. Why did it happen (if known)?
6. How did it happen (if known)?

Then develop: paragraph 2 gives details and quotations from witnesses or officials; paragraph 3 gives background and context; the final lines give minor or related information.




The inverted pyramid of news report structure: lead, then details, then background.

Two more features complete the genre. The **headline** is short, punchy, usually in the present tense, and omits articles: "Fire Destroys Bamenda Market Stalls". And **objectivity** governs everything: the reporter reports; he does not judge.

**WARNING** **Objectivity: The Hallmark of the News Report**

The most common and most costly mistake is injecting personal opinion into a news report. Never write "This shameful incident shows that our authorities are careless." That is an editorial comment. In a news report, attribute every judgement to a named source: "Residents blamed the authorities for the delay." Report facts, attribute opinions, and keep yourself invisible.

It is essential to distinguish the three journalistic genres the examiner may set:

| Genre | Purpose | Person and tone |
|---|---|---|
| News report | inform quickly and objectively | third person; neutral; facts first |
| Editorial | give the newspaper's opinion | first person plural (we); persuasive |
| Feature article | explore a topic in depth, human interest | descriptive, narrative; may be personal |

**WORKED EXAMPLE 10** **One Event, Three Registers and a News Report**

Task. Event: a burst water pipe flooded Commercial Avenue, Bamenda, on Monday morning, forcing shops to close for three hours; the water corporation repaired it by noon. (a) Write one sentence on the event in informal, neutral and formal registers. (b) Write the lead of a news report.

**SOLUTION**

Solution.

- Informal (message to a friend): "You won't believe it — a pipe burst on Commercial Ave this morning and the whole place was flooded; shops had to shut for hours!"
- Neutral (classroom announcement): "A water pipe burst on Commercial Avenue this morning. The street was flooded and shops closed for about three hours."
- Formal (letter to the council): "I wish to draw your attention to the flooding of Commercial Avenue on Monday morning, occasioned by a burst water main, which compelled traders to suspend business for approximately three hours."
- News report lead: "Shops along Commercial Avenue in Bamenda were forced to close for three hours on Monday morning after a burst water pipe flooded the street, before repair teams from the water corporation restored supply by noon." — Note how the lead answers Who (traders, repair teams), What (flooding, closures), When (Monday morning), Where (Commercial Avenue, Bamenda), Why (burst pipe) and How (flooding; repaired by noon), with no personal comment.

**EXERCISE 9** **Discursive Essay and News Report Practice**

1. Write a discursive essay (about 450 words) on: "Should mobile phones be allowed in secondary schools?" Follow the five-move plan and state your personal stance only in the conclusion.
2. Rewrite this informal sentence in the formal register: "The minister said they'd look into the water problem and sort it out soon."
3. Write the headline and lead of a news report on: your school's inter-house sports competition held last Friday, won by Blue House.

SOLUTION **Exercise 1**

1. A model outline: Introduction — phones are now part of daily life; their place in school divides parents, teachers and students. For — phones aid research, allow parents to reach children in emergencies, and teach digital responsibility. Against — they distract from lessons, encourage examination malpractice and cyberbullying, and widen the gap between rich and poor students. Weighing — the strongest argument is misuse during examinations, but total bans ignore educational benefits. Conclusion (stance) — phones should be allowed but strictly regulated: switched off during lessons and examinations. 2. "The minister announced that the water problem would be investigated and resolved in the near future." (No contraction, investigated for look into, resolved for sort out, passive for objectivity.) 3. Headline: "Blue House Wins Inter-House Sports Trophy". Lead: "Blue House on Friday emerged overall champions of this year's inter-house sports competition of GBHS Anytown, amassing the highest points in track and field events before a large crowd of students, staff and parents on the school campus."

KEY POINTS **Key Points of This Section**

- A **discursive essay** examines both sides fairly and reserves the personal stance for the conclusion.
- **Register** depends on audience, purpose and context; formal writing avoids contractions, slang and phrasal verbs.
- A **news report** follows the inverted pyramid: a lead answering the 5Ws and H, then details, then background — always objective, with opinions attributed to sources.
- Do not confuse news reports (inform) with editorials (give opinion) and features (explore in depth).

## 10 CRITICAL REASONING, RHETORIC AND VISUAL STIMULI

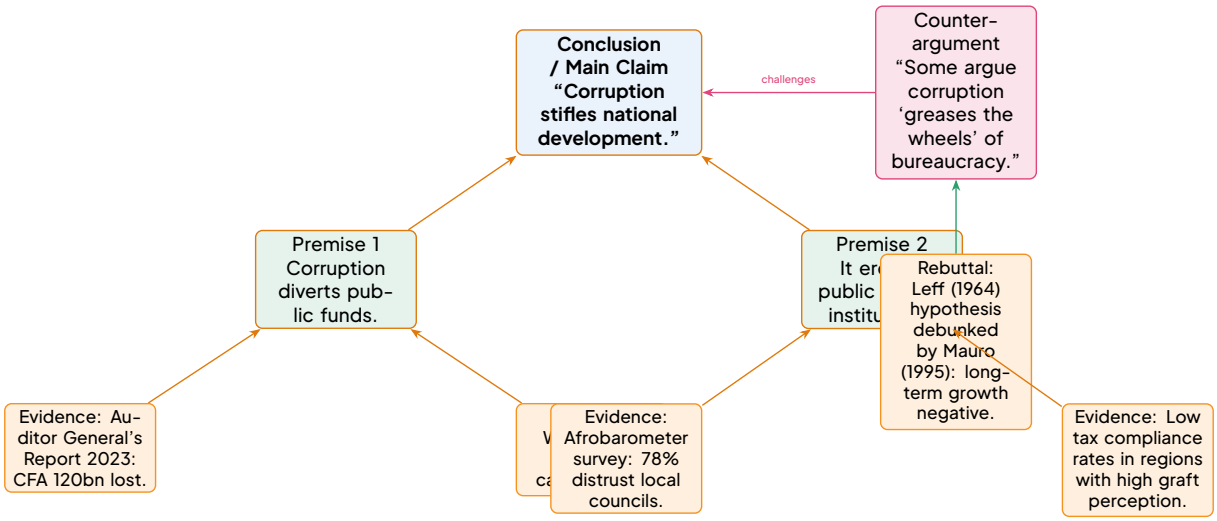
In the previous section, we mastered the architecture of discursive essays, the objectivity of news reports, and the precision of register control. We now turn to the engine that drives all persuasive and analytical writing: critical reasoning. Whether you are evaluating a stimulus text in Paper 1, constructing a counter-argument in Paper 2, or interpreting a cartoon in Paper 3, your success depends on your ability to dissect reasoning, recognise rhetorical craft, and decode visual messages. This section equips you with the toolkit of the critical thinker and the polished writer.

## 10.1 Evaluating Arguments: Anatomy of Reasoning

Every argument, from a newspaper editorial to a student's essay, rests on a structural skeleton. To evaluate it, you must first map it.

**DEFINITION** **Argument Structure**

An argument is a set of statements where one (the **conclusion**) is claimed to follow from the others (the **premises**). The connection between premises and conclusion is the **inference**. **Evidence** (facts, statistics, expert testimony, examples) supports the premises. A **claim** is an assertion that requires proof; a premise is a claim offered as a reason for the conclusion.




Argument map: claim supported by premises and evidence; counter-argument with rebuttal.

**PROPERTY** **The Strong Argument Principle**

A strong argument does not merely stack premises; it anticipates and refutes the strongest counter-argument. In GCE essays, a paragraph acknowledging the opposing view (concession) followed by a robust refutation earns top marks for critical maturity.

**EXEMPLE** **Mapping an Argument**

Stimulus: "The government's new tax on mobile money transfers is unjust. It hits the poor hardest because they rely on mobile money for daily transactions. The rich use banks. Therefore, the tax widens inequality."
Map:

- Conclusion: The mobile money tax is unjust (widens inequality).
- Premise 1: The tax hits the poor hardest.
- Premise 2: The poor rely on mobile money; the rich use banks.
- Evidence needed: Data on mobile money user demographics vs. bank account ownership; Gini coefficient impact studies.
- Implicit assumption (warrant): A policy that disproportionately burdens the poor is unjust.
- Potential counter-argument: The tax broadens the revenue base for social services that benefit the poor.

## 10.2 Detecting Fallacies: Errors in Reasoning

A **fallacy** is an error in reasoning that renders an argument invalid, unsound, or misleading. Spotting them is essential for Paper 1 comprehension (evaluating the writer's logic) and Paper 2 (avoiding them in your own essays).

DEFINITION **Fallacy**

A fallacy is a defect in an argument that arises from faulty reasoning, irrelevant appeals, or deceptive language, making the conclusion unreliable even if the premises are true.

| Fallacy | Definition & Mechanism | Example (Cameroon Context) |
|---|---|---|
| **Hasty Generalisation** | Drawing a broad conclusion from a small, unrepresentative sample. | "My neighbour's son studied in Nigeria and failed. Therefore, Nigerian universities are sub-standard." |
| **False Cause (Post Hoc)** | Assuming that because B followed A, A caused B. Confusing correlation with causation. | "The President visited the region; two weeks later, a bridge collapsed. Therefore, the visit caused the collapse." |
| **Ad Hominem** | Attacking the person making the argument rather than the argument itself. | "Don't listen to Prof. X's critique of the curriculum; he was once disciplined for late marking." |
| **Appeal to Emotion** | Manipulating feelings (pity, fear, patriotism) to bypass logical scrutiny. | "If you oppose this law, you don't love Cameroon. Think of the children!" |
| **Straw Man** | Misrepresenting an opponent's position to make it easier to attack. | "My opponent wants to reform the exam board? So he wants to abolish standards entirely!" |
| **False Dilemma** | Presenting only two extreme options, ignoring a spectrum. | "Either we ban all street vending or our cities drown in chaos." |
| **Slippery Slope** | Claiming a small step will inevitably lead to a catastrophic chain reaction without evidence. | "If we allow students to choose one elective, next they'll demand no exams, then the system collapses." |

**WARNING** **Common Mistake: Labelling vs. Explaining**

In Paper 1, writing "This is an ad hominem fallacy" earns zero marks without explanation. You must: (1) Identify the fallacy by name, (2) Quote the specific words, (3) Explain why it is fallacious (what logic is violated), and (4) State the effect on the reader/argument.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 11** **Fallacy Detection**

Passage: "The Minister of Education proposes extending school hours. But we all know he sent his own children to private schools abroad. He clearly doesn't care about our public system. This proposal is just another elitist plot to exhaust our children while the elite escape the consequences. We must reject it outright."
Solution:

1. Ad Hominem (Circumstantial): "He sent his own children to private schools abroad." The arguer attacks the Minister's personal choices rather than the merits of extended

hours. The Minister's hypocrisy (if true) does not logically invalidate the policy.

2. Poisoning the Well / Appeal to Emotion: "Elitist plot to exhaust our children." Loaded language ("plot", "exhaust") triggers fear and class resentment, substituting rhetoric for evidence on educational outcomes.
3. Straw Man: The proposal is "extending school hours"; the attack frames it as a malicious "plot", a distortion.
4. Effect: The reader is manipulated to reject the proposal based on distrust of the Minister, not on pedagogical evidence.

## 10.3 Assessing Evidence: Relevance, Sufficiency, Credibility, Bias

Not all evidence is created equal. As a critical reader (Paper 1) and writer (Paper 2), you must interrogate evidence using four criteria.

**KEY POINTS** **The RSCB Test for Evidence**

- R – Relevance: Does the evidence directly support this specific claim? (Irrelevant data is a red herring.)
- S – Sufficiency: Is there enough evidence? One anecdote ≠ proof of a trend. Statistical significance matters.
- C – Credibility: Is the source authoritative, primary, recent, and peer-reviewed? (e.g., World Bank > anonymous blog; 2023 report > 1998 report on tech.)
- B – Bias / Balance: Does the source have a vested interest? Is contrary evidence acknowledged? (e.g., a mining company's environmental impact report vs. an independent NGO audit.)

**EXEMPLE** **Applying RSCB**

Claim: "Cameroon's cocoa sector is booming." Evidence offered: "My uncle in Mbang says he sold his crop at a record price last week."

- Relevance: Low. One farmer's price ≠ sector performance.
- Sufficiency: Fail. Sample size $n = 1$.
- Credibility: Low. Anecdotal, hearsay, no verification.
- Bias: High. Uncle may exaggerate; no counter-data (e.g., global price dip, black pod disease).

Better evidence: "MINADER 2023 report: 300,000 tonnes exported, up 12% YoY; ICCO data shows Cameroon's market share stable at 5%; farmer income survey (World Bank, 2022) shows 8% real income rise."

### 10.4 Style and Rhetoric: Parallelism, Antithesis, and Repetition

Rhetoric is the art of effective persuasion. Mastering these three devices elevates your writing from competent to compelling — essential for Paper 2 essays and speeches.

**DEFINITION** **Parallelism**

Parallelism is the repetition of the same grammatical structure (words, phrases, clauses, sentences) to create rhythm, balance, and emphasis. It makes ideas visibly equal in weight.

**EXEMPLE** **Parallelism in Action**

Faulty (non-parallel): "The programme aims to train teachers, providing textbooks, and that classrooms are renovated." (Gerund, gerund, passive clause — clunky.) Parallel (gerunds): "The programme aims to training teachers, providing textbooks, and renovating classrooms." Parallel (infinitives): "The programme aims to train teachers, to provide textbooks, and to renovate classrooms." Parallel (clauses - rhetorical power): "We shall fight in the classrooms, we shall fight in the staffrooms, we shall fight in the ministries until every child has a desk."

## 11 MOCK EXAMINATIONS AND FINAL EXAMINATION TECHNIQUES

You have now revised critical reasoning, rhetoric, and the interpretation of visual stimuli. All the skills of the year — comprehension, summary, composition, grammar, phonology, and literature — are in place. What remains is the final and decisive stage: learning to perform under examination conditions. A candidate who knows the content but mismanages time, misreads the rubric, or panics in the hall will underperform. This section therefore trains you to sit full mock examinations for Papers 1, 2 and 3, to understand how examiners award marks, and to enter the real examination room with a calm, rehearsed strategy.

### 11.1 Understanding the Three GCE Papers

Before you can manage your time, you must know exactly what each paper demands. The GCE Advanced Level English Language examination is traditionally organised into three papers, each

testing a different cluster of skills.

| Paper | Sections and question types | Skills tested | Time |
|---|---|---|---|
| Paper 1 | Essay writing (composition from a choice of topics); language use (grammar, vocabulary, register, sentence transformation) | Fluency, organisation, grammatical accuracy, appropriateness of register | about 3 hours |
| Paper 2 | Reading comprehension; summary writing; reconstruction of texts (minutes, reports, dialogues) | Understanding, selection of relevant points, concision, text-format mastery | about 3 hours |
| Paper 3 | Literature: prose, drama, and poetry (essay and context questions on prescribed texts) | Knowledge of prescribed texts, literary analysis, relevance of illustration | about 3 hours |

DEFINITION **Rubric**

The **rubric** is the set of instructions printed on an examination paper that tells candidates exactly what they must do: how many questions to answer, from which sections, and any special conditions (for example, "Answer one question from this section" or "Do not answer more than one question on the same text").

WARNING **The Rubric Is Law**

The single most destructive examination error is ignoring the rubric. If a paper says "Answer three questions" and you answer five, the examiners mark only the required number — usually the first ones attempted — and the extra work earns nothing. Similarly, answering two questions from a section that permits only one means one of your answers is discarded. Read the rubric twice before writing a single word, and obey it to the letter. A related error is leaving a required question unattempted: a blank answer scores zero, whereas even a modest attempt almost always earns some marks. If time runs short, write a brief plan or a skeleton answer rather than nothing at all.

## 11.2 How Examiners Mark: The Four Criteria

GCE examiners do not mark by vague impression. For essays and literature answers especially, scripts are assessed against four broad criteria:

1. **Content**: the relevance, richness and development of your ideas. Do you actually answer the question set, with well-chosen points and illustrations?
2. **Organisation**: the logical arrangement of your answer — introduction, coherent paragraphs, clear progression, conclusion.

3. **Expression**: the quality of your English — vocabulary range, sentence variety, fluency, and appropriateness of tone and register.
4. **Mechanical accuracy**: spelling, punctuation, capitalisation, and grammar.

PROPERTY **Expression and Accuracy Always Count**

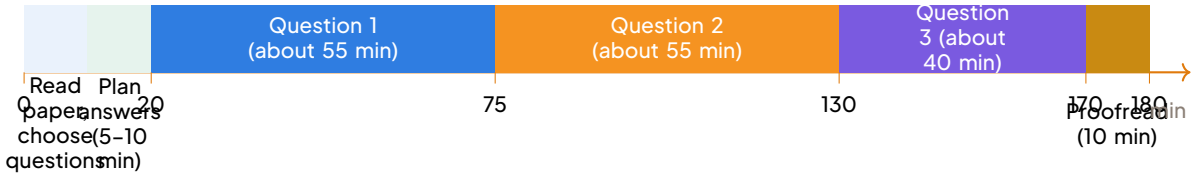
In every paper of the GCE English Language examination, **expression** and **mechanical accuracy** carry marks. A script full of brilliant ideas but riddled with spelling errors, broken sentences and illegible handwriting will lose marks. Conversely, a modest answer written in clean, correct, well-paragraphed English is rewarded. Proofreading is therefore not a luxury: it is a marks-earning activity.

EXEMPLE **The Same Ideas, Two Scripts**

Two candidates answer the same essay topic on examination malpractice. Candidate A has excellent ideas but writes "the goverment should purnish student which cheat" throughout, with no paragraphs. Candidate B has simpler ideas but writes in clear paragraphs: "The government should punish students who cheat." Candidate B will score higher on expression, organisation and mechanical accuracy — often enough to overtake Candidate A entirely. The lesson: how you write is worth as much as what you write.

## 11.3 Time Management: Minutes per Question and per Mark

A three-hour paper feels long until you are inside it. The golden rule is to **allocate time in proportion to marks**: a question worth 20 marks deserves roughly twice the time of one worth 10. Build in planning time at the start and proofreading time at the end, and never let one question consume another question's time.




Recommended time blocks for a 3-hour (180-minute) paper with three questions. Adapt the block sizes to the mark scheme of each paper, but always protect the planning and proofreading blocks.

METHOD **The Exam-Room Routine**

1. Read the whole paper and the rubric carefully (about 5 minutes). Note how many questions are required from each section.
2. Choose wisely: select the questions you can answer best, not the ones that merely look short. For essays, pick the topic on which you have the most ideas and the clearest plan.
3. Plan for 5 to 10 minutes: jot down your points in order (for an essay: introduction, three or four developed paragraphs, conclusion; for literature: argument plus textual evidence).
4. Write, keeping to your plan and watching the clock. Leave a line between paragraphs and write legibly.
5. Move on when a question's time is up, even mid-sentence if necessary; you can return in the proofreading block if time remains.
6. Reserve the last 10 minutes to proofread: correct spelling, punctuation, verb agreement, and any missing words. Cross out neatly with a single line; never use correction fluid to hide whole paragraphs.

## 11.4 Paper 1 Mock: Essay and Language Use

Paper 1 tests your productive command of English. Under full timed conditions, you write one composition chosen from several topics (narrative, descriptive, discursive, letter, speech, report or article) and answer language-use items.

**Guided marking focus.** When your mock is marked, check: Did you respect the text type (a speech needs an address and an audience; a formal letter needs addresses, date, salutation, subscription)? Is each paragraph one developed idea? Is the register appropriate to the topic and audience? Are tenses consistent?

EXEMPLE **Choosing the Right Topic**

Suppose Paper 1 offers: (a) a narrative beginning "The phone rang at midnight…"; (b) a discursive essay: "Boarding school is better than day school. Discuss"; (c) a speech on indiscipline in schools. A candidate who tells stories vividly but argues weakly should choose (a); a candidate strong in balanced argument should choose (b). The wise candidate spends two minutes matching the topic to personal strength — this choice alone can be worth several marks in content and expression.

WARNING **Text-Type Amnesia**

Under pressure, many candidates begin a speech or letter correctly and then forget the

format halfway through. A speech must keep addressing its audience ("Mr Chairman, ladies and gentlemen…") to the end, and a letter must close with the correct subscription ("Yours faithfully," with "Dear Sir"; "Yours sincerely," with a named person). Write the skeleton of the format in your plan so the structure survives your nerves.

## 11.5 Paper 2 Mock: Comprehension, Summary and Reconstruction

Paper 2 is a paper of discipline: every answer must come from the passage, not from your own opinions.

- **Comprehension**: read the questions before the passage, so you read with purpose. Answer in your own words unless the question asks for a quotation, and never lift whole sentences when the question says "in your own words".
- **Summary**: identify only the points the question asks for (e.g. "the causes" or "the effects" — not both). Write in continuous prose if required, within the word limit, using your own words and correct grammar. One sentence per point is a safe rhythm.
- **Reconstruction**: reproduce the correct format — minutes need a heading, attendance, agenda items and resolutions; a report needs a title, terms of reference, findings and recommendations. Format itself earns marks.

**WARNING** **Summary Traps**

Do not exceed the word limit (examiners stop reading at the limit); do not include examples, repetitions or figures of speech from the passage; do not add your own opinion. A summary that copies the passage's phrases wholesale is penalised for poor expression even if the points are correct.

## 11.6 Paper 3 Mock: Literature — Prose, Drama and Poetry

Paper 3 rewards knowledge deployed selectively. The examiner already knows the texts; what is tested is whether you can use them to answer the precise question.

- **Answer the question set**, not the one you revised. If the question asks about the theme of corruption in a play, do not retell the plot: argue the theme and support each claim with a brief, well-chosen reference or quotation.
- **Context questions**: identify who speaks, to whom, when in the text, and — above all — the significance of the passage (what it reveals about character, theme or style).
- **Poetry**: comment on the writer's craft — imagery, diction, rhythm, tone, structure — and link every observation to meaning.
- Distribute your answers across the required number of texts; never write two answers on the same text if the rubric forbids it.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 12** **Planning a Literature Answer Under Time Pressure**

Question (Paper 3): "Discuss the poet's use of contrast to convey his message in Rudyard Kipling's If." Show the 5-minute plan a strong candidate would produce.

**SOLUTION**

Plan (about 5 minutes):

1. Introduction (2 lines): The poem is built on a chain of contrasts — "If you can keep your head when all about you / Are losing theirs" — each one opposing the mature man to the weak one; the message is a code of stoic manhood.
2. Paragraph 1 — self versus crowd: "keep your head…losing theirs"; "trust yourself when all men doubt you". Contrast teaches independence of mind.
3. Paragraph 2 — extremes of fortune: "Triumph and Disaster…those two impostors"; "kings" versus "the common touch". Balance and humility.
4. Paragraph 3 — effort versus ruin: building with "worn-out tools"; losing "winnings" on "one turn of pitch-and-toss". Resilience.
5. Conclusion: the accumulated contrasts culminate in "you'll be a Man, my son" — contrast is the poem's very structure and its moral engine.

This plan guarantees relevance (every paragraph answers "contrast"), textual support (short quotations), and a clear organisation — the three things the marking scheme rewards.

## 11.7 The Writer's Craft: Final Revision of Prescribed Texts

In the last weeks, revise every prescribed text through three lenses:

1. **Language**: diction, imagery, figurative devices, register, rhythm. Ask: what effect does each device create?
2. **Form**: the type of text — novel, play, sonnet, free verse, dramatic monologue — and how the form shapes meaning (e.g. the tight structure of If mirrors its message of self-control).
3. **Structure**: how the work is organised — stanzas, acts and scenes, chapters, narrative chronology, climax and resolution — and how structure builds tension or argument.

For each of the poems in the Cosmic Anthology and each prose and drama text, prepare a one-page card: author, form, two or three themes, three key quotations, and two distinctive stylistic features. These cards are your last-week revision gold.

## 11.8 Final Review Checklists and Common Pitfalls

KEY POINTS **Final Checklist**

- Prescribed texts: I can state the plot, main characters, themes and style of each prose and drama text, and the theme, form and key lines of each poem.
- Formats: I can reproduce from memory the layout of formal and informal letters, speeches, reports, articles, minutes, memoranda and curriculum vitae.
- Language: I have revised modals, ellipsis and substitution, concord, tenses, reported speech, weak forms and rhythm.
- Technique: I know the rubric habits of each paper, my time blocks, and the four marking criteria.
- Materials: pens (two), and I know my candidate number and centre.

METHOD **Self-Assessment After Each Mock**

1. Mark your script strictly with the official-style scheme (content, organisation, expression, mechanical accuracy).
2. Classify every lost mark: was it lost for content (irrelevance, thin ideas), organisation (no paragraphs, no plan), expression (weak vocabulary, monotony), or accuracy (spelling, concord, punctuation)?
3. Identify your weakest category and target it in the next practice: e.g. if accuracy dominates, do daily error-correction drills; if content dominates, practise 5-minute plans on past questions.
4. Re-sit the same paper a week later and compare scores to measure progress.

## 11.9 Stress Management and Examination-Room Technique

DID YOU KNOW? **Exam-Useful: Managing Nerves**

Moderate nervousness sharpens concentration; panic destroys it. Practical techniques used by successful candidates: arrive at the centre early with all materials; breathe slowly (in for four counts, out for four) before opening the paper; if your mind goes blank on a question, leave a space, move to the next question, and return later — memory usually unblocks once anxiety drops. Sleep well the night before rather than cramming until dawn: a tired brain loses more marks in expression and accuracy than last-minute revision could ever gain.

**EXERCISE 10** **Full Mock and Self-Assessment**

1. Sit a complete past Paper 2 in 3 hours, without notes, respecting the rubric exactly.
2. Mark it with the scheme, classify every lost mark into the four criteria, and write a three-line action plan for your weakest category.
3. Prepare one-page revision cards (author, form, themes, key quotations, style) for three poems of your choice from the Cosmic Anthology.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise: guidance**

A strong self-assessment might read: "Lost 4 marks in summary (copied phrases — expression), 3 in comprehension (answers not in my own words — content/expression), 2 in reconstruction (missing agenda heading — organisation/format). Action plan: practise paraphrasing daily; memorise the minutes format; re-sit this paper next week." For the poem cards, an entry for If would note: Kipling; didactic poem in four octets; themes of self-mastery, resilience, humility; key lines "If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster / And treat those two impostors just the same"; style: conditional structure, contrast, imperative tone.

**KEY POINTS** **To Remember**

- The **rubric** is law: answer exactly the number of questions required, from the correct sections.
- Marks come from four criteria: **content**, **organisation**, **expression** and **mechanical accuracy** — and the last two count in every paper.
- Allocate time in proportion to marks; protect 5–10 minutes of planning and 10 minutes of proofreading.
- After every mock, classify lost marks and attack the weakest category.
- Revise prescribed texts through language, form and structure, using one-page cards.
- Calm, legible, rubric-obedient scripts beat brilliant but chaotic ones.

# 12 INTEGRATION ACTIVITY

# 13 MODULE THREE REVIEW: GCE SIMULATION WEEK — FROM CANDIDATE TO EXAMINER

## 13.1 Aims of the activity

This integration activity closes Module Three by placing you in the two roles that matter most in June: the **candidate** and the **examiner**. By the end of the week you should be able to:

- sit Paper 1 (Essay and Comprehension), Paper 2 (Literature) and Paper 3 (Language and Structure) under strict, timed, examination conditions;
- apply the chapter's core skills — **register analysis**, **editing**, **critical reasoning**, **ellipsis and substitution**, **advanced modals** — to real scripts rather than to textbook exercises;
- mark a peer's script objectively using a simplified marking scheme, justifying every mark awarded or withheld;
- write a formal **Examiner's Report** identifying strengths and weaknesses in grammar, register, argumentation and rhetorical effectiveness;
- produce a personal **revision portfolio** with an action plan targeting your three weakest areas before the real GCE session.

KEY POINTS **Why this activity matters**

Examiners do not only reward knowledge; they reward control — control of time, of register, of structure, of evidence. Marking another candidate's work is the fastest way to see your own habits from the outside. A student who can diagnose a weak thesis statement in a peer's essay can diagnose it in their own.

## 13.2 Situation

**The GCE Simulation Week at Government Bilingual High School, Mendong.**

It is the third week of May. The Principal of GBHS Mendong has authorised the English Language Department to run a full GCE Simulation Week for the Upper Sixth Arts and Science classes before study leave begins. The Head of Department, Mr. Ebai, has announced the following programme to your class of 42 candidates:

| Day | Activity | Conditions |
|---|---|---|
| Monday, 8.00–11.00 | Paper 1 mock: one essay (discursive or narrative/descriptive choice) and one comprehension passage with summary | 3 hours, silence, invigilated, no dictionaries |
| Tuesday, 8.00–11.00 | Paper 2 mock: one essay on a prescribed prose/drama text and one poetry question on the Cosmic Anthology | 3 hours, texts not allowed |
| Wednesday, 8.00–10.30 | Paper 3 mock: guided writing (minutes of a meeting or a news report or a speech) plus a language-awareness section | 2 hours 30 minutes |
| Thursday | Anonymous exchange of scripts; group marking with simplified marking schemes | Groups of four, supervised |
| Friday | Writing of individual Examiner's Reports and personal action plans; class debriefing | One page per report |

To make the simulation authentic, Mr. Ebai has imposed three rules borrowed from the real session:

1. Scripts are identified by candidate numbers only, never by names.
2. Any script left unfinished when time is called is collected as it stands — exactly as in the real examination hall.
3. Markers must justify every band they award with at least one quotation from the script.

On Thursday morning, your group of four receives a sealed envelope containing four anonymous Paper 1 essays. The essay you must report on, Candidate 017, answered this discursive question:

EXEMPLE **The question answered by Candidate 017**

"Social media has done more harm than good to the Cameroonian youth." Discuss, giving balanced consideration to at least two opposing viewpoints. (30 marks)

Candidate 017's essay (abridged for study) reads as follows:

EXEMPLE **Extract from Candidate 017's script**

"Social media is very bad. Youths in Cameroon nowadays they spend all their time on

Facebook and WhatsApp instead of studying. This is why results are dropping. You can't deny that it is a big problem, everybody knows it. On the other hand, some people say social media helps students to share documents and past questions. But me, I think the bad side is more. In conclusion, government should ban social media for students, because it is destroying our future, full stop."

Your task is to mark this script, report on it like an examiner, and then turn the same critical eye on your own performance during the week.

## 13.3 Tasks

Work through the following tasks in order. Each one mobilises skills from a different part of the chapter.

1. **Timing and conditions.** Before the mocks begin, draw up a personal time budget for each paper: how many minutes for planning, writing and proofreading in Paper 1? Justify your budget in three sentences, using at least two **advanced modals** of obligation or necessity (must, have to, need to, should).

2. **Comprehension check.** In one paragraph, state exactly what the command word "Discuss" requires of Candidate 017, and list the three features a balanced discursive essay must contain (thesis, counter-argument, weighed conclusion).

3. **Register analysis.** Identify **four** expressions in Candidate 017's extract that are too informal, too vague or too absolute for a discursive essay. For each, propose a formal replacement. Present your answer in a two-column table.

4. **Grammar and conciseness.** The extract contains at least three grammatical or structural faults (e.g. double subject, punctuation misuse, wordiness). Rewrite the first two sentences of the extract correctly, using **ellipsis** or **substitution** where possible to make them more concise.

5. **Critical reasoning.** Evaluate the argument "results are dropping, everybody knows it." What logical fallacies does it commit? Rewrite the claim so that it becomes an acceptable, hedged argument using a modal of probability rather than certainty.

6. **Rhetoric.** Candidate 017's conclusion is abrupt. Write a replacement conclusion of 60–80 words that uses **parallelism** or **antithesis** and ends with a balanced, weighed judgement rather than an extreme proposal.

7. **Marking.** Using the simplified scheme below, award Candidate 017 a mark out of 30, with one quoted justification per criterion.

| Criterion | Descriptor | Marks |
|---|---|---|
| Content and balance | Both sides treated, relevant ideas, weighed conclusion | /10 |
| Organisation | Clear introduction, linked paragraphs, logical progression | /8 |
| Expression and register | Formal register, accurate grammar, varied vocabulary | /8 |
| Mechanics | Spelling, punctuation, legibility | /4 |

8. **The Examiner's Report.** Write your one-page report (200–250 words) on Candidate 017's script, in formal register, under the headings: Strengths; Weaknesses (grammar, register, argumentation); Recommendations.

9. **Reflection.** Complete your personal action plan: name your own three weakest areas observed during the week, and for each, state one concrete revision strategy and one deadline before the real session.

## 13.4 Model answer

**Task 1 — Time budget (Paper 1).** I must reserve fifteen minutes for choosing my question and planning, because an unplanned essay cannot be rescued by good grammar. I should spend about ninety minutes writing the essay and sixty on the comprehension and summary. Finally, I need to keep the last fifteen minutes for proofreading, since mechanics carry marks.

**Task 2 — What "Discuss" requires.** The command word Discuss requires the candidate to examine the statement from at least two opposing viewpoints before reaching a personal, weighed conclusion. A balanced discursive essay must therefore contain: (i) a clear **thesis** in the introduction; (ii) a fairly developed **counter-argument** presented in its own paragraph; and (iii) a conclusion in which the candidate weighs both sides and justifies a final position.

**Task 3 — Register analysis.**

| Informal / vague / absolute expression | Formal replacement |
|---|---|
| "Social media is very bad." | "Social media has had harmful effects on many young people." |
| "You can't deny that…" | "It can hardly be denied that…" |
| "everybody knows it" | "as is widely observed" / "as several studies suggest" |
| "But me, I think the bad side is more." | "Nevertheless, the disadvantages appear to outweigh the advantages." |

**Task 4 — Grammar and conciseness.** Original: "Youths in Cameroon nowadays they spend all their time on Facebook and WhatsApp instead of studying. This is why results are dropping." Corrected and condensed: "Many Cameroonian youths nowadays spend most of their time on Facebook and WhatsApp instead of studying, which may explain declining results." The double subject (Youths…they) is removed, the two short sentences are combined, and the absolute claim is hedged with may.

**Task 5 — Critical reasoning.** The claim commits two fallacies: an **appeal to popular opinion** (everybody knows it) and an **unsupported generalisation** (no evidence is given that results are dropping). Acceptable version: "Examination results in some schools appear to have declined in recent years, and excessive use of social media may be one contributing factor." The modal *may* expresses probability, not certainty.

**Task 6 — Replacement conclusion (sample).** "Social media neither saves nor destroys the Cameroonian youth; it magnifies the use to which it is put. Where it opens libraries, it can also open doors to distraction; where it connects, it can also consume. The solution, therefore, is not prohibition but discipline: schools, parents and students must together ensure that the screen serves the student, and not the student the screen." (Parallelism and antithesis are used; the judgement is weighed.)

**Task 7 — Marking (sample award).** Content and balance: 5/10 (both sides mentioned, but the counter-argument is dismissed in one line: "But me, I think the bad side is more"). Organisation: 4/8 (paragraphs exist but ideas are not developed or linked). Expression and register: 3/8 (informal register: "You can't deny"; double subject: "Youths…they"). Mechanics: 3/4 (generally legible; the jocular "full stop" is inappropriate). **Total: 15/30.**

**Task 8 — Examiner's Report (model).**

EXEMPLE **Examiner's Report — Candidate 017, Paper 1**

Strengths. The candidate understood the topic and attempted both sides of the argument; the essay has a recognisable introduction and conclusion, and the handwriting is legible.
Weaknesses. Grammar: a recurrent double subject ("Youths in Cameroon nowadays they spend…"). Register: the tone is conversational ("You can't deny", "But me, I think"), unsuited to a discursive essay. Argumentation: claims are absolute and unsupported ("everybody knows it"), the counter-argument is dismissed rather than weighed, and the conclusion proposes an extreme measure (a total ban) without justification.
Recommendations. The candidate should (i) hedge claims with modals of probability (*may, might, could*); (ii) develop the counter-argument in a full paragraph before rebutting it; and (iii) replace informal expressions with impersonal constructions. With these corrections, this script could move from the average to the good band.

**Task 9 — Personal action plan (model).** Weakness 1: summary writing exceeds the word limit — strategy: practise one summary every two days, cutting with ellipsis and substitution; deadline: 10 June. Weakness 2: poetry essays quote without analysing — strategy: re-read three Cosmic Anthology poems per week, annotating one device per stanza; deadline: 15 June. Weakness 3: informal register slips into formal essays — strategy: keep a personal two-column register table and proofread specifically for it; deadline: every practice essay until the examination.

WARNING **Common traps during the real session**

Do not spend so long on the essay that the comprehension is rushed; do not copy the

question as an introduction; never write your name on the script; and never leave the hall believing a blank conclusion costs nothing — an unfinished argument loses marks under both content and organisation.

DID YOU KNOW? **Why examiners write reports**

After every GCE session, chief examiners compile reports describing exactly the weaknesses you have just diagnosed in Candidate 017: informal register, unbalanced discussion, unsupported claims. Reading past examiners' reports is therefore one of the most efficient revision tools available to a Cameroonian candidate — it tells you, in the examiners' own words, what to avoid and what to imitate.

# 14 METHODS AND WORKED EXAMPLES

# 15 CONSOLIDATING LITERARY ANALYSIS AND GRAMMAR FOUNDATIONS

## 15.1 Writer's Craft Across Genres: Prose, Drama, and Poetry

**METHOD** **Analysing Writer's Craft Across Genres: Prose, Drama, and Poetry**

1. Identify the Genre and Form: Determine if the text is prose (novel, short story), drama (play script), or poetry (sonnet, free verse, lyric). Note structural constraints (e.g., acts/scenes, stanzas/rhyme scheme, narrative perspective).
2. Deconstruct Language Choices (Lexis & Syntax): Highlight **diction** (formal, colloquial, archaic, Cameroonian Pidgin inclusions), **sentence types** (declarative, interrogative, elliptical), and **figurative language** (metaphor, simile, personification, irony).
3. Analyse Structural Devices: In prose: **narrative voice** (1st/3rd person), **chronology** (linear, flashback, in media res). In drama: **stage directions**, **soliloquy**, **dramatic irony**, **entrances/exits**. In poetry: **enjambment**, **caesura**, **rhythm/metre**, **stanza breaks**.
4. Connect Form to Meaning (The "So What?"): Explain how the device creates the effect. Avoid feature-spotting. Example: "The use of short, staccato sentences mimics the character's panicked heartbeat."
5. Comparative Linking (for Paper 1/Comparative Tasks): Use comparative connectives (similarly, conversely, whereas, in contrast). Structure by **theme** or **technique**, not by text (avoid "Text A does X, Text B does Y").
6. Contextualise: Relate to the **socio-historical context** (colonialism, post-independence Cameroon, gender roles) and **literary tradition** (oral tradition influence, modernism).

**WORKED EXAMPLE 13** **Comparative Analysis of Narrative Voice and Oral Tradition**

Task: Read the two extracts below. Compare and contrast how the writers use narrative voice and elements of oral tradition to convey the theme of cultural conflict.
Extract A (Prose - Adapted from The Old Man and the Medal by Ferdinand Oyono): Meka

sat on the bamboo bed, the medal heavy on his chest like a stone. The white administrator's words still rang in his ears: "France rewards her loyal sons." But the night was full of the whispers of his ancestors. He heard the tam-tam of the village assembly, not the brass band of the ceremony. He spat on the ground. "A medal for a dog," he muttered in Ewondo, the words tasting of iron and bile.
Extract B (Drama - Adapted from The Trial of Mallam Ilya by Bode Sowande): Mallam Ilya: (Standing centre stage, facing the audience. The lighting isolates him. He speaks in a rhythmic, incantatory tone.) They brought the Book and the Sword. "Choose," they said. We chose the Book. Now the Book says: "Thou shalt not steal." But the Sword steals our land. The Book says: "Love thy neighbour." But the Sword neighbours our wives. Chorus: (Off-stage, humming a low, minor-key melody) The hyena wears the crown of the lion... Mallam Ilya: (Smiles bitterly) And the Judge? The Judge is the hyena's brother.

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:
1. Genre & Form Impact on Voice:

- Extract A (Prose): Uses **Third-person Limited Omniscient** narration focalised through Meka. We access his **internal monologue** ("He heard...", "He spat..."). The voice is **psychological**, exploring interiority. The prose form allows seamless shifts between the external ceremony ("brass band") and internal memory ("whispers of ancestors").
- Extract B (Drama): Uses **Direct Address / Breaking the Fourth Wall**. Mallam Ilya speaks to the audience ("They brought the Book..."). The voice is **performative, rhetorical, public**. Stage directions ("rhythmic, incantatory tone", "lighting isolates him") dictate the delivery. The **Chorus** functions as a structural device (Greek/African oral tradition) providing communal commentary.

2. Oral Tradition Techniques:

| Technique | Extract A (Prose) | Extract B (Drama) |
|---|---|---|
| Proverbial / Idiomatic Language | "A medal for a dog" (Metaphor/Insult rooted in local world-view). Spitting = ritual rejection. | "The hyena wears the crown of the lion" (Chorus proverb). "The Judge is the hyena's brother" (Zoomorphic satire). |
| Rhythm & Repetition | Syntactic parallelism: "The Book says... But the Sword..." (Internal rhythm of thought). | **Anaphora**: "The Book says... But the Sword..." (Incantatory, hypnotic rhythm for performance). |
| Code-Switching / Indigenous Lexis | "Ewondo", "tam-tam" (Grounds reality in specific Cameroonian culture). | "Mallam" (Title), "Book/Sword" (Symbolic lexis for Colonialism/Islam/Christianity). |
| Call & Response | Implied: Meka vs. Administrator (absent). Internal dialogue. | Explicit: Mallam Ilya ↔ Chorus. Communal validation of the argument. |

3. Theme of Cultural Conflict – Comparative Synthesis:

- Similarity: Both use **juxtaposition** of Indigenous vs. Colonial systems. Extract A: Medal (Colonial honour) vs. Ancestors/Tam-tam (Indigenous value). Extract B: Book (Colonial law/religion) vs. Sword (Colonial violence).
- Difference in Effect: Extract A creates **pathos** and **isolation** – Meka is alone with his realisation. The prose form emphasises **alienation**. Extract B creates **collective resistance** and **defiance**. The drama form + Chorus transforms individual grievance into **communal indictment**.
- Writer's Craft Verdict: Oyono uses **free indirect style** to blur narrator/character, making the cultural collision intimate. Sowande uses **epic theatre** techniques (direct address, chorus, song) to make the collision political and didactic.

Examiner's Tip: Always link the device to the genre. "The use of a Chorus (drama convention) allows Sowande to externalise the community's voice, whereas Oyono must internalise it through Meka's consciousness (prose convention)."

# 16 COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS ACROSS PASSAGES AND GENRES

## 16.1 Comparative Literary Analysis: Themes Across Prose, Drama, and Poetry

**METHOD** **Comparative Analysis: Themes and Styles Across Passages**

1. Establish the Basis of Comparison: Identify the shared **theme** (e.g., cultural conflict, corruption, identity, power) or **technique** (e.g., narrative voice, irony, symbolism) specified in the question.
2. Analyse Each Text Individually First: For each passage, note: Genre/Form, Voice/Perspective, Key Devices, Tone/Atmosphere, Theme Development.
3. Structure the Response by Point, Not by Text: Use a **point-by-point** structure: "Both texts explore X through Y... Text A uses device Z to..., while Text B employs device W to..." This avoids the "two separate essays" trap.
4. Use Precise Comparative Connectives: Similarly, Likewise, Equally (similarities); Conversely, In contrast, Whereas, However, On the other hand (differences); More significantly, Furthermore, A crucial distinction (evaluation).
5. Evaluate Relative Effectiveness: Go beyond listing. Judge why a technique works better in its specific genre/context. "The soliloquy in the drama externalises the conflict that the prose novel internalises through free indirect discourse."
6. Contextual Synthesis: Relate both texts to broader literary movements (e.g., African post-colonial literature, oral tradition, magical realism) and historical moments.

**KEY POINTS** **Key Principles for Comparative Analysis**

- Thesis-Driven: Your introduction must state a clear comparative thesis.
- Balanced Coverage: Spend roughly equal time on each text.
- Integrated Evidence: Embed quotations from both texts in the same paragraph.
- Genre Awareness: Always explain how genre shapes the presentation of the theme.
- Nuanced Conclusion: Synthesise, don't just summarise. Offer a final insight into the significance of the similarities/differences.

# 17 IN-DEPTH STUDY OF SELECTED POEMS I: 'IF' AND MORAL THEMES

## 17.1 Analysing Kipling's 'If': Structure, Tone, and the Speaker

METHOD **Deep Poetry Analysis: Structure, Tone, and the "Speaker" (Kipling's "If" & Moral Didacticism)**

1. Identify the Speaker & Audience: Who speaks? (Persona vs Poet). To whom? (Specific addressee – "my son" – vs Universal reader). In "If", the speaker is a **father figure / stoic mentor**; audience is the **son / young man**.
2. Map the Structure & Form: "If" = 4 stanzas, 8 lines each (octaves), **iambic pentameter** (mostly), **ABABCDCD** rhyme. Crucial: It is one single periodic sentence (starts with "If", ends with "Yours is the Earth..."). This creates **suspense** and **cumulative pressure**.
3. Analyse the **Anaphora** Engine: The repetition of "If you can..." (13 times) builds a **conditional framework**. It presents manhood not as a right but an **achievement** through self-mastery.
4. Track the Paradoxes (Antithesis): "Trust yourself... but make allowance for their doubting"; "Talk with crowds... keep your virtue"; "Walk with Kings... nor lose the common touch". Manhood = **holding opposites in tension**.
5. Evaluate Tone Shifts: Stanza 1–2: **Self-control** (emotional/intellectual). Stanza 3: **Resilience** (risk/loss/physical). Stanza 4: **Social integration** (public/private). Final two lines: **Triumphant definition** ("You'll be a Man, my son!").
6. Critical Lens (GCE Requirement): Don't just praise. Question: Is this **toxic masculinity**? **Imperialist stoicism**? **Suppression of emotion**? A top-band answer acknowledges the poem's historical context (Victorian/Edwardian imperial ethos) while analysing its rhetorical power.

WORKED EXAMPLE 14 **Analysing the Rhetoric of Stoicism in "If"**

Task: "Kipling's 'If' uses the structure of a conditional sentence to construct a model of ideal masculinity based on emotional suppression." Discuss this view, referring closely to poetic methods.

SOLUTION

Detailed Solution:

Thesis: The poem does use the conditional structure to make masculinity conditional and earned, but "emotional suppression" is a reductive reading; the poem advocates **emotional regulation** and **detachment from outcome**, not absence of feeling.

1. The Architecture of Conditionality (Syntax as Theme):

- The entire poem is a **hypotactic** structure: a massive **periodic sentence** delaying the main clause ("Yours is the Earth…") until the final line.
- Effect: The reader experiences the endurance required. We must hold all 13 conditions in working memory before receiving the reward. The form enacts the content: **patience, memory, deferred gratification**.
- Anaphora ("If you can…"): Creates a **liturgical**, almost catechistic rhythm. It frames the virtues as a **checklist** or **initiation rites**.

2. "Emotional Suppression" vs. "Emotional Mastery" – Close Reading:

| Line / Stanza | Sup Rea ing | Ma Rea ing (Nu and |
|---|---|---|
| ”If you can keep your head when all about you / Are losing theirs” | Ignore panic. | Me Re- tain cog ni- tive fun tion am cha ”He = rea son |
| ”If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster / And treat those two impostors just the same” | Deny joy/gri | Ste Epi tus Eve are neu tra (”in pos tor val is as- sig by jud me De tac |

3. The Paradox of "Virtue" and "Common Touch" (Stanza 4):
   - "If you can talk with crowds and keep your virtue / Or walk with Kings – nor lose the common touch".
   - **Antithesis** / **Chiasmus** structure (Crowds/Kings ↔ Virtue/Common Touch).
   - This demands **social fluidity** – the ability to code-switch. This contradicts "suppression"; it requires **high emotional intelligence** and adaptability.
4. The Colonial/Imperial Context (AO3 - Context):
   - Written 1895 (Leander Starr Jameson Raid context). The "son" is the **imperial administrator**.
   - "Kings", "crowds", "Earth", "Man" – capitalised abstract nouns = **Imperial Ideology**. The "stiff upper lip" serves the **colonial project**: the administrator must not crack under "tropical" pressure.
   - Counter-argument: The poem transcends context. The virtues (resilience, integrity, humility) are **universal humanist values** adopted by Nelson Mandela (read on Robben Island) and countless others.

Conclusion: The conditional structure constructs masculinity as a **performative act** (Butler) – "You'll be a Man" only if you perform these acts. It is less about suppressing emotion than **subordinating impulse to principle**. The rhetorical power lies in the **accumulative anaphora** making the ideal feel inevitable, not optional.

# 18 IN-DEPTH STUDY OF SELECTED POEMS II: AFRICAN VOICES

## 18.1 Corruption and Power: Satirical Protest Poetry

METHOD **Analysing African Poetry: Voice, Imagery, and Post-Colonial Identity (Visser, Corruption Poems)**

1. Identify the Persona & Stance: Is the speaker a **griot**, a **victim**, a **rebel**, or a **pan-African visionary**? (e.g., Visser's "I Am An African" = **collective, affirmative, inclusive** persona).
2. Deconstruct **Imagery Clusters**: Group images: Land/Nature (rivers, soil, baobab, sun) → **rootedness, ownership**. Blood/Body (veins, heartbeat, sweat) → **lineage, sacrifice**. History/Time (ancestors, colonial scars, future) → **continuity**.

3. Analyse **Sound Patterning** (Orality): Look for **repetition**, **parallelism**, **ideophones** (sound-words), **call-and-response** structures, **rhythm** mimicking drumming or speech-song. Don't just look for rhyme; look for rhythm.
4. Track the **Dialectic of Pain and Hope**: African protest poetry (e.g., "Corruption", "Power of Corruption") often moves: Diagnosis (The rot, the cankerworm) → Indictment (The elite, the "big men") → Call to Action (The people, the youth, the broom).
5. Language Choice (Code-Switching/Register): Note the mix of **Standard English**, **Pidgin**, **indigenous lexicon** (e.g., ubuntu, nyama, fon). This is the theme: linguistic decolonisation.
6. Structure as Argument: Free verse allowing **breath-lines** (oral delivery). Stanza breaks = **shifts in perspective** (Past → Present → Future; Individual → Collective).

## 18.2 Identity and Belonging: Wayne Visser's "I Am An African"

**WORKED EXAMPLE 15** **The Rhetoric of Belonging: Analysing "I Am An African" by Wayne Visser**

Task: How does Visser use repetition, imagery, and structure in "I Am An African" to construct a Pan-African identity that transcends colonial borders?

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:
1. The Anaphoric Backbone: "I am..."

- The poem is built on **anaphora**: "I am an African", "I am born of...", "I am the...", "I know...", "I feel...", "I see...", "I am...".
- Function: It performs **self-fashioning**. Each repetition adds a layer. It moves from Geography ("born of the dust", "the heat", "the dust") → History ("the scramble", "the chains", "the struggle") → Spirituality ("the ancestors", "the spirit") → Future Agency ("I am the future").
- Grammatical Shift: Starts with **Passive/Receptive** ("I am born of...") → shifts to **Active/Agentive** ("I know", "I feel", "I see", "I am the dream"). Identity is not just inherited; it is **enacted**.

2. Imagery Clusters – The Body Politic:

| Cluster | Key Im-age | Symbolic Function |
|---|---|---|
| The Land as Body | ”dust”, ”heat”, ”veld”, ”bush”, ”rivers”, ”baobab”, ”aca-cia” | **Indigeneity**. The land is not property but progenitor. ”Dust” = humility/ori |
| The Body as History | ”veins”, ”blood”, ”sweat”, ”tears”, ”scars”, ”chains”, ”whip” | **Embodied Trauma**. History is not abstract; it is written on the flesh. ”Blood |
| The Sensory/Emotive | ”smell of rain”, ”thun-der”, ”drum-beat”, ”ul-u-la-tion”, ”laugh-ter”, ”song” | **Affective Atmosphere**. Appeals to **synaesthesia**. ”Drumbeat” = heartbea |
| The Future/Abstract | ”dream”, ”hope”, ”promise”, ”rain-bow”, ”phoenix” | **Aspiration**. ”Rainbow” = Mandela’s Rainbow Nation / Diversity. ”Phoenix” |

3. Structure: The Movement from ”I” to ”We”:

- Stanzas 1–3: **Rootedness**. ”I am born of…” (Geological/Ancestral time). No coloniser mentioned yet.

- Stanzas 4–6: **Confrontation**. "I know the… scramble / chains / whip / struggle". The coloniser enters as a **disruptor** but does not define the identity. The **agency** remains with "I" ("I know", "I survived").
- Stanzas 7–9: **Transcendence**. "I am the… dream / hope / promise". The persona expands to **Collective** ("We are the people"). The final stanza: "I am an African / Not because I was born there / But because Africa is born in me."
- The Chiasmus/Paradox: "Not because… But because…" redefines nationality from **jus soli** (birthright) to **jus sanguinis/cultural** (spiritual belonging). This includes the **Diaspora**.

4. Orality on the Page:

- **Parallelism**: "I am the heat / I am the dust / I am the veld…" (Lists = **cataloguing** technique of oral praise poetry).
- **Rhythm**: Strong stress-timed beat. "I am an A-fri-can" (4 beats). Suitable for **performance**.
- **Inclusivity**: "The Tswana, the Xhosa, the Zulu, the Swazi…" – **Enumeration** as political act of unity.

Examiner's Comment: A Grade A answer contrasts Visser's **affirmative, inclusive, future-oriented** voice with the **satirical, angry, diagnostic** voice of poems like "Corruption" (e.g., by Ken Saro-Wiwa or similar). Visser writes the **myth of origin**; corruption poems write the **critique of the present**.

# 19 COMPREHENSIVE POETRY REVIEW: THE COSMIC ANTHOLOGY

## 19.1 Reviewing All 18 Prescribed Poems

METHOD **Comprehensive Poetry Review Strategy**

1. Categorise the 18 Poems: Group by **Theme** (Colonialism, Identity, Corruption, Nature, Love, Death, Tradition vs Modernity, Gender, War/Conflict, Diaspora) and **Form/Style** (Sonnet, Free Verse, Oral-style, Narrative, Lyric, Satire, Elegy).
2. Create a Master Comparison Table: For each poem, note: Title/Poet, Key Themes, Voice/Persona, Structure/Form, Key Images/Motifs, Sound Devices, Tone Shifts, Context.

3. Practise Thematic Pairings: Prepare comparative notes for likely exam pairings: e.g., Colonial Legacy: "The Zulu Girl" (Campbell) vs "I Am An African" (Visser); Corruption: "Corruption" (Saro-Wiwa) vs "Power of Corruption" (unknown); Oral Tradition: "If" (Kipling - Western didactic) vs African oral-style poems.
4. Master the "Unseen" Skills: Even for prescribed poems, treat each reading as fresh. Focus on **how** meaning is made (language, form, structure), not just **what** the meaning is.
5. Memorise Key Quotations: Select 2–3 versatile lines per poem that illustrate multiple techniques (e.g., imagery + sound + theme).

KEY POINTS **Cosmic Anthology: Essential Revision Checklist**

- Can you identify the persona and tone of each poem instantly?
- Can you explain the structural logic (why this stanza order? why this line break?)?
- Can you link sound to sense (e.g., how alliteration mimics drumming; how enjambment enacts flow/escape)?
- Can you compare two poems on a shared theme in a structured, point-by-point essay?
- Do you know the socio-historical context for each poet (country, era, language background)?
- Are you ready for contextual questions linking poems to Cameroonian society today?

# 20 PHONOLOGY IN FOCUS: CONNECTED SPEECH, DIALECTS AND ACCENTS

## 20.1 Connected Speech: Weak Forms, Linking, Elision, Assimilation

METHOD **Phonology in Practice: Connected Speech, Weak Forms, and Rhythm**

1. Distinguish Citation vs. Connected Form: Citation form = dictionary pronunciation (strong form). Connected form = rapid speech adjustments.
2. Master the **Weak Forms** List (High Frequency): **Function words** (prepositions, auxil-

iaries, articles, pronouns, conjunctions) reduce to **schwa /ə/** or elide vowels.

- to → /tə/ or /t/ (before consonant); and → /ən/ or /n/; of → /əv/; a → /ə/; the → /ə/ (consonant) /ði/ (vowel); can → /kən/; have → /həv/ → /əv/; was → /wəz/; are → /ə/; you → /jə/; that (conj) → /ət/.

3. Apply **Linking Processes**:
   - Linking /r/: "far raway" (only in non-rhotic accents like RP/Cameroon Standard).
   - Intrusive /r/: "law rand order", "idea rof".
   - Linking /j/: "I yam", "see yit".
   - Linking /w/: "you ware", "go wout".
4. Identify **Elision** (Loss of sounds): /t/ /d/ loss in clusters: "nex' day", "stan' up", "mus' go". /h/ dropping: "tell 'im", "in 'is car".
5. Identify **Assimilation** (Neighbour influence): /t/ → /p/ before /b, m, p/ ("whip me"); /d/ → /b/ ("goob boy"); /n/ → /m/ ("greem park"); /s/ → /ʃ/ ("thish year").
6. Analyse **Rhythm** (Stress-Timing): English is **stress-timed** (Cameroon languages often **syllable-timed**). Content words (N, V, Adj, Adv) = **Stressed** (Strong). Function words = **Unstressed** (Weak). Practice: Tap the beat on content words only.
7. Transcription Task Strategy: 1. Write citation forms. 2. Mark stress. 3. Apply weak forms to function words. 4. Apply linking/elision/assimilation at boundaries. 5. Check for **tonic syllable** (nucleus of IP).

**WORKED EXAMPLE 16** **Phonological Transcription and Connected Speech Analysis**

Task: Transcribe the following sentence as it would be spoken in a rapid, connected Standard Cameroonian English (non-rhotic) delivery. Mark primary stress (') and intonation phrase boundaries (//). Explain the weak forms, linking, and elision used.
Sentence: "The Minister of State has to ensure that the funds are allocated properly."

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:
1. Citation Forms (Dictionary): /ði/ /mɪ̈nɪ̈stə/ /əv/ /steɪ̈t/ /hz/ /tu:/ /ɪ̈nʃuə/ /ət/ /ði/ /fɪ̈ndz/ /ɑ:/ /lɪ̈keɪ̈tɪ̈d/ /prɪ̈pəli/
2. Connected Speech Transcription (Rapid Style): // ði 'mɪ̈nɪ̈stə əv 'steɪ̈t // əz tə ɪ̈n' ʃuə // ət ði 'fɪ̈ndz ə 'rlɪ̈keɪ̈tɪ̈d 'prɪ̈pəli //
(Note: Intonation phrases split at major syntactic boundaries: Subject NP // VP // Object/Complement Clause)
3. Detailed Process Annotation:

| Segment | Process | Explanation |
|---|---|---|
| The Minister | Weak form /ði/ (before vowel /m/) | Article ”the” takes /i/ allophone before vowel sound. |
| of State | Weak form /əv/ | Preposition ”of” → /əv/. Linking /v/ to /s/ (no intrusion). |
| has to | Elision + Weak form /hz/ → /əz/ + /tu:/ → /tə/ → /əz tə/ | ”Has” loses /h/ (h-dropping in rapid speech). ”To” → |

4. Rhythm Analysis:

- Foot 1: The Min-is-ter of State (3 syllables between stresses → rapid compression).
- Foot 2: has to en-sure that the (4 weak syllables compressed).
- Foot 3: funds are al-lo-cated prop-erly (Regular alternation).

Key Teaching Point: Cameroonian students often speak **syllable-timed** (giving equal time to "of", "to", "the"). The transcription proves these must be weak/schwa to sound natural and maintain English rhythm.

## 20.2 Dialects and Accents: Understanding Variations

**METHOD** **Analysing Dialects and Accents: Variation in English**

1. Distinguish Accent vs. Dialect: **Accent** = pronunciation only (phonology). **Dialect** = grammar, vocabulary, and pronunciation (e.g., Cameroonian Pidgin, Nigerian Pidgin, Jamaican Creole, AAVE).
2. Standard vs. Non-Standard: **Standard English** (SE) = codified variety used in education, media, officialdom. **Non-standard varieties** have their own systematic rules (not "errors").
3. Key Varieties for GCE: RP (Received Pronunciation) - reference model; Standard Cameroonian English (SCamE) - endonormative, non-rhotic, syllable-timed tendency, distinct vowel inventory (/ə/ for /ʌ/ in cup, /e/ for // in cat); West African Pidgin/Creole continuum; Other World Englishes (Indian, Singaporean, Caribbean) - know key features (e.g., Indian English: retroflex /t, d/, spelling pronunciation).
4. Analyse Features Systematically: Vowels (mergers/splits), Consonants (rhoticity, dental fricatives /θ, ð/ → /t, d/), Stress/Intonation (syllable-timing vs stress-timing), Grammar (uncountable nouns made countable: "furnitures", "advices"; tag questions "isn't it?" invariant), Lexicon (local loanwords: "bush taxi", "buyam-sellam").
5. Attitudes & Identity: Understand **overt prestige** (SE) vs **covert prestige** (local variety). Code-switching as strategic competence.

**EXEMPLE** **Cameroonian English Phonological Features**

Vowel Shifts (Common in SCamE):

- KIT /ɪ̈/ ↔ FLEECE /i:/ merger tendency (ship = sheep).
- FOOT /ʊ̈/ ↔ GOOSE /u:/ merger (full = fool).

- TRAP // → /e/ (cat ≈ ket).
- STRUT /ʌ/ → /ə/ or /a/ (cup ≈ cap).
- LOT/THOUGHT merger (/ɑ/ = /ɑ :/).

Consonant Features:

- Non-rhotic (no post-vocalic /r/).
- /θ, ð/ → /t, d/ (think → tink, that → dat).
- Final consonant cluster simplification (test → tes, hand → han).

Grammatical Features:

- Invariant tag: "You're coming, isn't it?"
- Uncountable → countable: "equipments", "luggages", "damages" (meaning injury).
- Preposition use: "discuss about", "emphasise on", "reply me".

# 21 ADVANCED GRAMMAR: MODALS, ELLIPSIS AND SUBSTITUTION

## 21.1 Advanced Modals: Degrees of Certainty, Obligation, Permission

**METHOD** **Advanced Modals: Degrees of Certainty, Obligation, Permission**

1. Classify the **Modal Function**: Epistemic (Certainty/Possibility/Deduction – "It must be raining") vs Deontic (Obligation/Permission/Ability – "You must go"). Context decides.
2. Master the **Certainty Scale** (Epistemic):

| | |
|---|---|
| High Certainty | **will** (predictable), **must** (logical deduction), **can't/couldn't** (negative deduction) |
| Medium-High | **should / ought to** (expectation) |
| Medium | **may**, **may well**, **could** (possibility) |
| Low | **might**, **could** (remote possibility) |

3. Perfect Modals for Past Time Reference: **MODAL + HAVE + PAST PARTICIPLE**.
   - Must have done (Deduction past). Can't have done (Impossible past).

- Should have done (Unfulfilled expectation/Regret).
- Needn't have done (Unnecessary action performed) vs Didn't need to do (No obligation, action maybe performed).
- Could have done (Ability unfulfilled / Possibility unfulfilled / Reproach).

4. Deontic Nuances (Obligation/Permission):
   - **Must** = Internal authority / Speaker's opinion. **Have to** = External authority / Rules / Law.
   - **Needn't** = No necessity (Speaker's authority). **Don't have to** = No external obligation.
   - **May** = Formal permission (Granting). **Can** = Informal permission / Ability. **Could** = Polite request / Past permission.
5. Semi-Modals & Marginal Modals: **Dare, Need, Used to, Be to, Have (got) to**. Know their negative/interrogative forms without do-support (e.g., "Need he go?", "He need not go").
6. Transformation Strategy (Exam): "It is certain that..." → "It must be..." / "He will..." / "He is bound to..." / "There is no doubt that...".

**WORKED EXAMPLE 17** **Modal Transformation and Nuance Analysis**

Task A: Rewrite the sentences using a modal verb (or semi-modal) to express the meaning in brackets. Do not change the meaning.

1. "I am certain he has already left." (Deduction – Present Perfect)
2. "It was unnecessary for you to buy bread; we have plenty." (Criticism of unnecessary past action)
3. "The regulations forbid students from entering the lab without a coat." (External Prohibition)
4. "I strongly advise you to see a doctor immediately." (Strong Advice / Obligation)
5. "There is a possibility that the plane will land early." (Possibility)

Task B: Explain the difference in meaning between:

1. "You needn't have come yesterday." vs "You didn't need to come yesterday."
2. "He could have drowned." vs "He might have drowned."

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:

Task A – Transformations:

1. He **must have left** already. (Epistemic must + perfect infinitive = high certainty deduction about past).
2. You **needn't have bought** bread. (Needn't have + PP = action performed but unnecessary. Didn't need to buy would imply maybe you didn't buy it).
3. Students **must not** / **are not to** enter the lab without a coat. (Must not = Strong prohibition, often speaker's authority or rules. Are not to = Formal instruction/regulation). Cannot implies inability/permission denial.
4. You **should** / **ought to** see a doctor immediately. (Should/Ought to = Advice/Duty. Had better implies warning of negative consequence – also acceptable).
5. The plane **may** / **might** / **could** land early. (May = slightly higher probability than might/could. May well = high probability).

Task B – Nuance Analysis:

| Pair | Sentence 1 | Sentence 2 |
|---|---|---|
| Needn't have vs Didn't need to | You needn't have come yesterday.<br>Fact: You DID come.<br>Meaning: You wasted your time/effort. The speaker regrets the effort.<br>Context: "Why are you here? You needn't have come!" | You didn't need to come yesterday.<br>Fact: It is UNKNOWN if you came.<br>Meaning: There was no obligation/necessity. You may have come (voluntarily) or may not have come.<br>Context: "The meeting was cancelled. You didn't need to come (but you might be here anyway)." |
| Could have vs Might have | He could have drowned.<br>Meaning 1 (Past Ability unfulfilled): He was in danger of drowning but survived. (Lucky escape).<br>Meaning 2 (Reproach - Rare): "You could have drowned!" (Scolding a child taking risks). | He might have drowned.<br>Meaning: **Epistemic Possibility** (Speculation). "He fell in the water; he might have drowned (but we don't know if he did)."<br>NOT used for "Lucky escape" in standard grammar. Could have = Realised danger averted. Might have = Unrealised/Unknown outcome. |

Examiner's Trap Alert:

- "Mustn't" vs "Don't have to": "You mustn't park here" = Prohibition (Illegal). "You don't have to park here" = No obligation (You can if you want, but it's not required).
- "Can't have" vs "Mustn't have": "He can't have stolen it" = **Deduction: Impossible**. "He mustn't have stolen it" = INCORRECT for deduction. Use can't have or couldn't have for negative deduction.
- "Will" for Characteristic Behaviour: "He will sit there for hours." (Habit/Typical behaviour) – Epistemic high certainty about character.

## 21.2 Ellipsis and Substitution: Achieving Conciseness

**METHOD** **Ellipsis and Substitution: Achieving Conciseness in Writing**

1. Define **Ellipsis**: Omission of words recoverable from context. Types: Nominal (omission of head noun: "I prefer the blue [shirt]"), Verbal (omission of verb phrase: "Will you go?" "I might [go]"), Clausal (omission of clause: "Why did you leave?" "Because [I was tired]").
2. Define **Substitution**: Replacing a word/phrase with a **substitute form** (one/ones, do so, so, not, the same). Unlike ellipsis, a placeholder remains.
3. Key Substitution Rules:
   - One/Ones for countable nouns: "Which pen? The red one."
   - Do so for verb phrases (formal): "He promised to resign and he did so."
   - So/Not for clauses after think, hope, believe, expect, suppose, seem, appear: "Will it rain?" "I hope not / I think so."
   - The same for formal/legal repetition: "The applicant must sign here and date the same."
4. Apply in Reconstructive Writing (Minutes/Reports): "The Chairperson suggested that we should postpone the event" → "The Chairperson proposed postponing the event" / " Proposal to postpone the event." (Nominalisation + Ellipsis).
5. Avoid Faulty Ellipsis: Ensure the omitted material is identical in form. "She likes dancing more than me" (Ambiguous: than I do vs than she likes me). Correct: "She likes dancing more than I do" or "more than she likes me".

**WORKED EXAMPLE 18** **Editing for Conciseness using Ellipsis and Substitution**

Task: Reduce the following paragraph using ellipsis and substitution, maintaining full meaning. Original (68 words) → Target < 40 words.
"The Minister announced that the government would build new schools. The Minister also announced that the government would equip the new schools. The Minister further announced that the government would train teachers for the new schools. The Opposition Leader said that the Opposition did not believe the Minister. The Opposition Leader said that the Opposition thought the promises were empty."

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:
Step 1: Identify Repeated Structures

- Subject: "The Minister" (3×), "The Opposition Leader" (2×).
- Verb: "announced that the government would" (3×), "said that the Opposition" (2×).
- Complement clauses: "build…", "equip…", "train…".

Step 2: Apply Substitution (do so, so) and Ellipsis

- "The Minister announced that the government would build new schools, equip them, and train teachers for them." (Ellipsis of repeated subject/verb/modal).
- "The Opposition Leader dismissed this, believing the promises empty." (Substitution: dismissed this for said… did not believe; believing… empty for thought the promises were empty).

Final Version (32 words):

> The Minister announced plans to build, equip, and staff new schools. The Opposition Leader dismissed this, deeming the promises empty.

Techniques Used: **Coordination** (build, equip, staff), **Ellipsis** (shared subject/modal), **Substitution** (this for the announcement), **Nominalisation** (plans to…), **Participle clause** (deeming…).

# 22 RECONSTRUCTIVE WRITING: MINUTES, DEBATES, TALKS AND LECTURES

## 22.1 Reconstructing Minutes of Meetings

**METHOD** **Reconstructing Minutes: Format, Reported Speech, and Conciseness**

1. Understand the **Purpose**: Minutes are an **official legal record** of decisions and actions, not a transcript of dialogue. They answer: What was decided? Who does what? By when?
2. Master the **Standard Format** (Cameroon GCE Standard):
   (a) Header: Name of Body/Committee, Minutes of the Meeting, Date, Time, Venue.
   (b) Attendance: **Present** (Names + Titles), **Apologies for Absence** (Names + Reasons), **Absent** (No apology), **In Attendance** (Secretary, Observers, Guests).
   (c) Opening: "The Chairperson called the meeting to order at [Time]…" / Opening prayer/remarks.

(d) Adoption of Agenda: "Agenda adopted / Amended (Item X added)..."

(e) Confirmation of Previous Minutes: "Minutes of meeting dated [Date] read / taken as read / confirmed / amended (Item Y corrected)... Signed by Chair."

(f) Matters Arising: Updates on action points from previous minutes (Status: Done, Pending, Deferred).

(g) Main Business (Agenda Items): Numbered items. For each: Topic → Discussion Summary (Key arguments only) → Resolution/Decision → Action Point (Who/What/When).

(h) AOB (Any Other Business): Urgent items only.

(i) Date of Next Meeting.

(j) Adjournment/Closing: Time, Prayer/Remarks.

(k) Signatures: Secretary (Prepared by), Chairperson (Approved/Confirmed).

3. Apply **Reported Speech** Rules (Backshifting): Present → Past; Will → Would; Can → Could; Must → Had to / Must (obligation stays); This/These → That/Those; Now → Then; Today → That day.

4. Use **Impersonal/Passive Style** for Decisions: "It was resolved that...", "It was agreed that...", "The Committee decided to...", "The Secretary was tasked with..." Avoid "Mr X said...".

5. Achieve **Conciseness** via Ellipsis/Substitution/Nominalisation: "The Chairperson suggested that we should postpone the event" → "The Chairperson proposed postponing the event" / " Proposal to postpone the event." (See Lesson 54).

**WORKED EXAMPLE 19** **Reconstructing Minutes from a Transcript**

Task: You are the Secretary of the Buea University Students' Union (BUSU) Executive. Using the transcript below, write the Minutes of the Emergency Meeting held on 15th October 2024. (Word limit: 250–300 words for the Main Business section).
Transcript: Chair: (10:05 AM) Meeting called to order. Opening prayer by VP. VP: (Prays). Chair: Apologies? Sec-Gen: Treasurer (sick), PRO (exams). Chair: Noted. Agenda? Sec-Gen: 1. Fee hike protest. 2. Library hours. Chair: Adopted. Chair: Minutes of last meeting? Sec-Gen: Item 3 – Vice-Chancellor promised Wi-Fi. Not done. Chair: Write reminder. Chair: Item 1 – Fee Hike. FinSec: Admin wants 15% increase. We reject. VP: Peaceful march Thursday? Chair: Risky. Exams next week. Senator: Petition + Dialogue first. Chair: Agreed. Petition by Wednesday. Sen. to lead delegation Friday. Chair: Item 2 – Library. AcadSec: Close 10pm. Students want 12am. Chair: Cost? AcadSec: 500k/month generators. Treasurer (absent). Chair: Defer to next meeting. Treasurer to cost. Chair: AOB? VP: Water shortage Block B. Chair: Report to Maintenance. Next

meeting: 22 Oct. Closed 11:30.

SOLUTION

Detailed Solution:
BUEA UNIVERSITY STUDENTS' UNION (BUSU) EXECUTIVE MINUTES OF THE EMERGENCY MEETING HELD ON TUESDAY, 15TH OCTOBER 2024 AT 10:05 AM IN THE UNION BOARD-ROOM.
1. ATTENDANCE Present: N. Akwo (Chairperson), M. Etonde (Vice-President), P. Mbarga (Secretary General), J. Ndi (Financial Secretary), A. Fonkeng (Academic Secretary), S. Koum (Senator). Apologies for Absence: T. Ngwa (Treasurer – Illness), R. Baiye (PRO – Examinations). In Attendance: P. Mbarga (Secretary/Minute Taker).
2. OPENING The Chairperson called the meeting to order at 10:05 AM. The Vice-President said the opening prayer.
3. ADOPTION OF AGENDA The agenda was adopted without amendment.
4. CONFIRMATION OF PREVIOUS MINUTES The minutes of the meeting held on 8th October 2024 were confirmed. Matters Arising: Item 3 (Wi-Fi Installation): The Vice-Chancellor's promise remained unfulfilled. Action: Secretary General to send a formal reminder to the VC's office by 18th October.
5. MAIN BUSINESS
5.1 Proposed 15% Tuition Fee Increase Discussion: The Financial Secretary reported the Administration's proposal. The Executive unanimously rejected the increase. A peaceful march was proposed but deemed risky due to impending examinations. Resolution: A two-pronged approach was adopted: (i) Submission of a formal petition to the Rector by Wednesday, 16th October; (ii) A delegation led by Senator S. Koum to engage the Administration in dialogue on Friday, 18th October. Action: Sec-Gen (Petition drafting); Sen. Koum (Delegation leadership).
5.2 Extension of Library Opening Hours (10 PM → 12 AM) Discussion: The Academic Secretary presented student demand. Estimated generator cost: 500,000 FCFA/month. Treasurer absent for financial clearance. Resolution: Matter deferred to next meeting pending cost-benefit analysis. Action: Treasurer (T. Ngwa) to submit detailed costing by 21st October.
6. ANY OTHER BUSINESS Water Shortage Block B: Vice-President reported crisis. Chairperson directed immediate report to University Maintenance Department.
7. DATE OF NEXT MEETING Tuesday, 22nd October 2024 at 10:00 AM.
8. ADJOURNMENT Meeting adjourned at 11:30 AM after closing remarks by the Chairperson.

Prepared by: _____
P. Mbarga (Secretary General)
Date: 16/10/2024

Approved by: _____
N. Akwo (Chairperson)
Date: 16/10/2024

Examiner's Comments on Model:

- Format: Perfect header, attendance categories, numbering.

- Reported Speech: "Admin wants..." → "Financial Secretary reported..."; "We reject" → "Executive unanimously rejected..."; "Petition by Wednesday" → "Submission... by Wednesday".
- Conciseness: 10 lines of dialogue → 4 lines of minutes. "Risky. Exams next week" → "deemed risky due to impending examinations".
- Action Points: Clear WHO (Role), WHAT, WHEN.
- Tone: Formal, objective, passive constructions ("was adopted", "was deferred").

## 22.2 Reconstructing Debates, Talks, and Lectures

**METHOD** **Reconstructing Debates, Talks, and Lectures**

1. Identify the **Genre Conventions**:
   - Debate: Formal motion, **Proposers/Opposers**, **Points of Information**, **Rebuttals**, **Floor debate**, **Vote**. Structure: Motion → Opening speeches → Floor → Summation → Vote.
   - Talk/Lecture: **Introduction** (Hook, Thesis, Outline), **Body** (Signposted sections, Evidence, Examples), **Conclusion** (Summary, Implication, Q&A invitation).
2. Note-Taking Strategy (Real-time): Use **abbreviations**, **symbols** (↑ increase, ↓ decrease, → leads to, ↔ contrast), **structure mapping** (Main points → Sub-points → Evidence). Focus on arguments, not every word.
3. Reconstruction Principles:
   - Fidelity: Accurately represent the speaker's stance (don't straw-man).
   - Structure: Impose logical order (Problem-Solution, Cause-Effect, Compare-Contrast).
   - Register: Formal, objective. Use **reporting verbs**: argued, contended, asserted, challenged, conceded, refuted, illustrated, emphasised.
   - Attribution: "Speaker A maintained that...", "In response, Speaker B countered...".
4. Debate Reconstruction Format: Motion → Key Arguments (Proposition) → Key Arguments (Opposition) → Significant Clashes/POIs → Outcome.
5. Lecture/Talk Reconstruction Format: Title, Speaker, Date → Thesis → Main Points (with supporting evidence) → Key Examples/Case Studies → Conclusion/Implications → Notable Q&A.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 20** **Reconstructing a Lecture**

Task: Reconstruct the following lecture excerpt into a structured summary (150 words). Lecturer: "Today we examine the crisis of graduate unemployment in Cameroon. The core issue is structural. Our universities produce 30,000 graduates yearly. The formal sector creates maybe 5,000 jobs. That's a 25,000 gap. Why? Colonial curriculum. We train clerks, not creators. Look at the German dual system: apprenticeships + theory. We need TVET reform. But there's stigma. Parents want 'Baccalauréat', not 'CAP'. Funding follows prestige. Technical colleges are dilapidated. The solution? Three pillars: 1. Curriculum overhaul – competence-based. 2. Industry partnerships – mandatory internships. 3. Rebranding – skills competitions, media campaigns. It's not just education policy; it's economic survival."

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:
LECTURE RECONSTRUCTION: "The Graduate Unemployment Crisis in Cameroon: Structural Causes and Solutions"
Thesis: Graduate unemployment stems from a structural mismatch between colonial-era curricula and labour market needs, requiring a three-pillar reform of TVET.
Main Points:

1. Scale of Crisis: 30,000 annual graduates vs. 5,000 formal jobs (83% absorption gap).
2. Root Cause: Colonial curriculum legacy producing clerical workers rather than innovators; persistent stigma against Technical/Vocational Education (TVET).
3. Systemic Failure: Funding bias toward general education; dilapidated technical infrastructure; weak industry-academia links.
4. Proposed Model (German Dual System): Apprenticeships integrated with theory.
5. Three-Pillar Reform:
   - Curriculum: Shift to Competence-Based Approach (CBA).
   - Partnerships: Mandatory, structured internships with industry.
   - Rebranding: Skills competitions, media campaigns to elevate TVET prestige.

Conclusion: The lecturer frames educational reform as an economic imperative, not merely a social policy choice.

# 23 ADVANCED COMPOSITION: DISCURSIVE ESSAYS, NEWS REPORTS AND REGISTER

## 23.1 Discursive Essays: Exploring Multiple Perspectives

**METHOD** **Discursive Essays: Structure, Balance, and Register Control**

1. Analyse the **Prompt** (Command Words): "Discuss", "To what extent", "Evaluate", "Compare". Never write a one-sided argumentative essay. **Discursive** = **Exploring multiple perspectives** before reaching a nuanced conclusion.
2. Plan using the **Dialectical Structure** (Thesis - Antithesis - Synthesis):
   (a) Introduction (1 para): **Hook** (Quote, Stat, Anecdote) → **Define key terms** → **Contextualise** (Cameroon/Global) → **Thesis Statement** (Your roadmap: "This essay examines X, Y, and Z before arguing that...").
   (b) Body Paragraphs (4–6 paras): Use **PEEL** (Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link).
   (c) Cluster 1 (Perspective A): 1–2 paras supporting one view. **Topic Sentence** signposts the view.
   (d) Cluster 2 (Perspective B): 1–2 paras opposing/qualifying. Use **Contrastive Connectives**: However, Conversely, Critics argue, On the other hand.
   (e) Cluster 3 (Synthesis/Nuance): 1 para transcending binary. "While A highlights..., B reminds us... A third way suggests..."
   (f) Conclusion (1 para): **Restate Thesis** (fresh words) → **Summarise Main Trajectory** → **Final Thought / Implication / Call to Action** (The "So What?"). No new arguments.
3. Control **Register** (Formal/Academic):
   - No contractions (cannot, do not).
   - Impersonal structures: "It is argued that...", "Evidence suggests...", "One might contend..." (Avoid "I think", "In my opinion" until conclusion).
   - Hedging (Academic Caution): "tends to", "suggests", "indicates", "may", "could", "appears to". Avoid absolute claims ("proves", "always", "never") unless certain.
   - Nominalisation: "The government decided to increase fees" → "The decision to increase fees..." (Shifts focus to concept).
   - Signposting: "Furthermore", "Moreover", "Nevertheless", "Consequently", "Ultimately".

4. Content Generation (AO2/AO3): Brainstorm **Stakeholders** (Govt, Youth, Parents, Employers, Diaspora), **Dimensions** (Economic, Social, Political, Cultural, Ethical, Environmental), **Timeframes** (Short-term vs Long-term).

**WORKED EXAMPLE 21** **Discursive Essay: Planning and Opening**

Task: "The pursuit of academic certificates in Cameroon has overtaken the acquisition of practical skills. Discuss."
Part A: Produce a detailed Plan (Thesis, 4 Main Points with Evidence, Synthesis, Conclusion). Part B: Write the Introduction (approx. 80–100 words) demonstrating formal register and hedging.

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:
Part A: Essay Plan
Title: Paper Chases vs. Power Tools: Re-evaluating Educational Value in Cameroon.
Thesis Statement: While academic certification remains a vital gatekeeper for formal employment and social mobility in Cameroon, an over-reliance on paper qualifications at the expense of technical competence has created a structural mismatch in the labour market; a sustainable solution requires the formal integration and valorisation of Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) within the national qualification framework.
Body Paragraphs:

1. Point 1 (The Certificate Imperative – Thesis): Certificates as **social currency**. GCE/University degrees = access to Civil Service (Fonction Publique), prestige, "white-collar" identity. Evidence: Thousands sit GCE annually; "Baccalauréat" as rite of passage; parental pressure for "General Education" over "Technical".

2. Point 2 (The Skills Deficit – Antithesis): **Graduate Unemployment** crisis. Mismatch: Humanities grads vs. Market needs (Engineering, Agri-business, ICT, Artisanship). Evidence: MINESUP insertion surveys; "Bush falling" desperation; Employers (e.g., CDC, SONARA, SMEs) complaining of "unemployable graduates" lacking soft/technical skills.

3. Point 3 (Systemic Drivers – Analysis): **Structural Factors**. Colonial legacy (Clerical training); Funding bias (General lycées vs. Technical colleges infrastructure); Certification inflation (Master's required for entry jobs); Lack of Industry-Academia linkage (Apprenticeship weak).

4. Point 4 (The TVET Alternative – Counter-Perspective): **Success Stories**. GTTC/GTTHS graduates (Electricians, Welders, Nurses) often employed faster/self-employed. Government Policy: "Import-Substitution" policy needs skilled hands. Barrier: Stigma ("Second choice"), poor equipment, certification not equated to GCE A-Level for university entry easily.

5. Synthesis (The "Third Way"): **Competence-Based Approach (CBA)**. Not "Certificates vs" Skills, but "Certificates certifying Skills". Reforms: National Qualifications Framework (NQF) alignment; Mandatory internships/entrepreneurship modules in universities; "Dual Training" (German model); Rebranding TVET as "First Choice".

Conclusion: Restate: Certificates open doors, skills keep you inside. Call for **Paradigm Shift**: Society must celebrate the **Master Craftsperson** as much as the **PhD Holder**. Policy must fund workshops as well as lecture halls.
Part B: Model Introduction

> "A certificate is a receipt for tuition paid; competence is the ability to deliver value." This distinction, often attributed to vocational advocates, encapsulates a growing tension within the Cameroonian educational landscape. Since the colonial era, the **General Certificate of Education (GCE)** and university degrees have functioned as the primary **signalling mechanism** for merit, granting access to the civil service and the prestige of the **intelligentsia**. However, as the youth unemployment rate soars – officially estimated above 13% but widely acknowledged to be far higher among graduates – questions arise regarding the **instrumental value** of purely academic credentials. This essay contends that while certificates retain undeniable **exchange value** in the formal sector, the systemic privileging of theoretical knowledge over practical competence has exacerbated a critical **skills gap**. It will examine the socio-historical roots of this bias, analyse its labour market consequences, and evaluate the potential of a revitalised Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) sector to restore balance between **credentialism** and **competence**.

Register Check: **Hedging** ("often attributed", "widely acknowledged", "contends that", "potential of"), **Nominalisation** ("signalling mechanism", "instrumental value", "skills gap", "credentialism"), **Impersonal** ("This essay contends…", "It will examine…"), **Signposting** ("However", "It will examine… analyse… evaluate").

## 23.2 Register Analysis: Formal, Neutral, and Informal Styles

METHOD **Register Analysis: Identifying and Shifting Styles**

1. Define **Register**: The variety of language determined by Field (topic), Tenor (relationship between participants), Mode (channel: spoken/written).
2. Analyse the **Three Main Registers**:

| Feature | Formal | Neutral | Informal |
|---|---|---|---|
| Vocabulary | Latinate, precise, nominalised (commence, purchase, termination) | Standard, everyday (start, buy, end) | Germanic, phrasal verbs, slang, idioms (kick off, grab, wrap up) |
| Grammar | Passive constructions, complex sentences, subjunctive, no contractions | Standard syntax, mix of simple/complex, some contractions | Active voice, simple/elliptical sentences, contractions, non-standard grammar |
| Tenor | Distant, respectful, impersonal | Polite, accessible, semi-personal | Intimate, personal, expressive |
| Typical Contexts | Legal, academic, official, ceremonial | Journalism, textbooks, business letters, meetings | Friends, family, social media, creative writing |

3. Shifting Register (Exam Skill): Identify the **inappropriate** feature → Replace with **target register** equivalent. Example: Informal "The govt needs to fix the mess" → Formal "The government must address the crisis."
4. Mixed Register Awareness: Real texts often blend. Analyse why (e.g., a formal report with an informal anecdote for engagement).

**WORKED EXAMPLE 22** **Register Transformation**

Task: Rewrite the following informal complaint letter in a formal register suitable for submission to a Ministerial Delegate.
Informal: "Hey Sir, I'm writing 'cos I'm really fed up with the state of the road in our quarter. It's full of potholes and when it rains it's a nightmare. Cars get stuck, kids can't go to school. We've told the council loads of times but they don't care. You gotta do something fast!"

**SOLUTION**

Formal Version:

Subject: Urgent Appeal for Rehabilitation of Access Roads in [Quarter Name]

Dear Sir/Madam,

I write to express deep concern regarding the deplorable condition of the access roads in [Quarter Name]. The thoroughfares are severely degraded, characterised by extensive potholes which become impassable during the

rainy season. This situation impedes vehicular movement, disrupts school attendance for children, and poses significant safety hazards.

Despite repeated representations to the Municipal Council, no remedial action has been taken. We respectfully urge your office to intervene expeditiously and authorise the necessary rehabilitation works.

Yours faithfully, [Name/Association]

Changes: **Vocabulary** (fed up → deep concern; nightmare → impassable/safety hazards; loads of times → repeated representations). **Grammar** (Contractions removed; passive "no remedial action has been taken"; modal "must" → "urge… to intervene"). **Structure** (Subject line, formal salutation, paragraphing, formal closing).

## 23.3 Writing News Reports: Objectivity, Structure, and Style

**METHOD** **Writing News Reports: The Inverted Pyramid**

1. Structure (Inverted Pyramid):
   (a) Headline: Catchy, present tense, omits articles/auxiliaries (Government Launches Youth Employment Scheme).
   (b) Byline: Reporter name, location, date.
   (c) Lead Paragraph (The Lead): 25–35 words. Answers **5 Ws + H** (Who, What, Where, When, Why, How). Most critical info.
   (d) Body Paragraphs: Descending order of importance. **Quotes** (attributed), **Context/Background**, **Reaction/Consequence**, **Future developments**.
   (e) Tail: Least important details, contact info, related stories.
2. News Values (Newsworthiness): **Timeliness**, **Impact/Consequence**, **Conflict**, **Prominence**, **Proximity**, **Oddity/Novelty**, **Human Interest**.
3. Style Rules:
   - Objectivity: No "I", "we", opinion adjectives (tragic, wonderful). Use **attribution**: "Police said…", "The Minister announced…".
   - Concision: Short sentences (avg 20 words). Short paragraphs (1–2 sentences). Active voice preferred.
   - Attribution Verbs: said, stated, announced, confirmed, revealed, warned, urged, denied, disclosed. Avoid "claimed" (implies doubt) unless necessary.
   - Quotes: Direct quotes for colour/emotion/opinion. Indirect (reported) for facts/data.

4. Headline Grammar: Present simple for past events (Minister Opens Hospital); Infinitive for future (President To Visit Region); Omit be verbs (Three Dead in Crash).

WORKED EXAMPLE 23 **News Report Writing**

Task: Write a news report (200–250 words) based on these notes:

- Event: Launch of "Digital Skills for All" programme.
- Who: Minister of Youth Affairs (Mounouna Foutsou), UNICEF Rep.
- Where: Yaoundé Multipurpose Sports Complex.
- When: Yesterday, 10 AM.
- What: 5,000 youth to be trained in coding, digital marketing, AI basics. 6 months. FCFA 2bn budget.
- Why: Combat unemployment, bridge digital divide.
- Quote Minister: "This is a revolution, not just training."
- Quote Beneficiary: Student, 22, "Finally, a chance."
- Context: Youth unemployment 13%+.

SOLUTION

Detailed Solution:
HEADLINE: Government Launches FCFA 2bn Digital Skills Drive for 5,000 Youth
BYLINE: By [Candidate Name], Yaoundé
LEAD: The Minister of Youth Affairs and Civic Education, Mounouna Foutsou, yesterday launched the "Digital Skills for All" programme, a FCFA 2 billion initiative targeting 5,000 young Cameroonians for intensive training in coding, digital marketing, and artificial intelligence fundamentals.
BODY: Speaking at the Yaoundé Multipurpose Sports Complex, the Minister described the six-month programme as a "revolution, not just training," aimed at bridging the widening digital divide and tackling structural youth unemployment, currently estimated above 13%.
"This initiative moves beyond certificates to competence," Minister Foutsou stated. "We are equipping our youth with the currency of the 21st-century economy."
The programme, supported by UNICEF and private tech partners, will operate through regional hubs. Selection prioritises vulnerable groups, including internally displaced persons and rural youth.
For 22-year-old university graduate Achille Ngwa, the launch offers hope. "I have a degree but no job. This is finally a chance to learn something the market actually needs," he said.

UNICEF Representative Nadine Perrault emphasised the programme's alignment with the Sustainable Development Goals, urging beneficiaries to become "digital ambassadors" in their communities.
Applications open next Monday via the Ministry's digital platform. Training commences in July.

# 24 CRITICAL REASONING, RHETORIC AND VISUAL STIMULI

## 24.1 Critical Reasoning: Evaluating Arguments and Evidence

METHOD **Critical Reasoning: Evaluating Arguments & Visual Stimuli (Cartoons/Graphs)**

1. Argument Anatomy (Toulmin Model): Identify **Claim** (Conclusion), **Grounds** (Evidence/Data), **Warrant** (Assumption linking grounds to claim), **Backing** (Support for warrant), **Qualifier** (Certainty: "probably", "certainly"), **Rebuttal** (Counter-arguments acknowledged).
2. Spot **Logical Fallacies** (GCE Favourites):
   - **Ad Hominem**: Attacking person not argument.
   - **Straw Man**: Misrepresenting opponent's view.
   - **False Dilemma / Binary Thinking**: "Either A or B" (ignores spectrum).
   - **Hasty Generalisation**: Small sample → Broad rule.
   - **Post Hoc / False Cause**: Correlation ≠ Causation.
   - **Slippery Slope**: One step → Catastrophe (no evidence).
   - **Appeal to Authority/Popularity/Tradition**: "Everyone does it", "Minister said so".
   - **Circular Reasoning**: Claim proves itself.
3. Evaluate **Evidence Quality**: **Relevance**, **Sufficiency**, **Credibility** (Source bias? Date? Peer-reviewed? Anecdote vs Data?), **Representativeness**.
4. Visual Stimuli Analysis (Cartoons/Ads/Graphs): Use **OPTIC** or **SCAN** method:
   - S – **Subject/Scene**: What is happening? Who are the characters? (Caricatures = Exaggeration).
   - C – **Caption/Text**: Speech bubbles, labels, title. **Intertextuality** (references).

- A – **Action/Composition**: Foreground/Background, Size hierarchy, Lighting/Shading, Direction of gaze.
- N – **Nuance/Message**: What is the **Satirical Target**? What **Irony** is used? (Situational, Verbal, Dramatic). What is the **Call to Action / Critique**?

5. Graph/Chart Reading: Read **Axes, Units, Scale, Trends, Anomalies, Source**. Don't just describe; **interpret** ("The sharp dip in 2016 correlates with the onset of the Anglophone crisis…").

**WORKED EXAMPLE 24** **Critical Reasoning: Argument Deconstruction & Cartoon Analysis**

Task A (Argument Evaluation): Read the argument below. Identify the Main Conclusion, Two Premises, One Implicit Assumption (Warrant), and One Logical Fallacy.
"We must ban the use of smartphones in all secondary schools immediately. Last term, Lycée Bilingue de Yaoundé reported a 20% drop in Baccalaureate results. The Principal confirmed students were distracted by TikTok and WhatsApp during prep time. If we don't act now, our entire education system will collapse, and we will produce a generation of illiterates. Even the Minister of Secondary Education warned about 'digital distractions' recently. So, a total ban is the only way to save our children's future."
Task B (Visual Analysis): [Imagine a Cartoon]: A large, well-fed crocodile wearing a suit labelled "PUBLIC CONTRACTS BOARD" sits on a riverbank labelled "STATE RESOURCES". It holds a tiny fish labelled "SME CONTRACTS" in its mouth, looking greedy. A group of thin, ragged frogs labelled "YOUTH ENTREPRENEURS" watch hungrily from the water. Caption: "The Food Chain."
Analyse the cartoon using: Visual Metaphor, Caricature, Irony, and Satirical Target.

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Solution:
Task A: Argument Deconstruction

| Component | Identification |
|---|---|
| Main Conclusion | ”We must ban the use of smartphones in all secondary schools immediately.” (Signal: ”We must”, ”So” in last sentence). |
| Premise 1 (Evidence) | ”Last term, Lycée Bilingue de Yaoundé reported a 20% drop in Baccalaureate results.” (Specific data point). |
| Premise 2 (Evidence) | ”The Principal confirmed students were distracted by TikTok and WhatsApp during prep time.” (Testimony/Causal link claimed). |
| Implicit Assumption (Warrant) | ”Banning smartphones is the only effective way to remove distraction and improve results.” (Ignores: self-regulation, educational apps, teacher supervision, socio-economic factors for the drop). |
| Logical Fallacy 1 | Slippery Slope: ”If we don’t act now, our entire education system will collapse, and we will produce a generation of illiterates.” (Catastrophic chain reaction with no evidence). |
| Logical Fallacy 2 | Hasty Generalisation: One school (Lycée Bilingue Yaoundé), one term, one cause (phones) → Policy for ALL secondary schools nationwide. |
| Logical Fallacy 3 | False Dilemma: ”A total ban is the only way.” (Ignores regulated use, digital literacy curriculum, phone lockers, parental controls). |
| Logical Fallacy 4 | Appeal to Authority (Weak): ”Even the Minister warned...” (Vague reference, no policy citation). |

Evaluation Verdict: The argument is weak. It relies on a single, potentially confounded correlation (results drop ≠ solely phones), uses fear appeal (Slippery Slope), and proposes a draconian solution (Ban) without considering proportionality or educational benefits of tech.

Task B: Cartoon Analysis – ”The Food Chain”

| Element | Analysis |
|---|---|
| Visual Metaphor (The Core) | Predator-Prey / Food Chain. The natural order is inverted/perverted. The State (River) should nourish all citizens (Fauna), but the Public Contracts Board (Crocodile) monopolises the resources (Water/Fish). The SMEs/Youth (Frogs) are the natural prey but are starved. |
| Caricature / Exaggeration | Crocodile: "Well-fed", "Suit" (Bureaucratic corruption), "Greedy gaze", "Huge jaws" (Capacity to swallow massive contracts). Frogs: "Thin", "Ragged", "Hungry", "Numerous but powerless" (Vulnerability of youth/startups). Size Disparity: Visualises **Asymmetry of Power**. |
| Irony | Situational Irony: A "Public Contracts Board" (meant to distribute fairly) acts as a hoarder. Verbal Irony (Caption): "The Food Chain" implies a natural, inevitable law. The cartoonist argues it is a rigged, corrupt system, not nature. |
| Symbolism | Suit on Crocodile: Corruption wears a uniform of legitimacy. River "State Resources": Public wealth (Oil, Timber, Budget) flows through it. Tiny Fish "SME Contracts": Crumbs (10–15% quota?) swallowed whole by big players. |
| Satirical Target | Institutional Corruption & Nepotism in Public Procurement. Specifically: The failure of the **Public Contracts Code** (Cameroon) to enforce quotas for SMEs/Youth; "Big Men" (Crocodiles) capturing the allocation process. |
| Message / Call to Action | The system is structurally violent. The "Frogs" (Youth) cannot survive by waiting for crumbs. Need: Structural Reform (Transparent e-procurement, enforced quotas, protection for SMEs), not just "empowerment" rhetoric. |

Examiner's Tip: For cartoons, never just describe ("There is a crocodile"). Interpret ("The crocodile represents... symbolises... satirises..."). Link visual details (suit, size, label) directly to the **socio-political critique**.

## 24.2 Style and Rhetoric: Parallelism, Antithesis, and Repetition

METHOD **Style and Rhetoric: Parallelism, Antithesis, and Repetition**

1. **Parallelism** (Syntactic Balance): Repeating the same grammatical structure for coordinate ideas. Effect: Rhythm, clarity, memorability, equal weight. Types: **Anaphora** (start), **Epistrophe** (end), **Symploce** (both), **Isocolon** (equal length clauses). Example: "We shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds, we shall fight in the fields…" (Churchill).
2. **Antithesis** (Contrast in Parallel Structure): Juxtaposing opposing ideas in balanced phrases. Effect: Highlights conflict, sharpens definition, memorable. Formula: "Not X, but Y" / "X…; Y…". Example: "Ask not what your country can do for you – ask what you can do for your country" (JFK). **Chiasmus** (AB-BA): "Fair is foul, and foul is fair."
3. **Repetition** Strategies:
   - **Anaphora**: Start repetition (emphasis, build-up).
   - **Epistrophe**: End repetition (lingering emphasis).
   - **Anadiplosis**: End → Start ("Fear leads to anger. Anger leads to hate.").
   - **Polysyndeton**: Many conjunctions ("…and… and… and") = accumulation, weight.
   - **Asyndeton**: No conjunctions ("Veni, vidi, vici") = speed, urgency.
   - **Epizeuxis**: Immediate repetition ("Never, never, never").
4. Application in Writing: Use in speeches (oral impact), essays (thematic coherence), articles (persuasion). Avoid overuse (cliché, monotony).
5. Analysis Task: Identify the device → Quote the structure → Explain the rhetorical effect on the audience/reader (not just "it emphasises").

WORKED EXAMPLE 25 **Rhetorical Analysis of a Speech Excerpt**

Task: Analyse the rhetorical devices in this excerpt from a fictional presidential address. "We face a crisis of confidence. A crisis of character. A crisis of conscience. We did not build this nation on excuses. We built it on sweat. We built it on sacrifice. We built it on the unshakeable belief that tomorrow belongs to those who prepare for it today. The cynics say 'wait'. The corrupt say 'steal'. The cowards say 'flee'. But we say: 'Act. Build. Endure.' "

SOLUTION

Detailed Solution:

| Device | Instance | Rhetorical Effect |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Anaphora (x3) | ”A crisis of…” (3×) | Accumulation: Defines the crisis as multi-dimensional (systemic). Rhythm of inevitability. |
| Anaphora (x3) | ”We built it on…” (3×) | Foundation Myth: Reclaims agency/history. Concrete nouns (sweat, sacrifice, belief) vs abstract (”crisis”). |
| Antithesis (Triad) | ”Cynics… Corrupt… Cowards” vs ”We” | Moral Po- |

Synthesis: The speech moves from Diagnosis (Crisis anaphora) → Identity/Values (Building anaphora) → Rejection of Vice (Antithesis) → Call to Action (Asyndetic imperatives). The structure mirrors the argument: Past strength → Present choice → Future imperative.

## 24.3 Editing for Register, Tone, and Rhetorical Effectiveness

**METHOD** **Editing for Register, Tone, and Rhetorical Effectiveness**

1. Step 1: Audience & Purpose Audit: Who reads this? (Examiner, Minister, Peer, Public). What must it achieve? (Persuade, Inform, Record, Entertain). Every edit must serve this.
2. Step 2: Register Consistency Check: Scan for **register clashes**. Formal report with slang? Speech with academic jargon? Harmonise vocabulary, syntax, contraction use.
3. Step 3: Tone Calibration: **Tone** = Attitude conveyed (Urgent? Conciliatory? Authoritative? Reflective?). Check: Modals (must vs should), Adverbials (unfortunately, significantly), Sentence length (short = urgency/punch; long = complexity/nuance).
4. Step 4: Rhetorical Audit:
   - Clarity: Are agents clear? (Passive hiding actor? "Mistakes were made" → "The Ministry made mistakes").
   - Cohesion: Connectives (however, therefore, consequently) used accurately?
   - Emphasis: Key info at **end-focus** (end of sentence/paragraph)? Fronting for contrast?
   - Devices: Parallelism, Antithesis, Rule of Three used strategically?
5. Step 5: Concision & Precision (The "Red Pen"):
   - Delete **redundancies**: "free gift", "past history", "future plans".
   - Replace **nominalisations** with verbs where stronger: "make a decision" → "decide"; "conduct an investigation" → "investigate".
   - Replace **weak verbs + adverbs** with **strong verbs**: "walked quickly" → "hurried/rushed"; "said angrily" → "snapped".
   - Check **prepositional pile-ups**: "The decision of the committee regarding the matter of the budget" → "The committee's budget decision".
6. Step 6: Proofreading (SPAG): Spelling, Punctuation, Agreement, Tense consistency, Articles, Prepositions.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 26** **Editing a Student Essay Paragraph**

Task: Edit the following paragraph for formal register, concision, and rhetorical force. Original: "In my opinion, I think that the government really needs to do something about corruption because it is very bad for the country. Corruption makes the poor people suffer more and the rich people get richer. There are many examples of this, like when officials take bribes. This is not fair and it makes people lose trust in the government. So, the government should make strong laws and enforce them strictly. Also they should teach people about integrity in schools."

**SOLUTION**

Edited Version:

> Corruption critically undermines national development, disproportionately burdening the poor while entrenching elite privilege. Systemic bribery erodes public trust and distorts resource allocation. Addressing this requires a dual strategy: rigorous enforcement of anti-corruption legislation and the institutionalisation of integrity education within the national curriculum.

Edits Annotated:

- Register: "In my opinion I think" (Informal hedge) → Deleted (Impersonal authority).
- Precision: "really needs to do something" → "critically undermines", "requires a dual strategy".
- Concision: "makes the poor people suffer more and the rich people get richer" → "disproportionately burdening the poor while entrenching elite privilege".
- Nominalisation/Verb Strength: "take bribes" → "Systemic bribery"; "make strong laws and enforce them" → "rigorous enforcement of... legislation".
- Structure: 7 sentences → 3 sentences. **Parallelism** in final sentence ("rigorous enforcement... and... institutionalisation").

## 24.4 Euphemisms, Clichés, and Jargon

**METHOD** **Euphemisms, Clichés, and Jargon: Recognising and Using Appropriately**

1. **Euphemism**: Mild/indirect term substituting for harsh/blunt one. Function: Politeness, face-saving, taboo avoidance, manipulation (doublespeak).

| Direct/Blunt | Polite Euphemism | Doublespeak (Manipulative) |
|---|---|---|
| Died | Passed away, departed | Negative patient outcome |
| Fired/Laid off | Let go, made redundant | Workforce optimisation, rightsizing |
| Poor | Economically disadvantaged | Under-resourced |
| Old | Senior citizen, elderly | Chronologically gifted |
| Toilet | Restroom, washroom, facilities | Sanitation station |
| War/Civilian deaths | Conflict, collateral damage | Kinetic military action |

2. **Cliché**: Overused phrase losing original impact. Avoid in formal writing. Examples: "At the end of the day", "Think outside the box", "Low-hanging fruit", "Game changer", "In this day and age", "Last but not least". Replace with precise language.
3. **Jargon**: Specialised vocabulary of a profession/group. Appropriate: Expert-to-expert communication (precision, efficiency). Inappropriate: Communicating with lay audience (exclusion, obscurantism). Skill: **Code-switching** / **Plain English translation**.
4. Exam Application: Identify euphemism in a text → Explain why used (politeness vs deception). Identify cliché → Rewrite freshly. Identify jargon → Explain/translate for context.

EXEMPLE **Euphemism in Cameroonian Public Discourse**

- "Ghost workers" → Euphemism for fraudulent payroll entries.
- "Financial engineering" → Often euphemism for misappropriation/creative accounting.
- "Administrative bottleneck" → Euphemism for bureaucratic corruption/delay.
- "Restructuring" → Euphemism for mass layoffs.
- "Stakeholder engagement" → Can be euphemism for token consultation.

Critical Skill: Distinguish social lubrication ("passed away") from obfuscation ("collateral damage" for dead civilians).

# 25 RESPONDING TO VISUAL STIMULI

## 25.1 Analysing Cartoons, Advertisements, and Graphs

METHOD **Responding to Visual Stimuli: Cartoons, Advertisements, and Graphs**

1. General Framework (SCAN):
   - S – Subject/Source: What is it? Who made it? When? Context?
   - C – Composition/Content: Visual elements (colour, layout, font, images, people, objects). **Foreground vs Background**. **Size/Scale** = Importance/Power.
   - A – Argument/Aim: What is the **message**? **Persuasive goal**? (Sell, Satirise, Inform, Provoke).
   - N – Nuance/Technique: **Symbolism**, **Metaphor**, **Irony**, **Caricature**, **Intertextuality**, **Colour psychology**, **Gaze vectors**.
2. Cartoon Analysis Specifics:
   - Caricature: Exaggerated features = symbolic traits (big belly = greed, pinhead = stupidity).
   - Labels/Speech Bubbles: Anchor meaning. Irony often in gap between label and image.
   - Visual Metaphor: "The Food Chain" (Crocodile = Corrupt Official).
   - Juxtaposition: Contrast (Luxury vs Poverty) = Social critique.
3. Advertisement Analysis (AIDA + Semiotics):
   - AIDA: **Attention** (Hook), **Interest** (Benefits), **Desire** (Emotion/Lifestyle), **Action** (Call to Action).
   - Semiotics: **Signifier** (Image/Word) → **Signified** (Concept). **Denotation** (Literal) vs **Connotation** (Cultural association). **Myth** (Barthes): Naturalised cultural value (e.g., "Car = Freedom").
   - Language: Imperatives, superlatives, weasel words ("virtually spotless"), pseudo-scientific jargon.
4. Graph/Chart Analysis:
   - Read Metadata: Title, Axes labels, Units, Scale (linear/log), Source, Date.
   - Identify: Trend (up/down/fluctuate), Peak/Trough, Anomalies, Comparisons.
   - Write: Overview sentence → Key features with data → Interpretation/Implication. Use language of change: rose sharply, plateaued, plummeted, fluctuated wildly, witnessed a twofold increase.

**WORKED EXAMPLE 27** **Visual Stimulus: Advertisement Analysis**

Task: Analyse the following print ad description.
[Visual: A sleek, silver 4×4 SUV parked on a pristine, empty beach at sunset. No roads visible. Driver: A lone, well-dressed man looking at horizon. Text: "THE NEW TERRA X. UNLEASH YOUR TERRITORY. 0–100 in 6.2s. 5-Year Warranty. Starting 45M FCFA." Logo: Terra Motors.]

**SOLUTION**

Detailed Analysis:
1. Composition & Colour:

- Setting: Beach/Sunset = **Freedom, Escape, Nature, Limitlessness**. "No roads" = Vehicle creates its own path.
- Colour Palette: Silver (Modernity, Technology, Premium) + Gold/Orange Sunset (Warmth, Success, "Golden Hour"). High contrast = Visual pop.
- Figure: Lone male, tailored casual wear = **Autonomy, Mastery, Affluence**. Gaze to horizon = **Vision, Future**.

2. Semiotics (Denotation → Connotation):

- Signifier: 4×4 on sand. Signified: Capability, Dominance over nature.
- Signifier: "Unleash". Signified: Pent-up power, animalistic freedom, breaking constraints.
- Myth Activated: The Frontier Myth. The city is a cage; the vehicle is the key to "authentic" selfhood.

3. Linguistic/Rhetorical Devices:

- Imperative: "Unleash" (Command/Invitation).
- Metaphor: "Your Territory" (Possession, Identity, Masculine domain).
- Technical Specs (Logos): "0–100 in 6.2s" (Performance credibility). "5-Year Warranty" (Risk reduction/Trust).
- Price Anchor: "Starting 45M" (Positions as aspirational luxury; "Starting" implies higher trims).

4. Target Audience & Ideology:

- Demographic: Affluent urban males (35–55), professionals/entrepreneurs.
- Psychographic: "Achievers", "Explorers" (VALS framework). Desire for status + escape.
- Ideology: Consumption = Liberation. Nature as playground for the wealthy. Individualism.

5. Critical Evaluation: The ad sells a fantasy (empty beach, solo conquest) incompatible with the reality of urban Cameroonian driving (traffic, potholes, fuel queues). It commodifies "freedom".

# 26 MOCK EXAMINATIONS AND FINAL EXAMINATION TECHNIQUES

## 26.1 Paper 1 Mock Examination: Full Paper Practice

METHOD **Paper 1 (Essay/Composition) – 3 Hours Strategy**

1. Question Selection (5 mins): Read all options. Choose the genre you control best (Discursive, Narrative, Descriptive, Argumentative, Letter, Speech, Report, Article). Avoid topics where you lack content/vocabulary.
2. Planning (15–20 mins): Mind-map → Thesis/Controlling Idea → Structure Outline (Paragraph topics, key vocab, rhetorical devices). Word Count Target: 500–600 words (Quality ≫ Quantity).
3. Writing (2 hrs 15 mins):
   - Register Check: Formal (Essay/Report/Letter) vs Semi-formal (Article/Speech) vs Informal (Friendly Letter/Narrative voice).
   - Paragraphing: TiPToP (Time, Place, Topic, Person change = New paragraph). Topic sentences essential.
   - Vocabulary: Precision > "Big words". Collocations (make a decision → reach a decision). Idioms (used naturally).
   - Sentence Variety: Simple (punch), Compound (flow), Complex (subordination), Fronted adverbials, Inversion (Rarely have I seen...), Conditionals.
4. Proofreading (15–20 mins): Systematic Passes:
   (a) SPAG: Spelling (homophones: their/there, practice/practise), Punctuation (comma splices, apostrophes), Grammar (S-V agreement, tense consistency, articles, prepositions).
   (b) Register/Tone: Consistent? Appropriate?
   (c) Task Fulfilment: Answered the specific prompt? Format correct (addresses, dates, signatures for letters)?
   (d) Word Count: Check (don't obsess, but be aware).

KEY POINTS **Paper 1: Common Genre Templates**

- Formal Letter: Sender Address → Date → Recipient Address → Salutation → Subject Line → Body (Ref → Details → Action) → Complimentary Close → Signature/Name.
- Speech: Salutation (Protocol order) → Hook → Thesis → Signposted Body → Rhetorical Devices (Rule of 3, Rhetorical Q, Direct Address) → Call to Action → Closing Thanks.
- Report: Title → To/From/Date/Subject → Introduction (Terms of Reference) → Procedure/Findings (Headings) → Conclusions → Recommendations (Numbered, Imperative).
- Article: Catchy Headline → Byline → Lead → Body (Subheadings) → Conclusion (Summary/Opinion/Future look).

## 26.2 Paper 2 Mock Examination: Comprehension & Summary

METHOD **Paper 2 (Comprehension & Summary) – 2 Hours 30 Mins Strategy**

1. Section A: Comprehension (approx. 1 hr 30 mins)
   - Read Questions FIRST (2 mins). Underline keywords (command words: state, explain, suggest, infer, in your own words).
   - Scan Text for keywords/locations. Read relevant sections closely.
   - Answering Rules:
     - Own Words (OW): No lifting chunks > 3–4 words. Paraphrase vocabulary/structure. If "Quote": Copy exact words with quotation marks.
     - Inference ("Suggests/Implies"): Answer not in text. Combine text evidence + logic. "The writer implies X because the text says Y."
     - Vocab in Context: Give ONE word/phrase fitting the specific context. Check part of speech.
     - Grammar Transformation: Follow instruction exactly ("Begin with...", "Rewrite using...", "Change to passive").
2. Section B: Summary (approx. 1 hr)
   - Read Summary Question: Identify specific focus (e.g., "Causes of...", "Effects on...", "Solutions to..."). Ignore irrelevant paragraphs.
   - Method:

     (a) Highlight/Underline relevant points in text (Number them 1, 2, 3...).

(b) Group/Combine similar points. Generalise (Nominalisation).

(c) Draft in Own Words (No quotes, no examples, no "The writer says", no intro/conclusion).

(d) Count Words. Edit to limit (usually 130–150). Concision via ellipsis, substitution, complex sentences.

(e) Fair Copy: Clean, single paragraph (usually), accurate grammar/spelling.

WORKED EXAMPLE 28 **Mock Paper 2: Summary Writing Practice**

Task: Read the passage below (approx. 350 words) on "The Impact of Social Media on Cameroonian Youth". Write a summary of the negative effects on academic performance and mental health, as outlined in the passage. Length: Not more than 130 words. Use your own words as far as possible.
[Passage Omitted for Brevity – Assume a standard GCE passage with points: 1. Addiction/Time theft. 2. Distraction in class (phones). 3. Sleep deprivation (blue light/FOMO). 4. Cyberbullying/Anxiety. 5. Plagiarism/Copy-paste culture. 6. Unrealistic body image/Depression. 7. Fake news/Distraction from civic duty. 8. Positive: Access to info/Networking (IGNORE – not asked).]

SOLUTION

Detailed Solution:
Step 1: Highlight & Number Relevant Points (Negative Effects Only) 1. Addiction/Time Displacement: Compulsive checking steals study hours. 2. Classroom Distraction: Phones used during lectures/prep → fragmented attention. 3. Sleep Deprivation: Late-night scrolling (FOMO), blue light disrupts melatonin → fatigue, poor concentration. 4. Cyberbullying/Psychological Harm: Harassment, trolling → anxiety, low self-esteem, withdrawal. 5. Academic Dishonesty: Copy-paste assignments, buying essays → erodes critical thinking, research skills. 6. Body Image Issues: Curated perfection on Instagram/TikTok → body dysmorphia, eating disorders, depression. 7. Misinformation/Disengagement: Fake news consumption → distorted worldview, apathy toward real civic engagement.
Step 2: Drafting – Combining & Nominalising (Target ≈ 120 words) Draft 1: Social media addiction displaces study time as youths compulsively check feeds. In classrooms, phones fragment attention during lessons. Late-night usage, driven by fear of missing out and blue light exposure, causes sleep deprivation, leading to fatigue and poor concentration. Cyberbullying and trolling inflict psychological harm, triggering anxiety and low self-esteem. Academic integrity suffers through rampant plagiarism and purchased essays, undermining critical thinking. Furthermore, exposure to curated, unrealistic body images fosters body dysmorphia and depression. Finally, the spread of misinformation distorts worldviews and encourages civic apathy among the youth. (98 words) – Good, concise.

Step 3: Final Polish (Checking Flow, Register, Word Count) Final Version (102 words):

> Social media addiction displaces study time through compulsive usage. In classrooms, smartphones fragment learners' attention. Nocturnal scrolling, fuelled by fear of missing out and blue-light exposure, induces sleep deprivation, resulting in fatigue and diminished concentration. Cyberbullying inflicts psychological trauma, manifesting as anxiety and plummeting self-esteem. Academic integrity is eroded by pervasive plagiarism and contract cheating, stunting critical research skills. Additionally, algorithmically curated perfectionism triggers body dysmorphia and depressive episodes. Finally, viral misinformation warps political awareness, breeding civic disengagement. Collectively, these dynamics undermine both scholastic achievement and mental well-being.

Examiner's Marking Points (Simulated):

- Content (8 pts): All 7 points covered clearly. (8/8)
- Language (7 pts): Own words ("displaces", "fragments", "induces", "eroded", "stunting", "triggers", "breeding"). Complex sentences. Formal register. No lifting. (7/7)
- Length: 102 words (Well within 130 limit). (Pass)
- Total: 15/15.

Key Success Factors: Selection (ignored positive points), Synthesis (combined sleep/FOMO/blue light), Nominalisation ("Addiction", "Deprivation", "Integrity", "Perfectionism", "Disengagement"), Connectors ("Furthermore", "Additionally", "Finally", "Collectively").

## 26.3 Paper 3 Mock Examination: Oral/Aural

METHOD **Paper 3 (Oral/Aural) – Listening & Speaking Strategy**

1. Listening Section (approx. 45 mins):
   - Pre-Listening (Crucial): Read all questions. Predict answer type (Name? Number? Date? Reason? Opinion?). Predict vocabulary (synonyms/antonyms).
   - First Listen: Global understanding. Note keywords only (nouns, verbs, numbers, names). Use abbreviations/symbols. Don't write sentences.
   - Second Listen: Fill gaps. Check predictions. Focus on **signpost language** ("Firstly", "However", "The main reason", "In conclusion", "On the other hand").
   - Transfer: Write answers clearly in answer booklet. Spelling matters (especially

names, technical terms). Guess if unsure (no negative marking).

2. Speaking Section (Conversation/Presentation – approx. 15 mins):
   - Presentation (if applicable): **Structure:** Intro (Topic, Thesis, Outline) → Body (2–3 Main Points, Evidence/Examples) → Conclusion (Summary, Final Thought). Time management (e.g., 3–5 mins). Cue cards (Keywords only, not script).
   - Conversation/Interaction: **Listen actively**. **Respond relevantly**. **Expand** (Don't give 1-word answers). **Ask questions** (Shows initiative). **Repair** communication breakdowns ("Could you repeat?", "Do you mean...?").
   - Pronunciation Focus: **Intonation** (Fall = statement/certainty; Rise = question/uncertainty; Fall-Rise = reservation/politeness). **Word/Sentence Stress** (Content words). **Weak Forms** (Lesson 46). **Problem Sounds** (/θ, ð, ʃ, ʒ/ vs /i:/, /ʊ/ vs /u:/).
   - Vocabulary/Grammar Range: Use **topic-specific lexis**, **phrasal verbs**, **idioms** (naturally), **complex sentences** (conditionals, relative clauses, passive), **modals** (nuance).

KEY POINTS **Paper 3: Examiner's Checklist for Speaking**

- Fluency: Speed, flow, lack of long pauses (hesitation markers "er, well, you know" are fine if natural).
- Coherence: Logical sequencing, connectives (discourse markers).
- Lexical Resource: Range, precision, collocation, idiomaticity.
- Grammatical Range & Accuracy: Variety of structures, error frequency (slips vs systematic).
- Pronunciation: Intelligibility, stress, intonation, individual sounds.
- Interaction: Turn-taking, responding, initiating, developing topics.

# 27 WRITER'S CRAFT: LANGUAGE, FORM, AND STRUCTURE ACROSS TEXTS

## 27.1 Synthesising Language, Form, and Structure

METHOD **Writer's Craft: Language, Form, and Structure Across Texts**

1. The Craft Triangle: **Language** (Diction, Imagery, Figures, Syntax, Sound) + **Form** (Genre, Stanza, Act, Narrative Perspective) + **Structure** (Chronology, Juxtaposition, Repetition, Framing, Climax) = **Meaning/Effect**.
2. Analysis Protocol (for any text):
   (a) What? (Content/Theme/Subject).
   (b) How? (Devices/Techniques – Language, Form, Structure).
   (c) Why? (Effect/Purpose/Reader Response – The "So What?").
   (d) Context? (Author, Era, Genre conventions, Intertextuality).
3. Key Analytical Verbs (Replace "Shows"): Conveys, evokes, underscores, juxtaposes, subverts, satirises, illuminates, interrogates, destabilises, affirms, negotiates, constructs, deconstructs, mirrors, enacts.
4. Comparative Craft (Paper 1 Unseen/Comparative): Structure by Method or Theme. "Both writers use first-person narration to… However, Writer A uses stream of consciousness (structure) to convey fragmentation, while Writer B uses retrospective reflection (structure) to convey wisdom."
5. Exam Essay Structure: Intro (Thesis linking Craft → Meaning) → Body Paragraphs (Integrated Language+Form+Structure analysis) → Conclusion (Synthesis of Craft's role in Theme).

EXEMPLE **Craft Analysis Checklist for Prescribed Texts**

Prose (Novel/Short Story):

- Narrative Voice (1st/3rd, Reliable/Unreliable, Focalisation).
- Chronology (Linear, Circular, Flashback, In media res).
- Characterisation (Direct/Indirect, Foil, Development).
- Setting as Symbol / Pathetic Fallacy.
- Dialogue vs Narrative balance.
- Opening/Ending symmetry (Circular structure?).

Drama:

- Stage Directions (Setting, Atmosphere, Subtext).
- Dramatic Irony (Audience knows > Character).

- Soliloquy/Aside (Interiority made public).
- Entrances/Exits (Pacing, Tension).
- Subtext (What is not said).
- Acts/Scenes structure (Rising action, Climax, Denouement).

Poetry:

- Form (Sonnet, Villanelle, Free Verse, Ode, Ballad) → Why this constraint?
- Stanza logic (Argument shifts, Perspective shifts).
- Lineation (Enjambment = flow/surprise; Caesura = pause/emphasis; End-stopped = finality).
- Metre/Rhythm (Iambic = heartbeat/speech; Trochaic = urgency; Sprung rhythm).
- Sound patterning (Alliteration, Assonance, Consonance, Rhyme scheme) → Semantic links.
- Title significance.

# 28 FINAL REVIEW: ALL PRESCRIBED TEXTS AND EXAMINATION TECHNIQUES

## 28.1 Comprehensive Final Review Strategy

METHOD **Final Review: All Prescribed Texts and Examination Techniques**

1. Text Mastery Grid: Create a one-page summary per prescribed text (Prose, Drama, 18 Poems).

| Category | Content |
|---|---|
| Core Themes | 3–4 central themes with key evidence. |
| Characters/Voices | Protagonist, Antagonist, Foils, Persona – Arc/Function. |
| Craft Signatures | 3–5 distinctive techniques (e.g., "Oyono: Free Indirect Style, Irony, Oral Proverbs"). |
| Key Quotations | 5–7 versatile quotes (Theme + Technique + Context). |
| Context Links | Historical, Biographical, Cameroonian relevance. |
| Past Paper Questions | List recent GCE questions on this text. |

2. Thematic Cross-Text Mapping: Prepare Comparative Thesis Statements for major themes across genres:
   - Colonialism/Neocolonialism: Prose (Oyono/Beti) vs Drama (Sowande) vs Poetry (Visser/Saro-Wiwa).
   - Corruption/Power: Drama vs Poetry vs Prose.
   - Identity/Diaspora: Poetry (Visser) vs Prose (Adichie/Selin – if applicable).
   - Gender/Tradition: Drama vs Prose.
   - Oral Tradition/Modernity: All genres.
3. Exam Technique Drills (Final Week):
   - Timed Plans: 5 mins → Thesis + 4 Points + Quotes (Paper 1 & 2 Essay).
   - Timed Introductions: 10 mins → Perfect Hook + Context + Thesis.
   - Annotation Practice: 10 mins → Unseen Poem/Prose → 10 Devices + Effects.
   - Grammar Blitz: 20 mins → Modal transformations, Reported speech, Conditionals, Passive, Ellipsis.
   - Phonology Drill: Transcribe 3 sentences → Weak forms, Linking, Stress, Tone units.
4. Mental & Physical Preparation:
   - Sleep: 7–8 hours (consolidates memory).
   - Hydration/Nutrition: Brain fuel.
   - Materials: Pens (blue/black), HB pencils, eraser, sharpener, Watch, ID/Admission slip.
   - Ritual: Prayer/Meditation/Deep breathing before entry. Positive Visualisation.

KEY POINTS **GCE Advanced Level English: Final Commandments**

- Answer the Question. (RTQ – Read The Question). Circle command words.
- Plan Before Writing. Even in exam pressure. 5 mins saves 30 mins of waffle.
- Quote → Analyse → Evaluate. Never "quote dump". Every quote earns its keep.
- Register is King. Wrong register = Cap on Content/Expression marks.
- Structure is Queen. Paragraphs = Units of Thought. Topic Sentences = Signposts.
- Context is the Crown. Literature exists in time/place. Show you know the world of the text.

- Comparison is the Ace. Integrate. Point-by-point. "While... Conversely..."
- Proofread Backwards. Last sentence to first. Catches spelling/grammar the brain auto-corrects forward.
- Time is the Dealer. Wear a watch. Move on when time's up. Unfinished answer > Perfect half-answer.
- You Are Prepared. Trust the work. Breathe. Write with authority.

DID YOU KNOW? **The Cameroonian Context in GCE English**

The GCE Advanced Level English Language syllabus (Anglophone sub-system) uniquely positions you to analyse language and literature through the lens of Cameroonian reality. Examiners reward:

- Authentic Examples: Referencing buyam-sellam, bush taxi, fon, njangi, GCE Board, MINESUP, Anglophone Crisis (sensitively), TVET, National Dialogue.
- Code-Switching Awareness: Analysing how Pidgin, Standard English, French, and Indigenous languages interact in texts and society.
- Post-Colonial Lens: Reading Kipling, Shakespeare, or African writers with an awareness of the power dynamics of English in Cameroon.
- Oral Tradition as Theory: Not just "culture" but a literary methodology (Call-response, Griot, Proverb, Drum language) that shapes written literature.

Your "Cameroonian English" is a legitimate variety (SCamE). Master the Standard for the exam, but value your linguistic repertoire. That dual competence is the educated Cameroonian identity.

# 29 EXERCISES

## 29.1 I check my knowledge

**EXERCISE 11** **MCQ: Register, Rhetoric and Connected Speech**

Choose the best answer (A, B, C or D) for each item.

1. Which of the following is an example of a weak form in connected English speech?
   (a) "can" pronounced with a full, strong vowel in "I can go"
   (b) "can" pronounced with a reduced "uh" vowel (schwa) in "I can go"
   (c) "must" pronounced with a fully released final /t/ in every context
   (d) "and" pronounced in its full strong form in "bread and butter"
2. In a discursive essay, the writer should:
   (a) defend only one viewpoint from the first paragraph
   (b) explore at least two perspectives before reaching a reasoned conclusion
   (c) avoid using linking words in order to sound objective
   (d) use informal register throughout
3. "The land is sick; the land is bleeding" is an example of:
   (a) euphemism
   (b) parallelism and metaphor
   (c) jargon
   (d) ellipsis
4. The inverted pyramid structure of a news report requires that:
   (a) the least important details come first
   (b) the most newsworthy facts (who, what, where, when, why, how) come first
   (c) the headline appears at the end
   (d) quotations are forbidden
5. Which of the following is a euphemism?
   (a) "He died in agony."
   (b) "He passed away peacefully."

(c) "He kicked the bucket."

(d) "Dead bodies littered the street."

**EXERCISE 12** **True or False — Justify Your Answer**

Say whether each statement is true or false, and justify your answer in one or two sentences.

1. In minutes of a meeting, the writer should record every word spoken by each participant.
2. Ellipsis and substitution are cohesion devices used to avoid unnecessary repetition in writing.
3. The modal must in "She must be tired" expresses obligation.
4. A euphemism is a mild or indirect expression used in place of a harsh or offensive one.
5. In Kipling's If, the speaker addresses his daughter.

**EXERCISE 13** **Key Definitions**

Define each of the following terms in one clear sentence and give one example of each.

1. Register
2. Antithesis
3. Fallacy
4. Cliché
5. Weak form

**EXERCISE 14** **Quick Grammar Check**

Complete each sentence with the most appropriate advanced modal (must, can't, might, should, needn't, ought to, shall, may), then say whether it expresses certainty, obligation, permission or deduction.

1. Students …… wear the correct uniform; it is compulsory.
2. He hasn't arrived yet. He …… have missed the bus. (deduction)

3. You …… have brought an umbrella; it didn't rain after all.
4. Candidates …… not use dictionaries during the GCE examination.
5. The results …… be published next week, but I'm not sure.

## 29.2 I practise

**EXERCISE 15** **Register Transformation**

Below is an extract from a formal letter written by a student to the proprietor of a school.

> "I am writing to request permission to sit the examination at a later date, owing to a serious illness which rendered my attendance impossible."

1. Rewrite the extract in informal register, as if writing to a close friend.
2. Rewrite it in an even more formal register, as if addressing an official complaints board.
3. Justify each change you have made (vocabulary, contractions, sentence structure, tone).

**EXERCISE 16** **Ellipsis and Substitution Drill**

Rewrite each of the following sentences to make them more concise, using ellipsis or substitution. Underline the device you use.

1. Mary passed the examination and John passed the examination too.
2. "Will you attend the debate?" "I hope I will attend the debate."
3. The principal said the principal would close the school early because the principal had an urgent meeting.
4. If you want to apply for the scholarship, you can apply for the scholarship online.
5. I have never been to Bamenda, but my brother has been to Bamenda twice.

**EXERCISE 17** **Reconstructing Minutes**

The following dialogue took place during a staff meeting at Government High School Molyko. Reconstruct the minutes of the meeting, using the correct format (heading, at-

tendance, agenda items, decisions, adjournment).

> Principal: Good morning, colleagues. We are here to discuss the poor discipline in Form Five and the state of the school library.
> Mr Ebai: Concerning discipline, I suggest we reintroduce morning assembly inspections.
> Mrs Ngum: I agree. Also, the library needs new textbooks; many are outdated.
> Principal: Good. Mr Ebai, draft the inspection timetable. Mrs Ngum, prepare a list of books needed. We shall meet again next Friday at 10 a.m.

**EXERCISE 18** **Weak Forms and Rhythm**

Consider the sentence: "I should have told him that the books are on the table."

1. Transcribe the sentence as it would be pronounced in natural connected speech, marking the weak forms of should, have, him, that, the, are.
2. Mark the stressed syllables and divide the sentence into rhythm units.
3. Practise reading it aloud with natural English rhythm, then explain why weak forms are essential to English rhythm.

## 29.3 I prepare for the GCE

**EXERCISE 19** **Discursive Essay (GCE Paper 2 style) — 50 marks**

Write a discursive essay of 450–500 words on the following topic:

> "Social Media: A Tool for Education or a Distraction for Cameroonian Students?"

Your essay should:

1. present at least two contrasting perspectives, supported by relevant examples;
2. use appropriate discourse markers to signal contrast and balance;
3. end with a clear, well-justified personal conclusion;
4. demonstrate accurate grammar, varied sentence structures and formal register.

(50 marks)

**EXERCISE 20** **Comparative Poetry Essay (GCE Paper 3 style) — 25 marks**

Answer one of the following questions in an essay of about 400 words. Refer closely to the texts.

1. Compare the treatment of corruption in the poems Corruption and Power of Corruption, paying particular attention to imagery, tone and the poets' attitudes.
2. "Kipling's If offers timeless moral guidance." Discuss the moral lessons of the poem and assess their relevance to young Cameroonians today.

(25 marks)

**EXERCISE 21** **News Report and Critical Reasoning (GCE Paper 1/2 style) — 25 marks**

Part A (15 marks). Your school recently organised an inter-house science fair, during which a Form Six student presented a solar-powered water pump. Write a news report of about 250 words for a national newspaper. Your report must include:

1. a suitable headline;
2. a lead paragraph answering who, what, where, when, why and how;
3. the inverted pyramid structure and an objective, formal style;
4. at least one quotation (invented appropriately).

Part B (10 marks). Read the following claim: "Everybody in this town uses boda-bodas, so they must be the safest means of transport. Besides, my uncle, who has ridden one for years, says so." Identify the claim, name two fallacies it contains, and explain why the evidence offered is not credible.

# 30 SOLUTIONS TO THE EXERCISES

## 30.1 I check my knowledge

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 1 — MCQ: Register, Rhetoric and Connected Speech**

1. (b) In natural connected speech, function words such as can are reduced to their weak form (with a schwa /ə/) when unstressed; the strong form /kæn/ is reserved for emphasis, contrast, or final position.
2. (b) A discursive essay examines several sides of an issue before the writer reaches a balanced, justified conclusion. Defending one viewpoint from the start produces an argumentative essay, not a discursive one.
3. (b) The two clauses have identical grammatical structure (parallelism), and the land is presented as a suffering human body (metaphor/personification).
4. (b) The inverted pyramid places the essential facts (the 5 Ws and H) in the lead paragraph, followed by details of decreasing importance, so that an editor can cut from the bottom without losing the story.
5. (b) "Passed away" is a mild, indirect expression replacing the harsher "died". Option (c), "kicked the bucket", is informal slang, not a polite euphemism.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 2 — True or False — Justify Your Answer**

1. False. Minutes are a concise, objective summary of discussions, decisions and resolutions, not a verbatim transcript; only motions, decisions and assignments are recorded in detail.
2. True. Both devices create cohesion by avoiding repetition: ellipsis omits a recoverable element ("John passed and Mary did too"), while substitution replaces it ("Mary passed and John did so too").
3. False. Here must expresses a strong deduction (logical certainty), not obligation: the speaker concludes from evidence that she is tired. Obligation would be "She must rest."
4. True. For example, "to pass away" for "to die", or "to be retrenched" for "to be sacked"; euphemisms soften painful, embarrassing or offensive realities.
5. False. The speaker addresses his son: the poem ends "…you'll be a Man, my son!"

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 3 — Key Definitions**

1. Register: the level of formality and the choice of language appropriate to a particular situation, audience and purpose. Example: "I would be grateful if you could…" (formal) versus "Can you…?" (informal).
2. Antithesis: a rhetorical device in which two contrasting ideas are placed in balanced, parallel structures to sharpen the contrast. Example: "It was the best of times, it was the worst of times."
3. Fallacy: an error in reasoning that makes an argument invalid or unconvincing, even when it sounds persuasive. Example: "Everyone buys this phone, so it must be the best" (appeal to popularity/ argumentum ad populum).
4. Cliché: an overused expression that has lost its freshness and impact through repetition. Example: "at the end of the day", "last but not least".
5. Weak form: the reduced pronunciation of a function word (with a schwa or weakened vowel) when it is unstressed in connected speech. Example: of /əv/ in "a cup of tea".

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 4 — Quick Grammar Check: Advanced Modals**

1. must — obligation (a compulsory school rule imposed by an external authority).
2. must — deduction (the speaker draws a logical conclusion from the evidence of his absence).
3. needn't — absence of past necessity (the action was performed but turned out to be unnecessary). Note: didn't need to is ambiguous (may mean the action was not performed).
4. may — prohibition ("may not" = are not permitted to); must not is also acceptable and even stronger.
5. might / may — weak certainty or possibility (the speaker is unsure about the publication date).

## 30.2 I practise

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 5 — Register Transformation — Model Answer**

1. Informal: "Hi! Just to let you know — I couldn't write the exam because I fell seriously

ill, so I'm asking if I can take it later." (Contractions, phrasal verbs, direct question, friendly tone.)

2. More formal: "I hereby formally request that I be granted authorisation to sit the aforementioned examination at a rescheduled date, my attendance having been rendered impossible by a serious medical condition." (Passive constructions, nominalisations, legalistic vocabulary, no contractions, subjunctive that I be granted.)
3. Justification: the informal version uses contractions (couldn't, I'm), phrasal verbs (fell ill) and short, direct sentences addressed personally; the very formal version prefers passives, nominalisations (authorisation, condition), the subjunctive and an impersonal, deferential tone suited to an official body.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 6 — Ellipsis and Substitution Drill — Model Answers**

1. Mary passed the examination and John did too. (substitution with the auxiliary did)
2. "Will you attend the debate?" "I hope so." (substitution of the whole clause with so)
3. The principal said she would close the school early because she had an urgent meeting. (substitution with pronouns)
4. If you want to apply for the scholarship, you can do so online. (substitution with do so)
5. I have never been to Bamenda, but my brother has twice. (ellipsis of been to Bamenda after the auxiliary has)

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 7 — Reconstructing Minutes — Model Answer**

MINUTES OF A STAFF MEETING HELD AT GOVERNMENT HIGH SCHOOL MOLYKO
Date: (insert date) Time: morning Venue: Staff Room
Present: The Principal (Chairperson), Mr Ebai, Mrs Ngum, and other members of staff.
Agenda: (1) Discipline in Form Five; (2) The state of the school library.
1. Discipline in Form Five. The Principal expressed concern about poor discipline in Form Five. Mr Ebai proposed the reintroduction of morning assembly inspections, a proposal which Mrs Ngum supported. It was resolved that morning assembly inspections be reintroduced, and Mr Ebai was assigned to draft the inspection timetable.
2. The school library. Mrs Ngum observed that many library textbooks were outdated and that new ones were needed. It was resolved that Mrs Ngum prepare a list of the books required.
Adjournment: The meeting was adjourned to the following Friday at 10 a.m.
Secretary: …… Chairperson: ……

Examiner's expectations: a clear heading, attendance list, numbered agenda items, reported speech (no direct quotations), impersonal and past-tense narration, explicit resolutions and assignments, and a closing adjournment note with signatures.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 8 — Weak Forms and Rhythm — Guidance**

1. In natural speech: should and have are reduced ("should've" /ʃʃədəv/ with a schwa), him loses its /h/ and carries a weak vowel /ɪm/, and that, the and are are all pronounced with a schwa /ðət/, /ðə/, /ə/.
2. The stressed syllables fall on the content words: TOLD, BOOKS, TAble (and possibly ON). Rhythm units: I should have | TOLD him | that the BOOKS are | ON the TAble.
3. English is a stress-timed language: stressed syllables occur at roughly regular intervals, and the unstressed function words between them are compressed into weak forms. Without weak forms, speech sounds mechanical and unnatural, and listeners may fail to recognise the characteristic rhythm of English — which is why mastering weak forms improves both pronunciation and listening comprehension.

## 30.3 I prepare for the GCE

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 9 — Discursive Essay — Marking Guide and Model Outline**

Introduction: define social media and state the debate; announce a balanced treatment of both sides.
Perspective 1 — A tool for education: access to information, online tutorials, study groups on WhatsApp, exposure to English, e-learning during school disruptions; concrete examples from Cameroonian students preparing for the GCE.
Perspective 2 — A distraction: time wasted on entertainment, reduced concentration, examination malpractice, exposure to misinformation and cyberbullying.
Discourse markers expected: on the one hand / on the other hand, however, whereas, admittedly, nevertheless, it could be argued that, in conclusion.
Conclusion: a justified personal stance, e.g. social media is beneficial when used with discipline and guidance from parents and teachers.
Indicative mark scheme (50 marks): content and balanced treatment of both perspectives (15), organisation and cohesion (15), accuracy of grammar and range of vocabulary (10), register and style (10). The examiner expects formal register, no contractions, varied sentence structures, and a conclusion that clearly flows from the arguments presented rather than introducing new points.

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 10 — Comparative Poetry Essay — Marking Guide**

Question 1: candidates should identify each poet's central image of corruption (disease, decay, chains, greed), compare the tones (anger, lament, satire, warning), and contrast the poets' attitudes (denunciation, resignation, call to resistance), supporting every point with brief, well-integrated quotations. A mere summary of each poem in turn, without genuine comparison, earns little credit.

Question 2: candidates should discuss the moral qualities Kipling recommends — self-confidence without arrogance, patience, honesty, resilience in triumph and disaster, humility before crowds and kings — and evaluate their relevance to Cameroonian youths facing examination pressure, unemployment and moral compromise. Personal judgement must remain anchored in the text.

Indicative mark scheme (25 marks): knowledge of the poems and relevance to the question (10), quality of comparison or argument (8), use of textual evidence (4), expression and organisation (3).

**SOLUTION** **Exercise 11 — News Report and Critical Reasoning — Marking Guide and Model Answers**

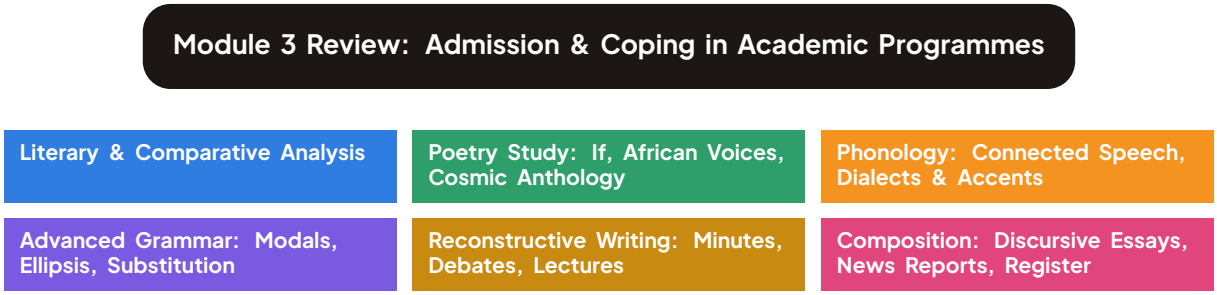
Part A (15 marks). Model headline: "Form Six Student Unveils Solar-Powered Water Pump at School Science Fair".

Model lead: "A Form Six student of Government High School … presented a solar-powered water pump at the school's annual inter-house science fair held on campus last Friday, an innovation designed to provide affordable water to rural communities."

The body should then give supporting details (how the pump works, its cost, reactions of visitors), at least one quotation (e.g. the principal: "This invention proves that our students can solve local problems with science."), and background information last. Indicative mark scheme: headline and lead answering the 5 Ws and H (5), inverted pyramid structure (4), objectivity and formal register (3), quotation and language accuracy (3). The examiner penalises personal opinions, emotional vocabulary and chronological storytelling, which belong to narrative, not news, writing.

Part B (10 marks). Claim: boda-bodas are the safest means of transport. Fallacies: (1) appeal to popularity (argumentum ad populum) — the fact that many people use them does not prove they are safe; (2) appeal to unqualified authority / anecdotal evidence — the uncle's personal experience is a single, unverified testimony, not statistical proof. The evidence is not credible because popularity is not evidence of safety, and one person's experience cannot be generalised to all riders; credible evidence would require accident statistics or expert safety studies.

# 31 SUMMARY SHEET




Mind map of the Module Three review chapter.

**FICHE BILAN** **L'essentiel à connaître pour l'examen**

1. Literary and comparative analysis.

- **Theme**: the central idea a text explores (corruption, duty, identity); **style**: the writer's distinctive use of language, form and structure.
- Comparative method: identify a common theme, then compare treatment, tone, imagery, structure and context across prose, drama and poetry. Use linking frames: whereas, similarly, in contrast to, both texts suggest that…
- The **writer's craft** = language (diction, imagery), form (sonnet, soliloquy, chapter) and structure (stanza order, climax, narrative voice).

2. Poetry essentials.

- If (Kipling): conditional structure, imperative tone, moral themes of self-mastery, patience, humility, integrity; the final reward is maturity ("you'll be a Man").
- African poems (Corruption, Power of Corruption, I Am An African): themes of social decay, moral responsibility, pride in identity; note personification, repetition, direct address and proverbial diction.
- For the Cosmic Anthology review: for each of the 18 poems know the subject, theme, tone, three key devices, and two quotable lines.

3. Phonology.

- **Weak forms**: function words (of, to, and, can, a) are reduced in connected speech (can → /k@n/); **rhythm**: English is stress-timed — content words carry the beat.
- **Dialect** = variation in grammar and vocabulary; **accent** = variation in pronunciation only. Respect all varieties; use Standard English in examinations.

4. Advanced grammar.

- Modals of certainty: must/can't be (strong), may/might/could be (weak); obligation: must, have to, should, ought to; permission: may, can, could. Past speculation: must have + past participle.
- **Ellipsis**: omitting recoverable words (She sings and dances → She sings and dances well); **substitution**: replacing with one, do, so, it to avoid repetition and achieve conciseness.

5. Reconstructive writing.
   - Minutes: heading (body, date, venue), attendance, agenda items, decisions, action points, adjournment; past tense, reported speech, impersonal tone.
   - Debates/talks/lectures: reconstruct from notes using reported speech, logical connectors, and clear paragraphing; keep the speaker's argument, not your opinion.
6. Composition and register.
   - **Discursive essay**: balanced exploration of multiple perspectives — introduction, arguments for, arguments against, personal justified conclusion.
   - News report: headline, byline, lead paragraph (who, what, where, when, why), body in descending importance; objective, factual, third person.
   - **Register**: formal (official letters, reports), neutral, informal (friendly letters); edit for tone, and use euphemisms (tact), avoid clichés and unnecessary jargon.
   - **Rhetoric**: parallelism (balanced structures), antithesis (opposing ideas), repetition (emphasis) — identify their effect, not just their presence.
   - Visual stimuli: describe the cartoon/advert/graph objectively, interpret the message, then evaluate its effectiveness.
7. Common mistakes to avoid.
   - Retelling the plot instead of analysing the writer's methods.
   - Using informal register in reports and minutes; mixing tenses in reported speech.
   - Quoting without commenting; naming devices without explaining their effect.
   - Weak-form confusion in listening; confusing mustn't (prohibition) with don't have to (no obligation).
8. GCE examination tips.
   - Paper 1: manage time per section; answer the question set, underline key instruction words.
   - Paper 2: plan essays for 5 minutes; one idea per paragraph with a topic sentence.
   - Paper 3: support every literary point with a short, relevant quotation.
   - In mocks, simulate real conditions; afterwards, correct every error and rewrite one weak answer.

**Signed • OnBuch+**
ONBUCH+ TEACHING TEAM
FOLLOWS THE OFFICIAL MINESEC SYLLABUS

OnBuch+